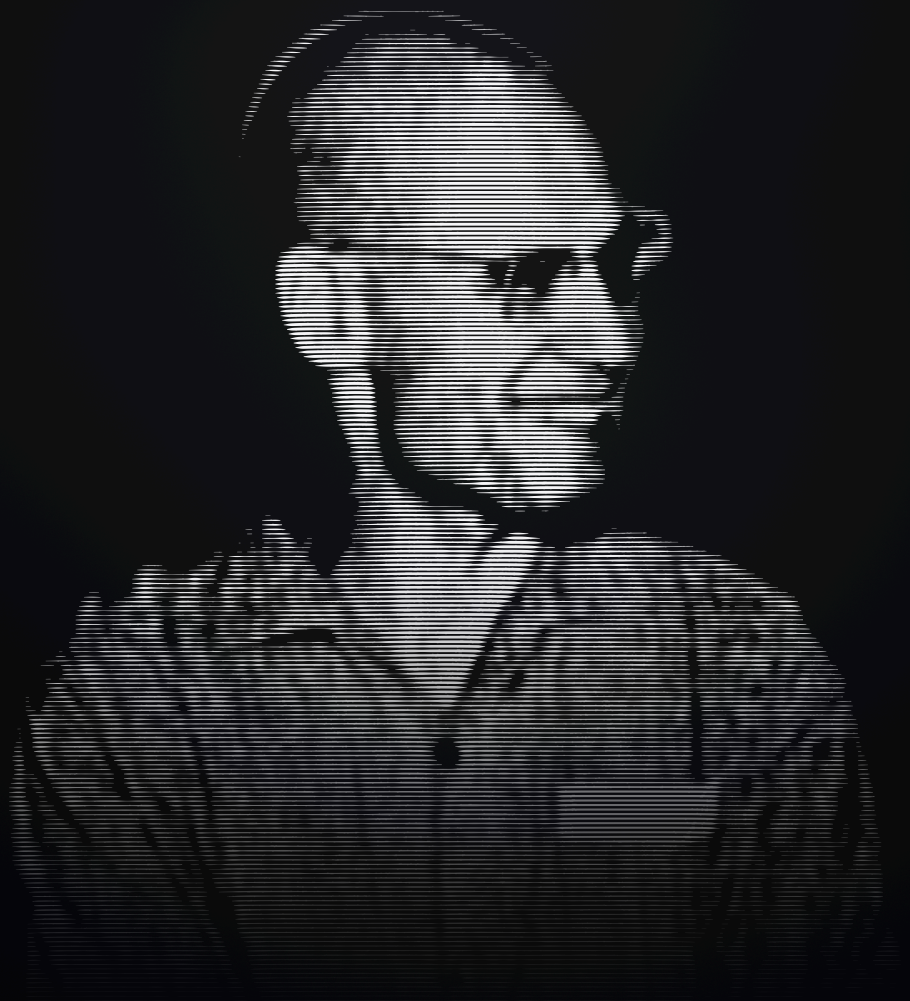
LIVES OF MATHEMATICAL THOUGHT



Alexander Grothendieck

A Life in Three Universes

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LIVES OF MATHEMATICAL THOUGHT · I

Alexander Grothendieck, Montreal, 1970.

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Preface

Alexander Grothendieck enters this book several times before he is born. He enters under uncertain surnames in the borderlands of the Russian Empire; in the unfinished education and radical commitments of his mother; in photographs, identity papers, a novel written from memory, and family stories that do not always agree. Secondary and institutional sources place his birth in Berlin on March 28, 1928; the Berlin civil entry and exact registered name have not yet been inspected. Law, kinship, domestic life, and later recollection describe the same infant differently. The discrepancy is the first lesson in how that life can be known.

Heroic biography looks backward for signs: a childhood question anticipates a theorem, exile becomes the source of abstraction, the solitary child already contains the mathematician who will remake geometry. This book takes a different route. It follows documents before symbols, chronology before destiny, and relations before essence. Few twentieth-century mathematicians changed so many working assumptions or proposed structures of comparable reach. Their making required teachers, students, correspondents, institutions, money, editorial labor, and the freedom to remain in—or refuse—a shared world.

Greatness here resides in the scale of the structures Grothendieck made possible and in the exact history of their making. Statelessness, bereavement, collaboration, and solitude belong to the life without serving as hidden causes of the mathematics. The lived and mathematical histories illuminate one another when comparison remains comparison rather than destiny.

Across twelve Parts and seventy-two chapters, this biography follows an unusually long change of scale. It begins with a family archive whose smallest facts are contested. It passes through camps, schools, provincial examinations, postwar seminars, and the collective construction of a new geometry. It reaches an institute at the height of international prestige, then follows a documented rupture over military-origin funding into ecological and antimilitarist activism. It returns to university classrooms, private mathematical manuscripts, autobiographical indictment, spiritual writing, retirement, and a village in the Ariège. It ends after the death, among two distinct archival collections, new editions, inherited rights, unfinished theories, and mathematical communities whose work no longer requires the founder's presence.

The book tells one chronological life through three inseparable universes. The lived universe: statelessness, war, migration, institutions, friendship, conflict, activism, withdrawal, and the archive left behind. The mathematical universe: the movement from isolated problem solving toward languages capable of reorganizing whole fields. The philosophical universe: simplicity, childhood, creation, community, responsibility, rupture, solitude, dreams, and the limits of possession. The word has a technical sense in his own mathematics: the universes of SGA 4 are sets large enough to hold the constructions of a theory without leaving set theory, and Chapter 33 describes them.[1] The subtitle borrows the word as a figure; it makes no claim about that mathematics.

One movement holds this Preface together: a change of scale can make relations visible, but every enlargement meets a boundary. That movement governs how the book explains

[1] Michael Artin et al., eds., *Théorie des topos et cohomologie étale des schémas (SGA 4), Tome 1*, Lecture Notes in Mathematics 269 (Springer, 1972), https://doi.org/10.1007/BFb0081551, exposé I, appendix.

mathematics, collective work, refusal, silence, and the archive. It also governs how the narrative stops when its evidence stops.

Names before birth: evidence and relation

One of the deepest changes associated with Grothendieck can be stated in ordinary language. Instead of asking only what a mathematical object is by itself, ask how it varies, what maps into it, what maps out of it, how it appears after a change of base, and which constructions remain compatible across those changes. The object does not disappear. It becomes intelligible through a system of relations.

This shift takes several technical forms. A scheme is studied over a base, so that fibers and changes of ground belong to the problem. A moduli question follows whole families and asks whether one geometric object represents them. Descent asks whether compatible local objects come from a global one. A topos gives sheaves and cohomology a setting in which such local-to-global traffic can occur. Later chapters unfold the distinctions; here the governing point is that an object becomes richer when the maps, tests, and transformations around it are retained.

Grothendieck's life also passed through names, countries, households, institutions, and communities. The resemblance is suggestive, but mathematical relations do not disclose their maker's psychology. Schemes, descent, and cohomology arose from technical pressures: classical varieties were too narrow, sheaves had to be transported and glued, fibers had to be compared, and the Weil conjectures demanded new forms of locality. Biography can place those pressures beside the conditions of a life while leaving cause to the evidence.

Relation over object nevertheless provides this book with an ethical as well as a mathematical discipline. A celebrated name should not absorb the network in which it operated. Grothendieck's results have relations to the work of Riemann, Roch, Lebesgue, Zariski, Weil, Cartan, Eilenberg, Mac Lane, Buchsbaum, Serre, Schwartz, Dieudonné, and many others. EGA has a relation to Dieudonné's sustained redaction. SGA has relations to its individual expositors, co-directors, students, and later editors. The Weil conjectures have a relation to Grothendieck's cohomological program and to Deligne's proof of the remaining central estimate. Later motives, stacks, derived geometry, anabelian geometry, and higher categories have relations to Grothendieck's programs and to the independent constructions of those who made them rigorous in forms he did not supply.

A related discipline of attention applies to the nonmathematical life. A civil record places a person in relation to a state; a memoir places later memory beside an earlier event; a letter records an address from one person to another; a resignation records an institutional act. These historical relations have no common proof structure with morphisms or descent. Their value lies in keeping source, date, speaker, and claim visibly connected.

This method also prevents the book from becoming either prosecution or defense. Grothendieck's later accusations about credit must be heard because they are part of his intellectual and moral history. They must also be tested against publications, correspondence, bylines, seminar records, and the independent testimony of the people accused. His ecological warnings deserve historical seriousness without being made infallible by mathematical authority. His spiritual writings deserve description without devotional endorsement or retrospective diagnosis. The relative view refuses the false choice between reverence and dismissal. It asks: relative to which document, which date, which speaker, which institution, which standard of proof?

Long before the research institutions that made Grothendieck's name familiar, later biographical and memorial sources identified his father as Alexander or Sascha Schapiro using

Tanaroff papers and reported an amputation, imprisonment, and anarchist activity. Authenticated civil and prison records remain open, as do the alleged sentence and commutation and the scale of his civil-war activity. The evidence does securely distinguish him from the better-documented anarcho-syndicalist Alexander Schapiro. That correction removes an attractive borrowed biography and leaves the father's own record thinner.

Public memorial, family, and biographical sources give his mother's name as Johanna Frida Elisabeth Grothendieck and record the later forms Hanna and Hanka. Those sources place her in a northern German household whose economic security deteriorated and describe training, artistic ambition, reform movements, political experiment, writing, performance, and precarious work. Her autobiographical novel, *Eine Frau*, is literary self-representation: evidence of how she shaped a life in prose rather than civil proof of each episode.

Jackson and later biographies report that Sascha and Hanka met within the political and artistic geography of Weimar Berlin and lived amid irregular photographic income, prior relationships, children across households, and the vulnerability of Tanaroff papers. Secondary and institutional sources place Grothendieck's birth in Berlin on March 28, 1928. The legal birth-name, paternity, legitimacy, and marriage sequence remains unresolved pending inspection of Berlin civil and family-court records. Naming here is an unsettled series of family and administrative acts, not a label silently attached at birth.

After 1933, National Socialist power made an already precarious household dangerous. Biographical sources report that the young Alexander lived with Wilhelm and Dagmar Heydorn near Hamburg from late 1933 or early 1934 until 1939 and place the household in an anti-Nazi milieu; underlying family and placement records remain unchecked. His parents went toward Spain and the anti-fascist struggle. Distance divided political commitment from daily care, while correspondence and later recollection preserve a relationship across it.

By 1939 the arrangement could no longer hold. Grothendieck traveled from Germany to France and rejoined his parents during the collapse of the Spanish Republic and the approach of another war. French policy toward foreigners and enemy nationals fractured the household again. Inspected biographies report Hanka and her son at Rieucros, Sascha's internment at Le Vernet, his deportation in August 1942, and his death at Auschwitz. The intermediate Drancy, convoy, arrival, and death-record chain awaits direct archival inspection.

The father's death remained part of the son's life without becoming the moral capital of his career. Mathematical eminence offers no compensation for murder. The documentary sequence carries all the weight the narrative can ask of it.

Grothendieck and his mother survived through another network. Named biographies and institutional histories place him in the Le Chambon-sur-Lignon orbit and at the Collège Cévenol, where refuge and schooling depended on teachers, religious communities, relief organizations, hosts, administrators, and other refugees. The route after Rieucros, the possible Gurs or Brens layers, the residential facility, enrollment dates, and labor details remain unclosed. Collective protection is secure at the level of the network; its exact itinerary is not.

War did not stop education. The surviving record supports study and examinations, while Grothendieck's later recollection identifies dissatisfaction with the way length, area, and volume had been taught. Those questions acquired importance through the work that followed, not as prophecies staged in a classroom.

Liberation brought neither a restored family nor an uncomplicated nationality. Grothendieck entered the University of Montpellier in the 1945–1946 academic year. Accounts describe a modest scholarship, agricultural work, and material difficulty, but exact household claims remain unevenly documented. The legally precise onset and continuity of statelessness are among the questions that require records not yet opened. It is safest to

describe the condition as it appears in the available biographical and administrative evidence without inventing a single juridical turning point.

Institutional and scholarly biographies describe Grothendieck as stateless through 1971 and as obtaining French citizenship that year. They also connect particular travel and employment constraints to documentary status, although the onset, continuity, naturalization decree, and effective date await archival confirmation. Statelessness was a concrete vulnerability among his many relations as student, son, partner, parent, employee, and colleague; it was never a total identity.

At Montpellier, Grothendieck later recalled pursuing questions about length, area, volume, measure, and integration that the local curriculum did not satisfy. Secondary accounts characterize the work as an independent reconstruction of measure theory. No authenticated student manuscript has yet been checked against Lebesgue theory, so its exact definitions, scope, and omissions remain open.

This episode establishes a habit without establishing a destiny. Grothendieck wanted something beyond a formula that returned the right number. He wanted to know what made the formula an instance of a coherent construction. He later recalled declining, for a time, to consult the established solution because he wished to let the question disclose its own necessities. The method could waste effort, miss counterexamples, and produce gaps; his recollection acknowledges as much. It could also reveal why a definition had the shape it did. Understanding came to mean rebuilding the setting in which a result became unavoidable.

Montpellier could not offer a research community equal to that inquiry, but it supplied examinations, a degree, books, and a professor who saw that Paris offered what the local faculty could not. Dependence and independence coexisted. This will recur throughout the life. The institution that fails one need can still supply another; the person who refuses its intellectual limit can still require its certificate.

From solitary questions to a relative world

Grothendieck later described his 1948 arrival in Paris as an encounter with unfamiliar vocabulary—groups, fields, rings, modules, complexes, and homology—and biographical accounts emphasize gaps between his Montpellier training and the language assumed in research seminars. He arrived with an unusual measure manuscript as well. The mismatch shows the distance between reconstructing one subject alone and entering a community in which many subjects have already been organized.

The Cartan seminar and the Parisian mathematical network exposed both the strength and the limit of solitary reconstruction. Henri Cartan, André Weil, Jean Dieudonné, Laurent Schwartz, Jean-Pierre Serre, and others represented different ages, institutions, and mathematical temperaments. They should not be arranged retrospectively as a pantheon assembled to recognize a future master. At that moment Grothendieck was a newcomer with uncertain professional prospects. Statelessness complicated ordinary routes to appointments and travel. What mattered was not ceremony but the identification of a problem and a place where he could work on it.

Nancy provided that place from October 1949. Schwartz and Dieudonné were developing functional analysis beyond the established terrain of Banach spaces. Spaces of smooth functions, test functions, and distributions required topologies governed by families of seminorms rather than one norm. Duality, tensor products, boundedness, completeness, and infinite-dimensional operations did not line up automatically. Schwartz and Dieudonné offered a list of hard questions. Grothendieck's rapid progress altered his status from inadequately prepared student to an active contributor.

Functional analysis can look remote from the algebraic geometry for which he became known. It already displayed several enduring demands. A distribution is a continuous linear functional on a specified space of test functions, so a generalized object is understood through all admissible probes. A topology can be chosen to make the right operations continuous. Tensor products require a setting in which bilinear relations can be represented linearly. Nuclear spaces identify conditions under which competing completions and tensor constructions behave with unusual harmony.

Topological vector spaces arose because ordinary normed spaces were too narrow for central objects of analysis. Nuclearity controlled operators, tensor products, and duality in settings tied to distributions and partial differential equations. These were live questions posed by mentors and predecessors, not symbols waiting to be decoded as personality.

Nancy also corrects the myth of intellectual self-creation. Schwartz and Dieudonné selected the terrain, offered problems, read work, and connected Grothendieck to a professional community. Grothendieck supplied solutions of extraordinary range and speed. Mentorship became collaboration without ceasing to be asymmetric. Hanka remained part of the material and emotional perimeter of these years, but the available record does not license an intimate domestic reconstruction. The dedication associated with his thesis and later accounts establish gratitude more securely than imagined conversations.

The doctoral work appeared across publications whose dates and exact administrative sequence require care. This book keeps the memoir, journal publication, degree process, and later reputation distinct. A result can be completed, presented, accepted, and published at different times. The common habit of assigning one year to an entire intellectual transition creates false simultaneity. The same caution will matter for EGA and SGA, where seminar year, fascicle circulation, revision, and book publication often diverge by a decade.

After Nancy came appointments and travel in São Paulo and Kansas, followed by a return to France. These years were not decorative bridges between analysis and geometry. In São Paulo, a different mathematical community and teaching setting widened the professional world. In Kansas, Grothendieck worked on the foundations of homological algebra that would become the 1957 paper commonly called Tôhoku. The nickname refers to the journal, not to a visit to Japan. Writing belongs to the Kansas period; publication belongs to a later year; canonical status belongs to the subsequent use of the paper.

The paper's central move can be explained without requiring the reader to calculate a derived functor. Algebra often studies operations that preserve part of an exact sequence and fail to preserve the rest. Homological algebra records the failure as structured information. Higher Ext, Tor, and cohomology groups do more than announce that something went wrong; they measure the obstruction and arrange it across degrees. Cartan and Eilenberg had systematized this machinery for modules. Buchsbaum had already sought a broader exact setting. Grothendieck developed an axiomatic environment in which the method worked for categories including sheaves, proved major existence results for injectives under stated conditions, and established machinery for composing derived functors.

An abelian category is not a mist in which objects disappear. It is a setting where arrows can be added, kernels and cokernels behave well, and exact sequences retain the formal properties needed for homological arguments. The achievement was portability. A proof that used only this grammar could move from modules to sheaves and future examples. The limits also matter. Infinite sums, filtered colimits, enough injectives, generators, and size conditions require explicit hypotheses. A universal language is useful because it names its conditions, not because it makes conditions vanish.

The Tôhoku paper also displays the discipline behind universal language. A universal property specifies a class of candidate objects and a unique morphism in a stated direction; initial and terminal constructions point in opposite directions, and each theorem must say which one it uses. Universality therefore means exact relational characterization, not applicability to everything. Grothendieck repeatedly sought this form of understanding, with generality following from the conditions rather than from a taste for altitude.

During the same period, sheaves and cohomology drew him toward geometry. Serre's work on coherent algebraic sheaves and the relation between algebraic and analytic geometry supplied major foundations. Category theory, introduced by Eilenberg and Mac Lane, supplied language already in use. Weil's arithmetic program and Zariski's local methods supplied problems and predecessors. The transition was not an analyst waking one morning as an algebraic geometer. It was a convergence of tools whose compatibility had become visible.

Grothendieck's reformulation of Riemann–Roch offers an early, decisive example. The classical theorem had developed from questions about meromorphic functions on curves. Hirzebruch had carried it to nonsingular complex projective varieties through characteristic classes. Grothendieck changed the subject from an invariant attached to one variety to compatibility under a proper morphism. K-theory encoded additivity from exact sequences; direct images transported sheaf-theoretic information; characteristic classes translated between kinds of data. When the target was a point, the earlier theorem reappeared as a special case.

The published history prevents a single-author fable. The new theorem was presented in 1957 and expounded in print by Armand Borel and Jean-Pierre Serre in 1958, with explicit attribution to Grothendieck's unpublished results. Grothendieck supplied a separate appendix on Chern classes. Authorship of the exposition and origin of the theorem were related but distinct. The episode is a compact model for this biography's account of collective mathematics: name each act at the resolution the documents allow.

By 1958 the questions surrounding algebraic geometry had outgrown the available objects. Varieties over fields did not comfortably hold arithmetic families over the integers, infinitesimal structure, degeneration, specialization, and change of base within one grammar. Cohomology suitable for the Weil conjectures would require constructions stable across characteristics. Moduli problems required a way to treat families, not only isolated examples. Foundations were not a retreat from research. They were what research had begun to demand.

Grothendieck's address at the International Congress in Edinburgh announced part of this need. That same year, correspondence records the beginning of the writing project that became *Éléments de géométrie algébrique*, or EGA. The timing is useful because it catches the project before later monumentality concealed its provisional character. There was an ambitious program, a collaborator beginning sustained redaction, notes and letters moving among mathematicians, and an expected schedule that would prove radically optimistic.

A scheme is the central object in the new foundation, but its significance lies in the relations it permits. For a commutative ring A, the prime ideals form the points of $\operatorname{Spec} A$; a topology and structure sheaf record how algebra behaves locally. Schemes are built by gluing such affine pieces. The definition allows ordinary varieties, arithmetic bases, generic points, special fibers, and nilpotent infinitesimal information to occupy one category. It also admits objects that resist ordinary visualization.

The familiar phrase generalized space is useful for less than a page. It tells a general reader that geometry has been enlarged. It becomes false if it suggests that every scheme is a hidden shape in three-dimensional space. $\operatorname{Spec} \mathbb{Z}$ has closed points associated with prime numbers and a generic point associated with the zero ideal; changing base to a finite field selects an

arithmetic fiber. Nilpotents may carry deformation information without adding visible points. The faithful intuition is not a strange picture. It is a setting in which algebraic variation, localization, and base change can be performed coherently.

The relative viewpoint changes the unit of attention. Instead of a scheme X alone, consider a morphism $X \to S$. The base S may parameterize a family. Pulling back along $S' \to S$ produces $X \times_S S'$, the same construction viewed after a change of ground. A property worth using in families must have an explicitly stated behavior under this operation. Geometry becomes a study of transport.

This is where relation over object acquires technical force. A point is one kind of test, but a whole scheme can be another. The functor of points asks, for every test scheme T, which morphisms $T \to X$ exist. Under the Yoneda principle, the compatible system of all such maps determines X up to unique isomorphism. An object is recovered through every admissible relation into it. The principle does not mean that objects are illusions. It means that identity in a category can be expressed without opening an object to inspect hidden substance.

Representability turns this into a research method. Suppose a rule assigns to each test scheme T a set of families, line bundles, divisors, curves, or other data, and pullback makes the assignment functorial. Is there a scheme M such that maps $T \to M$ correspond naturally to those families? If so, M represents the functor and carries a universal family. A classification problem has become geometry.

Representability is never guaranteed. Automorphisms may require a stack rather than a scheme. Separation can fail. A parameter object may be infinite-dimensional, or no acceptable object may exist. Grothendieck's Fondements de la géométrie algébrique, associated with a sequence of Bourbaki expositions, developed representability and formal methods in concrete, difficult settings. FGA should not be described as a third book parallel to EGA and SGA. It is a publication history built from expositions and later collections. Its role was to show how the functorial question could yield Picard schemes, Hilbert schemes, formal existence results, and general criteria under precise hypotheses.

The relative world also changed how old objects were valued. Nilpotents, once easy to dismiss because they do not create new ordinary points, could record an infinitesimal thickening and hence a possible deformation. A fiber over one prime could be compared with fibers over others. A family could reveal which features persist and which jump. A singular member was no longer treated as a defective isolated object; it might be a boundary point of a moduli problem and a source of information about the whole family.

The intellectual power of this shift should not obscure its ancestry. EGA itself names Zariski, Weil, Serre, Chevalley, Nagata, commutative algebra, homological algebra, and sheaf theory among the sources from which it worked. Bourbaki contributed standards, personnel, and a structural discipline, but EGA was not Bourbaki mechanically applied to geometry. The driving problems came from geometry and arithmetic. The language changed because those problems resisted inherited categories.

The making of EGA belonged equally to an institutional transition. Léon Motchane founded the Institut des Hautes Études Scientifiques in 1958. Jean Dieudonné became its first permanent mathematician and, in the institution's later account, made Grothendieck's recruitment a condition of his own. The early institute worked from Paris before moving to the Bois-Marie property at Bures-sur-Yvette in 1962. *Publications Mathématiques de l'IHÉS* provided a vehicle for work whose length and serial form exceeded ordinary journal expectations.

This sequence matters because institutions are often described as neutral containers for genius. IHÉS was made through fundraising, negotiation, appointments, buildings, journals, visitors, and administrative choices. It gave Grothendieck unusual freedom and a concentrated

international community. His work gave the new institute extraordinary scientific authority. Neither side can be reduced to benefactor and beneficiary. Their later conflict arose inside a relation of mutual construction.

The new geometry soon required measuring systems equal to its change of scale. Cohomology often begins when locally available data fail to produce a global solution. Functions that agree on overlaps do glue; the obstruction lies in finding compatible choices, or in the cocycles left when local choices differ. Many such obstructions can be encoded cohomologically in graded groups whose structure can be transported and compared.

For algebraic varieties over the complex numbers, topology supplied familiar cohomology. Over finite fields and in positive characteristic, there may be no underlying complex manifold whose ordinary topology can be borrowed. Weil's conjectures concerning point counts and zeta functions demanded an algebraic cohomology with properties analogous to those of a good topological theory: finite-dimensionality, functoriality, products, duality, cycle classes, and an action of Frobenius whose traces encode arithmetic counts.

The first requirement was a new notion of local covering. Zariski-open sets are often too coarse. Étale maps behave, in one useful sense, like local isomorphisms without requiring inclusion as an open subset. The analogy with covering spaces helps explain why finite étale covers can support an algebraic fundamental group. It stops where topological paths are assumed. In arithmetic geometry the group is reconstructed from the category of covers and a fiber functor, not from loops drawn in an ambient manifold.

A site abstracts this choice of locality. It is a category equipped with families of morphisms declared to cover, subject to compatibility conditions. A sheaf on the site is data that restricts and glues according to those covers. This separates the idea of locality from a predetermined set of open subsets. The étale site of a scheme permits local observations that the Zariski topology cannot see.

Descent asks the complementary question. If objects are given over a cover and isomorphisms identify them on overlaps, with the identifications satisfying a cocycle condition, do they come from one object downstairs? The slogan local data glue is insufficient. The overlaps, arrows, and compatibility on triple overlaps are part of the substance. Effective descent is a theorem under hypotheses, not an automatic feature of any attractive collection of pieces.

Descent carries philosophical resonance because it refuses to regard a global object as a pile of local appearances: overlap data determine whether a genuine whole exists. The analogy stops before mathematical diagrams are treated as social proofs.

Topoi enlarge the setting again. A Grothendieck topos is, in one standard description, a category equivalent to sheaves of sets on a site. Different sites can present equivalent topoi, so the world of sheaves is more intrinsic than any one presentation. Ordinary topological spaces produce examples, but a topos cannot be reduced to a space with unusual open sets. It is a category with limits, colimits, exponentials, a subobject classifier, and a distinctive internal logic. In geometry, it provides a habitat for sheaves and cohomology; in logic, it supports variable mathematical universes.

The word world is useful if its limit is stated. A topos supplies rules for how objects, truth values, and local sections behave internally. It does not create an alternative physical universe. Nor should its logical applications be credited entirely to Grothendieck: the theory developed through Lawvere, Tierney, Giraud, and many others, in mathematical conversations whose branches had their own authors.

The seminars known collectively as SGA were the engine of this construction. The first numbered seminar treated étale coverings and the fundamental group. Later programs addressed local cohomology, group schemes, topoi and étale cohomology, ℓ-adic methods,

L-functions, intersections, Riemann–Roch, and monodromy. EGA stabilized foundational grammar while SGA tested, extended, and taught it against active problems. The separation is imperfect because each depended on the other.

SGA was not a transcript of one person speaking. Seminar years, oral expositions, typed fascicles, revisions, and publication dates form distinct layers. SGA 1 carries the seminar year 1960–1961 and a 1971 publication date in its revised edition. The three volumes of SGA 4 appeared in 1972 and 1973 after the 1963–1964 seminar. To cite only the book year can make the research late; to cite only the seminar year can transport later redaction backward. This biography gives both when they matter.

The collective form was real and unequal. Grothendieck chose programs, supplied concepts and prenotes, assigned expositions, corrected drafts, and exercised exceptional authority. Participants proved results, filled gaps, proposed generalizations, wrote expositions, and later edited volumes. Individual bylines, co-directorships, and editorial formulas should survive summary. The phrase Grothendieck's seminar identifies an organizing center. Used possessively to claim every theorem, it becomes false.

The architecture of cohomology grew through this system. Derived functors translated failures of exactness into higher groups. Spectral sequences organized calculations across layers. Base-change theorems controlled the relation between fibers and families; duality related complementary degrees; ℓ-adic constructions supplied coefficients suitable for Frobenius. The Grothendieck–Lefschetz trace-formula program connected fixed points and arithmetic counts through work spread across SGA 4 and SGA 5. SGA 4 credits Artin, Grothendieck, and Verdier as directors; SGA 5 records the 1965–1966 seminar and appeared in 1977 under Illusie's editorship, while theorem-level credit remains with named expositors. This collective architecture advanced the Weil program without completing the analogue of the Riemann hypothesis.

The distinction is crucial for attribution. Grothendieck proposed and directed a cohomological architecture in which the Weil conjectures could be attacked. Deligne later proved the remaining central estimate. Saying that Grothendieck proved the Weil conjectures is false. Saying that Deligne's proof occurred in an unrelated landscape is equally false. History needs a grammar capable of naming program, framework, theorem, proof, and continuation separately.

Motives arose from the plurality of cohomologies. Betti, de Rham, étale, and crystalline theories seemed to reveal different realizations of something shared. Grothendieck proposed motives as a universal source for such realizations, linked to algebraic cycles and equivalence relations. The musical metaphor of one motif sounding through several arrangements is memorable and incomplete. It does not construct a category, settle the standard conjectures, or supply comparison functors.

There is no single finished category of motives possessing every expected property. There are rigorous categories of pure motives under specified choices, triangulated and mixed constructions, motivic cohomology, and motivic homotopy theories, alongside conjectural structures. The standard conjectures were intended to secure deep positivity and equivalence properties for algebraic cycles, with consequences for a satisfactory theory. Their openness was not a minor gap beneath a completed vision. It marked the boundary between program and theorem.

This period culminated publicly in the 1966 Fields Medal. The International Congress of Mathematicians met in Moscow, and Grothendieck did not attend. The absence is documented; the exact motive is not fixed by a contemporaneous public explanation in the present record. Later biographies place it within his pacifism and political refusals, but consistency with later

action cannot become a missing acceptance speech. It should not be called a refusal of the medal itself. His explicit refusal of a prize came in 1988 under different circumstances.

The absent laureate is an apt but dangerous emblem. It can make political withdrawal appear inevitable years before the institutional break. In 1966 Grothendieck remained intensely engaged at IHÉS, completing large texts, directing seminars, corresponding, and opening further programs in crystals, motives, and monodromy. The summit was not already the fall. Chronology requires that later knowledge be withheld from the earlier moment.

The house, its many hands, and the price of refusal

By the mid-1960s the mathematical school stood near its height, while the institution that sustained it had become a house in more than one sense. IHÉS consisted of an estate and seminar rooms, but also schedules, trains, visiting appointments, salaries, publication budgets, secretarial work, governance, and money from sources that did not carry the same political meaning for every participant.

At Bois-Marie, Grothendieck's Tuesday seminars combined preparation and openness. Witnesses remember lucid exposition, careful recall of prerequisites, severe standards for written work, and long correction sessions. Students could receive questions that determined years of research. Being chosen could feel like recognition and like an obligation. A leader able to see a field's architecture could give unusually fertile problems; the same authority could narrow the space in which another person's priorities appeared.

The biographer should not settle this tension with one adjective. Generous and dominating can describe different effects of the same act. Patient with a basic question and exacting about a comma can belong to one teacher. A collective enterprise can be shared in fact and strongly hierarchical. The purpose of naming contradictions is not to turn a person into an enigma. It is to avoid making one witness cancel another.

The printed record makes the plurality visible. EGA attributes the work to Grothendieck with the collaboration of Dieudonné. Retrospective accounts gathered by Borel and Jackson, including Illusie's testimony, describe Dieudonné organizing and rewriting material, completing proofs, controlling notation, and contributing mathematics. SGA title pages and tables of contents identify directors, editors, collaborators, and exposé authors. Hartshorne's *Residues and Duality* emerged from Grothendieck's program and prenotes while remaining Hartshorne's book. Posters name Deligne and Grothendieck together as directors of the local monodromy seminar before the breach. Katz, Illusie, Berthelot, Verdier, Raynaud, Artin, and many others entered the work under distinct bibliographic forms.

Four kinds of making repeatedly overlap: proposing a concept or program, constructing definitions and proofs, writing or redacting an exposition, and editing or producing a stable publication. Standard authorship compresses them. Biography should expand them again without pretending that every lemma can be assigned from surviving evidence. Typists and production staff did not become coauthors of theorems, but their skilled work made thousands of pages navigable. Grothendieck's 1967 instructions for manuscript preparation reveal a precise infrastructure of notation, punctuation, references, correction, and return to authors when doubt arose. The mathematical monument had a workflow.

The ethic of this system depended partly on abundance. Problems and ideas could be given because a large program would benefit from their development in other hands. A student's theorem could become part of a shared architecture. Tacit knowledge within a close community might preserve origin even when every paper did not repeat a name. Once the community dispersed, those assumptions became unstable. A printed byline could record the expositor without recording the person who proposed the problem; a program director could

remember an idea as part of his construction while the person who proved it remembered the labor that made it true.

Grothendieck's later writings would transform these tensions into accusations of burial and appropriation. They must not be imported backward as secret causes already governing the 1960s. During the summit years, many witnesses remember openness, excitement, and shared work. The later grievance is evidence of a changed judgment, not proof that generosity was false. Conversely, earlier generosity does not make all later complaints imaginary. The chronology allows both records to exist and asks that each claim about credit be tested at its proper date.

The mathematics at the summit also remained unfinished. EGA had reached a vast published extent without completing its original plan. SGA volumes required years of redaction. Motives and the standard conjectures opened a horizon rather than closing one. The scale of the work makes it tempting to interpret incompletion psychologically, as exhaustion or despair. The documents establish expansion, competing programs, editorial burden, and unfinished texts. They do not establish one private cause.

Political action had already entered the life before the IHÉS dispute. Grothendieck traveled to North Vietnam in 1967 and taught during a war in which air raids were a material condition. May 1968 altered the French political landscape and the relation between universities, authority, and public dissent. Neither event alone explains the 1970 resignation. They belong to an accumulation of encounters in which mathematical work and organized violence could no longer be held in separate moral compartments.

The house at Bures had enabled extraordinary independence from routine university demands. That independence required support. Motchane assembled a mixed financial structure from public, private, French, European, and American sources. Its negotiated plurality of patrons allowed research freedom while leaving open who could set an ethical boundary for the institution. Here a method successful in mathematics reached its limit: enlarging the context clarified the conflict but could not dissolve it.

The immediate rupture can be narrated without a psychological theory. An audited statement for 1969 lists 90,000 francs received from the Ministry of the Armies. The amount formed a small but nontrivial part of the institute's finances, roughly four percent of contributions and subsidies and a smaller share of total income depending on the denominator used. In a budget under pressure, it was neither the foundation of IHÉS nor an amount without practical consequence.

The evidence does not show that Grothendieck or his seminar performed a weapons project. The dispute concerned the origin of the money and the moral meaning of accepting it. This distinction should not be used to trivialize the objection. For Grothendieck, provenance itself crossed a boundary. For colleagues seeking continuity, the absence of directed military research and the possibility of assigning the funds to visits in physics could matter. The disagreement was partly a disagreement over whether use could contain origin.

The chronology separates several acts often compressed into one dramatic departure. Conflict entered the scientific committee on April 6, 1970. The board minutes of April 22 record Grothendieck's condition that such funding be refused if he were to remain, the position of physicists Louis Michel and David Ruelle, and the board's decision to accept a proposed 90,000-franc grant while giving priority to invitations in physics. Grothendieck's letter of May 25 announced his decision and a probable October 1 departure. A June 9 letter confirmed October 1 as the effective date.

The break was a process. On June 26, Grothendieck spoke at Orsay on the responsibility of scientists and the military apparatus. In July, he lectured on current mathematics at a

summer school in Montreal while making space for a public address about science and military institutions. The first *Survivre* bulletin dated the movement's formation to July 20 and its first general meeting to July 24; the issue appeared in August, while later accounts disagree over founder and editorial labels. At Nice, during the International Congress of Mathematicians, political distribution and congress rules came into conflict. Mathematical and public work therefore overlapped the documented departure.

The military-funding sequence has the strongest documentary claim as the proximate cause of departure from IHÉS. Broader accounts name other factors: political transformation, the Vietnam War, May 1968, accumulated conflict with Motchane, work intensity, dissatisfaction with the profession, and changing priorities. Some may belong to a fuller explanation, but their evidentiary status differs. A later self-interpretation cannot be made contemporary by smooth prose. An institutional cause need not become a total explanation of a life.

The ethical force of resignation came from consistency between a stated condition and an enacted consequence. Its ethical difficulty came from dependence. Grothendieck did not leave work belonging only to himself. Students and collaborators were writing inside programs he had directed. Seminar volumes remained unfinished. Colleagues had commitments to visitors and institutions. Asking others to resign with him made solidarity materially consequential, but it also asked people whose careers and mathematical choices were connected to his authority to accept his political judgment. Deligne and the other permanent professors did not leave. Their refusal was not a theorem against Grothendieck's conscience; his disappointment was not proof of their betrayal.

Professional continuity after the breach further complicates the word exile. Grothendieck held a temporary position at the Collège de France, described in his own contemporary account as proposed and later renewed through Serre's initiative. He also taught at Orsay. Technical mathematical activity continued. These positions did not recreate the permanent post, visitor network, publication machinery, and seminar authority of IHÉS. They show continuity without cancelling rupture.

Survivre, later *Survivre et vivre*, widened the argument beyond one budget line. Its early program joined nuclear danger, militarism, pollution, ecological imbalance, industrial society, resource destruction, scientific authority, and the separation of science from life. Grothendieck was a principal initiator, but the movement was not his private instrument. Gordon Edwards and a broader founding and editorial group participated from the Montreal phase; Claude Chevalley and Pierre Samuel became important in France; later contributors altered the bulletin's emphasis and form.

The name supplied a minimum rather than a complete politics: survival of humanity and life. That breadth allowed weapons, pollution, technology, population, food, energy, and professional responsibility to appear in one field. It also created disagreements about priority, expertise, and action. Should scientists begin by refusing military money? Should the movement first analyze capitalism, state power, and industrial production? Could specialized knowledge be used without reproducing the hierarchy being criticized? Was catastrophic urgency compatible with slow collective deliberation?

Grothendieck's answer often began with individual refusal. A scientist implicated in military systems should decline support and warn others; analysis that indefinitely postponed action risked becoming accommodation. The argument was morally clear and practically incomplete. Removing one grant could not dismantle an armaments system. Technical knowledge, public institutions, and collective organization remained necessary. The movement's history records attempts to move from personal purity toward a broader ecology of responsibility.

Public lectures became assemblies rather than one-way transmissions. Mathematical reputation drew audiences, while the talks questioned the social value of the activity that had produced the reputation. This contradiction was productive and unstable. Grothendieck could challenge scientific hierarchy from a platform made available by scientific distinction. Listeners could agree about nuclear danger and reject his prescription. Younger militants could regard the recent dissident from IHÉS as an established mandarin. Leaving an elite institution did not erase the social authority accumulated within it.

The activism also changed the meaning of expertise. Grothendieck's mathematical achievements gave him no special authority to predict ecological timelines or settle political economy. He learned from activists, scientists, pamphlets, travel, and public debate. Some warnings were prescient in direction; some forecasts and formulations were uneven. The book neither borrows certainty from the Fields Medal nor uses error in one domain to diminish achievement in another.

The years 1969–1971 therefore form no simple conversion from pure mathematics to politics. They show a refusal of the separation itself. Mathematical work, institutional finance, military systems, environmental danger, pedagogy, and public authority had become connected questions. The connection did not yield one durable organization or a complete social theory. It altered what Grothendieck was willing to treat as outside the mathematician's responsibility.

By 1973, the most intense phase of his direct involvement in the movement was passing, though the bulletin continued until 1975 under changing leadership. He had neither returned to the old research life nor left institutions altogether. The next phase would unfold in the public university where his own formal mathematical education had begun.

Work beyond the center: reaping, sowing, pursuing

Grothendieck took up a professorship at Montpellier during the 1973–1974 academic year. The appointment is an ordinary administrative fact with unusual corrective power. Three years after the IHÉS resignation, he had not ceased to be employed as a mathematician. He entered a different academic ecology: regular courses, examinations, degree structures, students of uneven preparation, fewer advanced interlocutors, and far less control over the surrounding research agenda.

The return to Montpellier creates a biographical symmetry that should be distrusted before it is used. The young student had found the curriculum inadequate and pursued his own foundational question. The professor now had to teach within a curriculum and decide how another person's question could become serious work. A university cannot require every student to rediscover a theory alone. It must transmit common language, establish standards, and still leave room for problems that the syllabus has not authorized. Grothendieck's later teaching experiments can be read as efforts to hold these demands together. There is no evidence that he arrived in 1973 with the answer already formed.

The setting was marginal only in relation to the research center he had left. Montpellier was an established university city, and Grothendieck held rank, salary, and international reputation. Students knew that their professor had received a Fields Medal. Yet he stood at a distance from the seminar circuits, journals, visitor networks, and concentrated school through which research prestige was reproduced. In *Esquisse d'un programme*, he later said that he had ceased publishing scientific articles after 1970. That self-report concerns ordinary article publication: private manuscripts continued to circulate, and earlier collective EGA and SGA work continued to appear in print. Geography, teaching, conflict, and narrowing contact added other forms of distance.

Teaching brought mathematics to a smaller scale. Courses and student projects turned toward surfaces, elementary geometry, groupoids, and research initiation. The word elementary did not mean easy or trivial. A surface can be cut, marked, glued, and deformed in ways that expose topology before a large technical machine is introduced. Several mathematical languages can describe the same surface: topological, differentiable, conformal, algebraic. Passing among them raises exact questions about what each language remembers.

Grothendieck's own retrospective assessment was mixed. He regarded the Montpellier encounter as fertile for his mathematical imagination and often judged his research-level teaching unsuccessful. The judgment belongs to him and should not become an objective grade assigned to every student. It does establish that the later period was not a pastoral success story in which a famous mathematician chose ordinary teaching and found uncomplicated renewal. Preparation gaps, institutional requirements, scarce positions, different expectations, and the difficulty of communicating an enormous private program limited what could become collective work.

The classroom also displaced the idea of first principles. At Nancy, Grothendieck had entered a field through hard questions posed by established mathematicians. At Montpellier, some students needed a question whose surface could be seen before the technical language was mastered. Research initiation therefore had to distinguish productive ignorance from simple lack of equipment. A teacher could honor a student's intuition while still showing where proof, counterexample, and inherited theory changed the problem.

These pedagogical years formed the foreground of an extensive private workshop. Letters, course papers, manuscripts, and later catalogs show mathematical production across the 1970s and 1980s. The works have different states. Some are complete documents with stable

publication histories; some are long investigations circulated by copy; some are programs; some are editorially reconstructed much later; some remain blocked from strong claims because their manuscripts and provenance have not received adequate inspection. The mere quantity of paper proves activity, not correctness or completion.

La Longue Marche à travers la théorie de Galois, associated with 1981, belongs to this workshop. Its complete extent and critical status remain insufficiently verified for the strongest bibliographic claims, so the title should not be made to carry a finished hidden theory. Its subject returns to the absolute Galois group and to the problem of understanding an immense symmetry through more accessible geometric and combinatorial structures. The route would lead toward dessins, moduli, fundamental groups, and anabelian reconstruction.

The movement back toward algebraic geometry was neither a repudiation of activism nor a restoration of the IHÉS period. The objects were often lower-dimensional and visually elementary; the mode of circulation was personal rather than institutional; the intended architecture remained broad. Curves and surfaces sit at a junction where topology, complex analysis, algebraic geometry, and arithmetic meet. Their apparent smallness concentrates relations rather than reducing them.

An event in the late 1970s illustrates the new communication system. Through Deligne, Grothendieck learned of Belyi's theorem, which connects algebraic curves over the algebraic closure of the rational numbers with finite maps to the projective line ramified only over 0, 1, and ∞. The theorem traveled through publications, letters, and personal report rather than through a seminar directed by Grothendieck. Its consequences became central to his later program.

For a Belyi map $\beta : X \to \mathbb{P}^1$, the inverse image of the interval $[0,1]$ is a bipartite graph embedded on the oriented surface X: a dessin d'enfant. The vertices lie over 0 and 1, and the embedding supplies cyclic order data. This structured dessin, rather than an arbitrary drawing, records the branched covering up to the appropriate equivalence. The absolute Galois group acts on Belyi pairs and hence on dessins; Belyi's theorem and Grothendieck's later dessins program remain distinct achievements.

The charm of the picture can conceal the difficulty. A drawing does not visibly reveal its field of definition. Similar combinatorial features need not determine a Galois orbit. One curve may carry many Belyi maps. The theorem normalizes branching; it does not make arithmetic transparent. The program's force lay in making invisible symmetry act on finite objects without pretending that the action had thereby been classified.

Grothendieck also turned toward the Teichmüller tower: the interconnected moduli spaces of curves with marked points, together with operations of gluing, forgetting, degeneration, and the actions on their fundamental groups. The popular image of Lego pieces captures assembly from elementary forms. It fails if it suggests rigid blocks, no automorphisms, or effortless compatibility. Curves deform; boundary strata intersect; gluing in different orders requires relations among relations. The hoped-for reconstruction from low levels was a program, not a theorem already completed in the sketch.

Anabelian geometry asked a related but distinct question. For suitable arithmetic varieties, how much geometry can be reconstructed from a nonabelian profinite fundamental group equipped with Galois action? The phrase far from abelian signals the refusal to discard commutator information that may encode geometry. Later work separated isomorphism, homomorphism, birational, and section problems under different hypotheses; the chapters name individual authors and versions rather than folding that theorem history into a claim that every space is determined by a group.

The Montpellier years also returned Grothendieck to stacks. A moduli problem involving objects with automorphisms is not faithfully represented by a set of isomorphism classes. Local objects may be isomorphic rather than equal; their isomorphisms must agree on overlaps; the global result retains stabilizers. A stack is a category-valued form of sheaf satisfying descent for objects and arrows. Higher stacks add further levels of coherent comparison.

This is not only an ascent in abstraction. It is a refusal to throw away symmetry to obtain a simpler answer. A coarse moduli space can be useful, but it forgets information. The stack keeps the automorphisms because they affect deformation, intersection, and gluing. Once again an object is understood through relations, including relations among its relations.

The private workshop did not develop in total isolation. Students, correspondents, former colleagues, and mathematicians in Bangor, Paris, and elsewhere exchanged pages and questions. Selective contact is not the same as a seminar community, but it refutes the image of twenty years without mathematical relation. The hidden work was hidden from ordinary professional visibility, not created outside all social infrastructure.

One later document makes the continuity visible. *Esquisse d'un programme* accompanied Grothendieck's effort to leave regular teaching for a CNRS research position. Its printed terminal date is January 1984, while a curated catalog assigns a 1983 label whose basis has not been fully reopened. Composition had antecedents in 1983 letters and manuscripts; formal publication came only in 1997. Writing date, circulation, and publication are separate facts.

The *Esquisse* takes stock by proposing work. It moves among dessins, the absolute Galois group, marked curves, the Teichmüller tower, tame topology, higher structures, and questions arising from teaching. Some statements are theorems, some conjectures, some desired foundations, and some heuristic images. To praise the document by turning every task into an achievement would destroy the programmatic tense that gives it meaning.

Its administrative setting sharpens the mathematics. Grothendieck argued that research-level teaching at Montpellier had become unproductive for him and that no local colleague or successor seemed likely to develop the perspectives he was describing. He also acknowledged the scarcity of research positions and the cost of appointing an established mathematician. The CNRS application was neither the manifesto of an unknown outsider nor the restoration of the Bois-Marie school. It sought public support for a Fields medalist who described himself as mathematically isolated.

The sketch's proposal for tame topology reveals an enduring method. General topology admitted phenomena too wild for the geometry he wanted to control. Rather than exclude pathologies one by one, he sought categories of spaces stable under gluing, stratification, tubular neighborhoods, fibrations, and isotopy. The proposal remained incomplete. Its significance lies in the attempt to choose a world whose native operations match the questions, as schemes and topoi had done in different settings.

Récoltes et Semailles began in June 1983 and expanded through 1986. There was no single finished book suddenly present at the end of composition. Movements acquired notes; provisional fascicles circulated; letters produced supplements; later preliminary texts reorganized the entrance; digital surrogates omitted portions; published editions created new textual objects. The work's changing state is part of its history.

The title joins harvest and seed. Reaping gathers mathematical work, relationships, conflicts, institutions, and the consequences of earlier choices. Sowing addresses a future the writer cannot control. The agricultural language changes the temporal form of mathematical autobiography. A theorem can be printed as if detached from discovery; a harvest carries labor, season, inheritance, and the uncertainty of what will grow from the seed.

The work calls itself reflections and testimony on a past as a mathematician, and its genres exceed ordinary autobiography. Mathematical history, personal recollection, ethical meditation, polemic, self-analysis, correspondence, and recursive commentary occupy the same structure. This makes it indispensable and hazardous. It is direct evidence of Grothendieck's language and his judgment in the 1980s. It is not independent proof of every event recalled or accusation made.

One of its most valuable contributions is an account of mathematical creation that resists both command and prestige. The figure of the child names the capacity to ask an elementary question without shame and to remain with it before convention supplies an answer. The contrasting figure of the boss names the internalized demand for rank, possession, and control of appearances. These are textual figures, not psychiatric entities. They organize moral reflection and should not be converted into diagnoses.

The child can become another heroic myth if removed from community. Montpellier supplied the story of solitary reconstruction, but Nancy supplied mentors and questions. EGA required Dieudonné. SGA required expositors and editors. A private insight becomes mathematics through definitions, examples, counterexamples, proof, criticism, and transmission. Solitude may protect attention; it cannot by itself create public validity.

The manuscript's controversy concerns what happens after ideas are given. Grothendieck believed that former students and colleagues had failed to credit, publish, or continue parts of his work and had participated in a burial of his mathematical person. He also examined his own vanity and the wish to possess creation. The result oscillates between gift and ownership. If a giver retains control over every future use, the gift becomes conditional. If recipients detach an idea from the people and conditions that produced it, circulation can become erasure.

There is no universal accounting rule that resolves every case. A person who proposes a theorem and a person who proves it have different claims. A student who turns prenotes into a rigorous exposition performs authorship even when the program came from a teacher. A field may stop repeating a name because an idea has become grammar, but tacit attribution can disappear for later readers. A recipient remains free to choose another research life. Intellectual gratitude requires honesty; it does not establish permanent obedience.

This biography therefore separates credit from continuation and both from friendship. A missing citation, an abandoned program, a delayed seminar volume, and a broken personal relation are not the same ethical act. *Récoltes et Semailles* often joins them under one moral weather. Historical analysis must take the judgment seriously enough to disaggregate it.

The book's length and recurrence produce further difficulties. Return can expose a new layer of self-correction or demonstrate that an earlier account failed to settle the writer's concern. It can also amplify grievance and pressure the reader toward the author's diagnosis. Severe editing might make the work more accessible while removing the temporal evidence Grothendieck valued. A critical edition has to decide how to preserve sequence, notes, variants, and contradiction without treating every repetition as sacred.

The material labor again matters. Typescripts, fair copies, handwritten correction, duplication, address lists, and mailing carried a solitary voice to roughly two hundred recipients in differing configurations. Secretarial and institutional reproduction work did not authorize the claims, but without it the testimony would not have circulated in legible form. The work that criticizes collective mathematics was itself transmitted through a small collective infrastructure.

Pursuing Stacks offers another form of expansion. Its prehistory lies in correspondence with Ronald Brown, Philip Higgins, Larry Breen, Tim Porter, and others concerned with higher

groupoids and forms of the van Kampen theorem. A request for contact and an exchange of letters became a manuscript distributed in installments during 1983, last dated in November of that year. It was written in English because the correspondence through which it grew was conducted in English.

The title is partly misleading. Some sections directly address stacks, but much of the manuscript pursues homotopy types, higher groupoids, test categories, localizers, model structures, and coherence. Grothendieck himself described the foundational investigation as an unforeseen digression. The digression became the principal work because higher stacks require trustworthy models for the higher homotopical data they are meant to glue.

A groupoid retains several base points and invertible paths among them. A higher groupoid also retains homotopies between paths and further layers of comparison. Composition then holds through coherent higher data rather than strict equality. Grothendieck's homotopy hypothesis and his search for test categories asked which such models faithfully present homotopy types. In 1983 these were guiding programs requiring adequate definitions and comparison theorems, not one completed formalism.

The manuscript did not contain all of modern higher or derived geometry. Later mathematicians supplied models, coherence theorems, representability results, and applications in frameworks with their own histories. Grothendieck articulated powerful questions and strategies. Georges Maltsiniotis, Denis-Charles Cisinski, and many others developed parts of the homotopical program. Modern higher categories and higher topoi were built through further work associated with numerous authors. A precursor is honored most accurately when the future is not placed inside his pages as completed possession.

The mode of circulation shaped reception. Photocopies moved through permission-based personal networks. Definitions remained provisional; errors remained visible; recipients could answer. There was no publisher fixing pagination or guaranteeing that two readers held the same state. Informal circulation can move ideas quickly and preserve the openness of discovery. It can also make priority, correction, access, and citation fragile.

During the same years, spiritual attention and mathematical work overlapped. Grothendieck's interest in dreams did not begin after mathematics ended. *La Longue Marche*, *Pursuing Stacks*, the Faltings letter, *Esquisse*, and the beginning of *Récoltes et Semailles* occupied years in which he was also interpreting dreams and enlarging a personal religious vocabulary. The chronology resists a clean division between rational work and spiritual turn.

A scholarly chronology dates *La Clef des Songes* to 1987, and the BnF reports a corrected typescript. Exact place and start, item-level sequence, completeness, chapter count, pagination, and quotation rights await examination of the authenticated archival object. The publicly described text presents Grothendieck's conviction that dreams came from a figure he called the Dreamer and identified with God; this is evidence of his stated belief, not verification of its supernatural claim.

The opposite reduction is diagnosis. Religious conviction, long writing, polemic, seclusion, and unusual cosmology do not by themselves establish a medical condition. No retrospective clinical label should replace description of the text. Claims can be criticized, contradictions shown, and standards of warrant compared without pretending to examine a patient through prose.

Dream interpretation and mathematical discovery share formal descriptions in Grothendieck's writing: attention to material not yet understood, patience with resistance, the arrival of a relation that reorganizes details, and writing as an instrument of discovery. Their warrants remain different. A proof is public and rule-governed; another competent reader can

inspect each inference. A revelation may be personally compelling and not reproducible by another reader. Similarity of experience does not make dreams proofs or proofs revelations.

CNRS and BnF accounts, read with Grothendieck's April 1988 letter, place the research position from October 1984 to pension retirement in October 1988; personnel-file confirmation of the effective dates remains open. Retirement removed teaching and then institutional research status while writing continued. That year brought a final major public refusal. The Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences awarded the Crafoord Prize jointly to Grothendieck and Deligne. On April 19, Grothendieck declined it in a letter later published in *Le Monde*.

His stated reasons should govern the account. He considered his salary and approaching pension sufficient, criticized the concentration of money and prestige among established researchers, argued that time rather than honors tests an idea's fertility, and condemned what he saw as a decline in scientific ethics. The letter proves that he made these arguments. It does not prove every accusation about the community. Deligne accepted his share. Their different acts require no invented exchange.

The contrast with 1966 is real. Grothendieck did not attend the Moscow ceremony but did not then issue an explicit refusal of the Fields Medal. In 1988 he refused the Crafoord Prize with reasons. The intervening twenty-two years changed his relation to recognition. Those reasons are documented; a hidden inner conversion is unnecessary.

Mathematical correspondence and large projects continued after administrative retirement. The manuscript known as *Les Dérivateurs* is reported by editors as an extensive work from 1990–1991, but exact extent, chapter structure, priority claims, and author-final status remain dependent on editorial descriptions that require further archive-level verification. Open letters from 1991 independently establish continuing technical thought and selective exchange. This book prefers the narrow fact to the maximal claim.

Silence, archive, and afterlife

Grothendieck moved to Lasserre in the Ariège in 1991. The exact arrival day is not established. Public and professional accessibility diminished drastically. "Seclusion" accurately describes his withdrawal from conferences, ordinary publication, broadly available correspondence, and a public address, while documented visits, letters, and practical relations continued.

Later documents make the limit visible. Papers were transferred. Letters were sent. A substantial manuscript sequence continued through the 1990s. In 2010, a declaration reached Luc Illusie with a request that it be circulated. Every act implies material and human infrastructure without restoring public life. Withdrawal controlled channels; it did not suspend dependence on roads, postal service, archives, and other people.

This book calls the place a village rather than a hermitage. A village is an inhabited civic place with roads, services, property, and neighbors. Hermitage imports a spiritual role; disappearance denies documented contact. The exact house, household routine, and local witnesses are not narrative trophies. Privacy remains relevant after death, especially where family members, neighbors, care workers, and correspondents would be exposed only because they were near a famous person.

The move did not cause the enlarged late cosmology. A scholarly chronology places *La Clef des Songes* among the late manuscripts of Grothendieck's retirement period. Questions of dreams, psyche, creation, God, mathematics, activism, and solitude were already coexisting. Lasserre altered conditions of access and circulation. Geography cannot be made to explain every idea that followed.

The Bibliothèque nationale de France dates the large sequence *Réflexions sur la Vie et le Cosmos* from 1992 to 1999 and describes forty-one volumes. Named components include

writing on elementary schematic geometry, psyche, Maxwell's equations, creation, and the problem of evil. The scale is extraordinary and epistemically neutral. Forty-one volumes do not constitute one conclusion; thousands of pages do not make an argument true.

The crossing of disciplines is itself a historical fact. Mathematical diagrams and structural vocabulary enter reflections on psychology, physics, cosmology, and theology. The crossing must be read page by page. A formal pattern used as analogy does not provide mathematical proof in another domain. A physicist, historian of religion, philosopher, or clinician may ask questions different from those of an algebraic geometer. Grothendieck's competence in one field does not automatically transfer authority to all others.

Dismissal is equally inadequate. A mathematical habit can shape serious thought outside mathematics without turning it into theorem. The historian must identify whether a diagram serves as analogy, proposed model, notation, or deduction; which premises support it; and what kind of criticism applies. The late corpus deserves readers competent in its several domains, not a single verdict borrowed from fame.

The cataloged sequence reaches 1999. Grothendieck lived for another fifteen years. That endpoint belongs to a surviving archival body, not necessarily to writing or thought. The record used here does not authorize a daily chronology after the catalog stops. Press anecdotes, sightings, private testimony, and retrospective interpretations must meet a higher threshold because the subject had withdrawn and the people around him did not volunteer to become scenery.

Silence is relational. To the mathematical profession, there were no regular papers, seminars, or conference interventions. To a manuscript page, there could be sustained work. To a correspondent, there might be a letter. To a biographer, silence means the absence of adequate evidence for a claim, not a discovered emotional state. It cannot be translated without support into shame, hostility, serenity, illness, holiness, or despair.

According to a publicly circulated facsimile and draft transcription, a covering letter dated January 3, 2010, transmitted a *Déclaration d'intention de non-publication*. The public text opposes unauthorized dissemination across scientific and personal writing, print and electronic media, letters, translations, and substantial extracts, while allowing brief quotation. The original has not been authenticated or compared phrase by phrase for this account, so this summary is attributed rather than offered as a close translation.

The declaration concerns intention, authorization, and withdrawal from circulation rather than a command to destroy unique manuscripts. Its temporal language cannot by itself decide posthumous rights, and its legal effect depends on records for particular works, contracts, succession, and transfers.

An earlier institutional finding aid attributes to Jean Malgoire the statement that Grothendieck destroyed some nonmathematical papers around the first transfer of mathematical material. It supplies neither a complete inventory nor a dramatic scene. This is distinct from the 2010 request to remove editions from circulation, and both are distinct from later archival preservation. Combining them into a wish to burn everything falsifies the record.

The declaration also exposes a paradox of public refusal. To limit circulation, Grothendieck had to circulate the limit. To oppose publication, he produced a text intended to be copied through an old mathematical network. The paradox requires no diagnosis. It is the ordinary dependence of refusal on an audience capable of honoring it.

Libraries can preserve an object while placing different conditions on consultation, reproduction, quotation, and publication. The layers matter: preservation keeps the page; a catalog makes it findable; permission governs a proposed use.

Grothendieck died on November 13, 2014, in the Ariège. The exact civil and medical details beyond the established public record remain subject to unresolved documentation, and no final scene is supplied. A death date does not authorize a hospital-room reconstruction, last thought, or reconciliation. The life ends where the evidence permits. The archive continues because custody has changed.

Death altered the papers before it altered their interpretation. Materials that had belonged to a living author with strong and sometimes prohibitive intentions became the concern of children, legatees, custodians, archivists, librarians, editors, mathematicians, rights holders, and readers. These actors do not possess the same authority. A repository can number a leaf without settling whether its argument is correct. An editor can make a text readable without acquiring the right to expose every person named in it. A mathematician can verify a proof without resolving the ethics of publication.

There is no single Grothendieck archive. One substantial mathematical corpus, covering much of the period from 1949 to 1991, traveled through Jean Malgoire to the University of Montpellier. Official accounts differ on whether Grothendieck entrusted material in 1990 alone or in stages in 1990 and 1995. They agree on institutional deposit in 2010. After inventory and conservation, digitization began in 2016. In May 2017, the university opened approximately 18,000 pages from a corpus described as approximately 28,000.

The difference between those approximate totals should not be called the secret remainder. Correspondence may involve third-party rights; materials may await processing; counting rules may change. A page can be a recto, a verso, a blank, an enclosure, or a reused sheet carrying two chronologies. Archival number, authorial page number, and digital image number are different things. The value of a digital portal lies not in visibility alone but in stable identifiers, sequence, provenance, and the ability to recover context.

The second major corpus entered the Bibliothèque nationale de France in late September 2023. The BnF describes the accession as a bequest by Grothendieck completed by a gift from his children. It includes the corrected typescript of *La Clef des Songes* and the forty-one-volume *Réflexions sur la Vie et le Cosmos*, estimated in public reports at roughly 30,000 pages. These figures and holdings must not be merged with Montpellier's. The two collections have distinct provenance, genres, catalog structures, and access regimes.

An archive does not speak when opened. Handwriting must be transcribed; dates distinguished as authorial or assigned; physical order compared with later arrangement; versions collated; mathematical claims checked; references opened; and private statements assessed for relevance and harm. A plan must not become a completed theorem. A polemic must not become an impartial account of another person's conduct. A corrected typescript may still be unfinished.

Archival order is itself evidence and intervention. Grothendieck organized some dossiers; Malgoire preserved material; university staff inventoried and scanned; BnF staff appraised and cataloged; digital interfaces sort; researchers request some units and ignore others. None of this discredits the record. It makes the chain of custody and selection part of what the historian must describe.

The posthumous editions add another layer. Editions of *Récoltes et Semailles* and *La Clef des Songes* make difficult texts available in new forms. The Société Mathématique de France's 2022 *Pursuing Stacks* is Volume I, covering sections 1–91 and 95–98; Volume II remains announced rather than independently cataloged as published. Each edition has a distinct scope and history. They have appeared through editorial and estate processes whose work-specific authorization records have not been inspected here, so their legal status is not inferred from publication. The 2010 declaration remains part of that history.

Public study has widened. Montpellier's archive supported exhibitions and research on mathematical work after 1973. The BnF and the Société mathématique de France convened a 2025 study day bringing activism, teaching, mathematics, autobiography, film, and late spiritual writing into one program. A mobile exhibition selected twelve panels from thousands of pages. Selection is not a defect if its purpose is stated. An exhibition, like a biography, is an argument about a route through material that remains larger than the route.

Mathematics meanwhile continued without waiting for a complete archive. Scheme theory became infrastructure. Sites, sheaves, descent, and six-operation formalisms traveled into new geometries. Stacks became routine in moduli and acquired higher and derived forms. Motives developed through several rigorous theories and persistent conjectures. Dessins, anabelian geometry, and Grothendieck–Teichmüller theory drew from the *Esquisse* while acquiring independent builders. Homotopy-theoretic programs from *Pursuing Stacks* entered research through later proofs, comparisons, and models.

The strongest evidence of legacy is not the atmospheric claim that Grothendieck is everywhere. It is a traceable relation. The Stacks Project provides a collaborative digital reference built on schemes, algebraic spaces, and stacks with its own maintainers and contributors. Voevodsky, Morel, and others constructed motivic homotopy and cohomology theories with theorems the earlier program did not contain. Toën, Vezzosi, Lurie, and many collaborators developed forms of derived and higher geometry. Scholze's work on perfectoid spaces, diamonds, and v-stacks uses sites, descent, étale cohomology, and functorial operations in settings whose mathematics belongs to Scholze and his contemporaries.

An influence sentence needs at least two verbs. Grothendieck proposed, formulated, organized, or supplied a language; another mathematician defined, proved, constructed, corrected, or extended. Giving the later verb to its proper subject does not diminish the earlier one. It prevents legacy from becoming annexation.

The same rule applies backward. Belyi's theorem remains Belyi's. Deligne's proof remains Deligne's. Serre's FAC and GAGA remain Serre's. Dieudonné's redaction remains intellectual labor. Weil's conjectures remain Weil's questions. Grothendieck's achievement is large enough to survive accurate boundaries.

How this book knows what it knows

A biography of Grothendieck faces an unusual imbalance. Administrative records give some dates and amounts exactly; family history may travel from oral report to novel, late meditation, and scholarly biography; a mathematical result may have separate oral, manuscript, seminar, fascicle, edition, and reception dates. The prose marks those differences instead of smoothing them away.

Five levels guide its assertions. A documentary fact rests on a record speaking within its competence. Attributed testimony names the person remembering. Corroborated reconstruction brings independent sources together and preserves disagreement. Interpretation identifies itself as a reading. Speculation directs research but stays outside factual narration. Documents and memories answer different questions: a government file may classify accurately and understand badly, while a memoir may preserve an experience no office recorded.

Unknown means that the warrant has reached its boundary. Family testimony about Sascha remains testimony where prison files are missing. An absent reply cannot prove that no reply existed; a catalog endpoint cannot date the end of writing; Moscow without a public explanation supplies an act but no certain motive. Scenes follow the same rule. Supported actions and objects can make a vivid narrative; invented weather, dialogue, interior thought, and final glances cannot.

Grothendieck's late writings carry two times at once. *Récoltes et Semailles* directly records his judgments in the 1980s and his retrospective account of earlier decades. *La Clef des Songes* records a spiritual self-understanding assigned by its scholarly chronology to 1987. Neither converts recollection into a contemporary record of childhood. A source chain also remains a chain: three books drawing from one interview do not become three witnesses.

The mathematical explanations begin with a problem and a concrete anchor, then give the minimum exact structure and the point where the image fails. A general reader should be able to identify the change of viewpoint and its consequence; a mathematician should be able to locate every suppressed condition. Metaphor opens a door, while definition determines what may pass through it. Mathematical ideas illuminate documented habits of work without diagnosing personality.

Historical language receives the same care. Modern definitions are identified as modern when period terminology differed. Seminar year, circulated fascicle, revised edition, and later reception keep separate dates. Program, theorem, proof, exposition, and editorship keep separate verbs. This is why the life cannot be organized as one rise and one renunciation: the IHÉS resignation, cessation of ordinary article publication, move to Montpellier, CNRS retirement, move to Lasserre, and 2010 declaration were different acts with different objects.

An immense archive sharpens rather than removes the limit. Page count measures paper, not the duration or importance of every relationship. Grothendieck selected, discarded, entrusted, retained, and ordered; Malgoire, university staff, BnF archivists, heirs, editors, and researchers added further acts of custody and selection. People named in those pages retain voices and privacy independent of the protagonist.

AI tools assisted with drafting, with the polishing and proofreading of the whole text, and with the search for, the verification and the organisation of the literature: they can compare wording, locate repetition, and test a sentence against the evidence supplied to them. They supply no human witness, mathematical expertise, archival authority, translation approval, or legal judgment. The conception of this biography, the design of its Parts and chapters and

of their content, and the direction of the writing are the author's; the author has reviewed the whole book and is responsible for its text.

The rising sea and its shore

Near the end, this book returns to an image associated with Grothendieck's description of mathematical work. The present route is Colin McLarty's secondary translation and analysis; the French passage and its mapping to an authorized edition have not been reopened, so no quotation or independent translation is printed here. In paraphrase, a resistant problem may be approached by enlarging the surrounding theory until the obstacle stands within a more natural landscape and the desired statement follows from the changed level. The rising sea belongs to that attributed mathematical image. The shore is this biography's counter-image.

The image illuminates patience, universality, and conceptual enlargement. Abelian categories made separate homological constructions instances of one grammar. Schemes made arithmetic and geometric fibers part of one relative world. Topoi made locality and sheaf theory portable beyond ordinary spaces. Motives proposed a source beneath several cohomologies. Higher structures sought to retain coherence that lower categories discard. In each case, a broader setting changed which questions appeared natural.

The image also conceals labor if left alone. A theory rises because named people write definitions, check a base-change hypothesis, find a counterexample, correct an exposé, type a fascicle, secure a journal budget, or maintain a digital reference. Its apparent inevitability is usually visible only afterward.

Biography can use context to dissolve a false opposition, but it cannot make a person the consequence of a theory. The shore marks where one kind of explanation stops and privacy, contradiction, or singular responsibility begins.

The state assigned names; family memory carried what registers omitted; seminars joined unequal forms of authority; resignation made principle costly; manuscripts survived their author; later mathematicians built beyond his programs. Grothendieck's mathematics enlarged the worlds in which problems could be seen, while his life exposed the limits of worlds made by states, universities, disciplines, prizes, movements, families, and archives.

After his death, access widened unevenly. Editions appeared under different conditions, repositories acquired distinct duties, mathematicians continued along paths with their own authors, and disputes about credit, privacy, and permission remained. The last movement of the book therefore returns to small, accountable acts. A leaf receives a shelfmark. A date is marked as authorial or assigned. A conjecture is separated from a theorem. A contested memory keeps the witness's name. A translation names its translator. A later proof keeps its author.

Vincent Liu
WiseMotif.ai
2026

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PART I

Before Belonging

Chapter 1

Before the Name

> *S'il a une prétention, c'est celle seulement d'être vrai. Et c'est beaucoup.*
>
> If this document has any pretension, it is only to be true. And that is a great deal.
>
> — Alexander Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, Promenade, §3 « L'aventure intérieure – ou mythe et témoignage »

A father of uncertain names

Scharlau reconstructs Grothendieck's father as born around 1889–1890, usually identified as Alexander or Sascha Schapiro and later documented as Alexander Tanaroff. No civil birth entry has been consulted for this chapter, and the surviving dates and surnames conflict. The paternal history therefore begins with a range and an attributed identity, not a repaired register.[1]

Novozybkov is the firmest element in that first cluster of facts. The town lay in the western borderlands of the Russian Empire, between Bryansk and Gomel, in a region whose later national descriptions shifted. It is now in Russia, close to Belarus and Ukraine. Old Believers had been important in its founding history, and by the beginning of the twentieth century it also had a substantial Jewish population. The exact demographic figures repeated in the online biography depend on web sources that have not been checked against a census record, so they are not needed here. What matters is narrower: Sasha was remembered as having been born there into a Jewish household, in a town where confessional identity and imperial administration had immediate civic consequences.[2]

Scharlau reports the family claim that Sasha came from a religious Hasidic household and that one grandfather had been a rabbi. No birth, synagogue, or school record inspected for this chapter independently establishes those particulars. Scharlau also reports a 1930 Berlin declaration made under Tanaroff and a privately held family photograph; neither can serve here as an untouched genealogy. Sasha's parents' occupations, his siblings if any, his schooling, and the language chiefly used at home remain unknown.[3]

Those blanks must not be filled with a stock picture of a Jewish borderland childhood. Novozybkov possessed markets, religious institutions, administrative offices, workshops, and factories, but such facts do not identify the street on which one family lived or the speech heard in its rooms. Sasha later spoke Russian and was remembered in Western Europe for a strong Russian accent. Hebrew script appeared on the reverse of one family photograph. German may have been accessible to him early, and Yiddish is possible. The traces do not

[1] Winfried Scharlau, *Who Is Alexander Grothendieck? Anarchy, Mathematics, Spirituality, Solitude. Part 1: Anarchy*, trans. Melissa Schneps (n.d.), chap. 1, https://webusers.imj-prg.fr/~leila.schneps/grothendieckcircle/Scharlau/Anarchy.pdf.

[2] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 1.

[3] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 1.

establish a single mother tongue. They show why the normal biographical shorthand—one place, one language, one name—would be misleading at the outset.

Two Alexander Schapiros

The documentary problem is intensified by another man. Alexander Schapiro, commonly called Sania, was a prominent anarcho-syndicalist organizer, editor, translator, and international activist. He was born in 1882, worked with well-known figures in the movement, took part in conferences, and left extensive records. Grothendieck's father did not. Both men passed through some of the same cities and political networks, and both could be called Sasha Shapiro. As a result, later accounts transferred episodes from the better-documented organizer to the less-documented refugee. Scharlau's separation of the two biographies is therefore not a minor correction of spelling. It removes an archive that never belonged to Grothendieck's father.[4]

The distinction changes the evidentiary scale of everything that follows. A congress list naming Sania cannot prove Sasha's attendance. A memoir referring to an international organizer cannot be made into evidence for a teenage militant from Novozybkov. Even Grothendieck apparently learned only late that two men had been conflated. His recollections of what he had heard about his father were sincere testimony, but sincerity cannot identify the subject of an ambiguous record. The more famous names surrounding the movement—Peter Kropotkin, Emma Goldman, Alexander Berkman, Nestor Makhno—must not be used to promote Sasha retrospectively into their documented company.

Arrest and imprisonment

The chief account of Sasha's adolescence reached the archive by a long route. Sasha told parts of his history to Hanka during their years together. Hanka incorporated those accounts into *Eine Frau*, an autobiographical novel written much later, with pseudonyms, reconstructed speech, and literary shaping. Their son revisited the same past in *Récoltes et Semailles* and especially *La Clef des Songes*, after reading family papers and interpreting his parents through concerns of the 1980s. Scharlau then compared those narratives with the surviving documents he could locate. Each layer is valuable, but none converts the family story into a contemporaneous court file.[5]

In later family accounts, Sasha left home as an adolescent to join anarchists, was arrested as a teenager, condemned to death, and had the sentence commuted because of his age. No contemporaneous court or prison file examined for this review establishes the charge, date, group, trial, or act of commutation. The attempted-assassination claim concerning Nicholas II is excluded.[6]

The absence of a file does not make the entire testimony worthless. It changes its grammar. The claim belongs to what Sasha's family later said, not to what an imperial record has yet established. His missing left arm, his years in prison, and his later account of the injury form a more strongly supported core; dates, dialogue, and the exact charge are weaker. Biography

[4] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 2; Ching-Li Chai and Frans Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," *Notices of the International Congress of Chinese Mathematicians* 5, no. 1 (2017): sec. 1.3, https://www2.math.upenn.edu/~chai/AG/ChaiFO9-AG.pdf.

[5] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 3–6.

[6] Alexandre Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles: Réflexions et témoignage sur un passé de mathématicien*, ed. Mateo Carmona (1985), 603–8, Manuscript, https://webusers.imj-prg.fr/~leila.schneps/grothendieckcircle/RetSbis.pdf. These are retrospective family accounts, not a contemporaneous judicial file.

can retain that hierarchy without deciding that every transmitted detail is either literal fact or invention.

The Russia in which the story was placed had undergone the revolution of 1905. Military defeat by Japan compounded rural distress, industrial conflict, demands for political reform, and long opposition to autocratic rule. On Bloody Sunday, imperial forces fired on petitioners in Saint Petersburg. Strikes, mutinies, peasant uprisings, and political organization spread. The October Manifesto promised civil liberties and a representative assembly, but repression returned as the revolutionary movement weakened. Anti-Jewish pogroms accompanied the crisis, supported or tolerated by forces allied with monarchy and the established order. This background makes an adolescent's attraction to revolutionary politics historically intelligible. It does not tell us which meeting Sasha attended, which weapon he carried, or which violence he witnessed.[7]

Anarchism itself cannot serve as a single explanatory label. The movement contained advocates of syndicalism, education, mutual aid, insurrection, and armed struggle, divided over organization and the use of violence. Its shared negative principle was opposition to coercive hierarchy, especially the authority claimed by the state; its positive vocabularies included voluntary association, workers' self-organization, and freedom from domination. Sasha later identified himself as an anarchist and revolutionary. The surviving evidence shows a durable allegiance, not a systematic doctrine written in his own hand.

At this point, the temptation to turn the adolescent into the finished political man must be resisted. The sources do not reveal the arguments in his parents' home, the sequence by which he encountered anarchist ideas, or his private reasons for leaving. His Jewish origin, borderland birthplace, and the upheavals of 1905 are conditions around the act, not a sufficient causal account. The record begins to follow him only after family narration places him inside repression. What preceded that moment remains largely silent.

No verified conviction year or commutation instrument has been located. Hanka's autobiographical narrative places part of the imprisonment at Yaroslavl; that location has not been checked against a prison register.[8]

The family narrative says that Sasha was shot during an escape attempt and that his left arm was amputated. The amputation is visible in later photographs; the age, attempted suicide, pursuit, wounds, and surgical sequence remain mediated family testimony rather than a verified prison record.[9]

Other particulars from the prison years remain similarly graded. He was said to have attempted escape more than once, to have spent about a year in isolation in 1914, and to have joined hunger strikes to obtain the treatment accorded political prisoners. Prison libraries, supplied in part by sympathetic members of the intelligentsia, became an important means of education. *Eine Frau* names another political prisoner with whom he formed an attachment, but that person has not been independently identified. Dialogue assigned to prison officials, comrades, or Sasha himself comes through the novel and is not reproduced here. The broad outline is one of confinement, resistance, injury, and self-education; the precise episodes await primary records.[10]

The shaved head by which Sasha later became recognizable belonged to this history. Prison authorities shaved inmates as a disciplinary mark. According to the explanation Hanka preserved, some released prisoners continued the practice and turned a sign intended

[7] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 3.
[8] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 4. Prison particulars derive principally from later family testimony.
[9] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 4. Prison particulars derive principally from later family testimony.
[10] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 4. Prison particulars derive principally from later family testimony.

to humiliate them into one they chose for themselves. After the injury, Sasha also lost much of his hair for a time. Photographs support the later appearance, while the meaning comes from reported speech in *Eine Frau*. It is possible to describe the act as a reclaimed sign because the source attributes that explanation to him. It would be a further, unsupported step to make the habit a complete key to his character.[11]

The same limit applies to education. Sasha reportedly regarded prison libraries as the place where he learned literature and formed ambitions as a writer. There is no syllabus, borrowing record, or surviving prison notebook. His later wish to write a history of the revolution is attested by Hanka and Grothendieck, and two short political articles would eventually appear under the name Sasha-Piotr. These later traces make the claim of serious literary aspiration credible. They do not tell us what he read in a particular year or permit a list of influences to be invented.[12]

Revolution and civil war

Release came during the revolutions of 1917. Whether it followed the February Revolution or occurred later is unresolved. Political prisoners were freed amid the collapse of imperial authority, and Sasha entered a landscape in which the institutions that had confined him were themselves being dismantled, replaced, or captured by competing powers. He had spent most of the normal years of education and early employment in prison. Once outside, according to every family account, he treated revolutionary work not as a temporary reaction but as his vocation.[13]

Grothendieck later wrote that his father led an armed anarchist group in contact with Makhno's movement. Scharlau found no contemporaneous roster or operational record confirming the account; Sasha's exact role remains unknown. Hanka's civil-war scenes are literary testimony and do not establish a named brigade, operation, rank, or battle.[14]

The absence is not surprising in itself. Ukraine between 1917 and 1921 was crossed by forces loyal to the Bolsheviks, White generals, Ukrainian governments and national movements, Germany and Austria-Hungary, Poland, peasant formations, anarchist detachments, and local armed groups. Alliances shifted. Cities could change hands repeatedly, and civilian populations endured requisition, displacement, and pogroms. Makhno's movement developed a formidable military organization around Huliaipole, fought occupation and White forces, cooperated tactically with the Red Army, and was then suppressed by the Bolsheviks. A mobile anarchist group could disappear from major narratives. That possibility is not evidence that Sasha commanded one.

Rachil and Dodek

Scharlau reports photographs and letters supporting the existence of Rachil and her son Dodek, whom the family associated with Sasha. Their exact birth dates, marital status, and domestic chronology have not been established from original civil records. Reconstructed conversations in *Eine Frau* remain literary testimony.[15]

Later family accounts also allege another Bolshevik imprisonment, death sentence, and escape. No official record examined here establishes that sequence or the named helpers. By

[11] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 4. Prison particulars derive principally from later family testimony.
[12] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 4 and 7.
[13] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 4–5.
[14] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 5. No contemporaneous roster or operational record was identified.
[15] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 6; Centre for Grothendieckian Studies, "Correspondence," https://csg.igrothendieck.org/correspondence/.

1921 Sasha had left while Rachil and Dodek remained; correspondence reported by Scharlau suggests later contact but does not establish motive, support, or the terms of separation.

Scharlau reports that Hanka's novel summarizes a 1926 letter describing imprisonment and deprivation, and that photographs and later letters survived among Sasha's papers. Because the underlying correspondence has not been consulted here, the camp history, dates, support, and eventual fates of Rachil and Dodek remain unverified.[16]

Rachil and Dodek should not be reduced to casualties in a prehistory that belongs to someone else. Their presence discloses the human cost of a political life built around movement. Sasha argued, in the mediated sources, that revolutionaries should not be captured by conventional family claims. He nevertheless formed attachments and fathered a child whose care fell chiefly to a woman left in Russia. It is fair to put those facts together. It is not fair to invent his thoughts at departure, to attribute Rachil's later persecution solely to him without an official record, or to treat her suffering as proof of what he intended.

The surviving photographs complicate the tendency of narrative to make flight look like a clean break. A person could leave a household and continue to carry its images; a child could be absent from daily life and remain present in correspondence. Those objects do not prove regular support or sustained intimacy, but they prevent the relation from being described as simple disappearance. In the papers later examined by Grothendieck, Rachil and Dodek belonged to the father's continuing history. Their own voices reached the son only as fragments written in a language and situation not his own.

The later search for Dodek also shows how uncertainty can cross generations. Grothendieck did not transform a few letters into a claim that he knew his brother. He acknowledged the opposite: the tangible signs were old photographs and correspondence, and his attempt to find a living trace failed. That failed inquiry is a biographical fact. Dodek's fate is not. The distinction is especially important in a family history repeatedly exposed to imprisonment, war, and genocide, where silence can invite the most catastrophic inference. No such inference should be promoted to fact without evidence.

One chain of testimony

Absence from major Makhnovist histories does not prove that Sasha never fought, but incomplete histories cannot establish command. The bounded conclusion is that the family associated his post-1917 armed activity with Makhno while its scale and operational nature remain unknown.

The story of prison poses the reverse problem. Several later sources repeat the same episodes, but they are not fully independent. Grothendieck drew on what his mother told him and on papers from the same household. Hanka drew on Sasha's narrated past. Scharlau drew on both. Three texts do not become three witnesses when their information travels down one chain. The visible amputation and administrative use of Tanaroff add independent support to parts of the story; they do not corroborate the alleged charge or every escape attempt.

Such source dependence affects tone. "Sasha later said" is stronger and more accurate than an unmarked account of a scene. "The family remembered" preserves a claim without making a modern narrator its guarantor. "No record has been located in the available record" is not an insinuation that the event did not happen. These formulations may interrupt the smoothness expected of heroic biography, but the interruptions reproduce the actual state of knowledge.

[16] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 6; Centre for Grothendieckian Studies, "Correspondence".

Flight west under a new name

Another young woman, Lia, was associated with his flight west. The family account places her at the crossing of the Russian-Polish frontier and says that her younger sister accompanied him toward Gdańsk. Her place of origin and the details of the journey are uncertain. In Minsk, Sasha was said to have met Alexander Berkman and received money for the onward route. Berkman's published record confirms his presence in the broader itinerary but does not mention Sasha. The meeting therefore remains a family claim, plausible in time and place but not independently confirmed.[17]

The papers carried on that journey named him Tanaroff. Hanka later explained that a comrade altered the Cyrillic surname on existing papers as well as the letters permitted. Scharlau consulted Yuri Manin, who observed that the resulting name did not sound naturally Russian. The proposed manipulation is possible but unproved. Usage is the secure fact: Sasha lived under Tanaroff from 1921, appeared under it in later German and French documents, and was eventually deported under it. An assumed identity was not a detachable fiction. It became the legal name by which states tracked his life.

The Grothendiecks of Hamburg

The maternal archive has a different texture. Scharlau's reconstruction from civil and church records places the Grothendieck family in northern Germany across several generations. He reads Albert Ernst Hermann Grothendieck's birth entry as January 3, 1871 and identifies the family as Lutheran; the original certificate has not been consulted for this chapter. Albert later moved to Rostock and worked in the beer trade.[18]

In Scharlau's reconstruction, Albert's first marriage in 1894 produced a daughter, Eleonore, known as Nora; after he was widowed, he married Anna Luise Lisette Johanna Demmin on February 23, 1900. Scharlau gives Anna's birth date as June 1, 1872 and traces her to a Mecklenburg family of farmers, innkeepers, and a blacksmith. His reading of marriage and baptismal records identifies both lines as Protestant, contrary to secondary claims of Jewish ancestry on Hanka's side.[19]

Scharlau gives August 21, 1900 in Hamburg as the birth date and place of Johanna Frida Elisabeth Grothendieck. She later appeared as Hanna and Hanka in different documentary and social settings. These variations were not equivalent to Sasha's altered identity papers, but they warn against treating one spelling as the whole life.[20]

Her childhood did not begin in uninterrupted poverty. Near the turn of the century, Albert owned or managed the Rathaus Hotel in Altona, close to the town hall. Photographs and business recollections describe a substantial establishment with employees and an all-woman orchestra. The family occupied the respectable middle-class world of hospitality, servants, commercial display, and social aspiration. That position later became the "before" in Hanka's account of a prolonged fall.[21]

No single cause accounts for the decline. Family memory emphasized Albert's concern with status and his interest in horse racing. The records and recollections also point to disadvantageous leases, alleged fraud by others, Anna's medical expenses, the First World War, economic crisis, and inflation. After the hotel came a rented tavern and, from about 1911, a tourist café on the Süllberg above the Elbe. Albert sometimes returned to wage work as a

[17] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 5–7.
[18] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 8.
[19] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 8.
[20] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 11.
[21] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 8.

Figure 1. Hamburg within the German Empire of 1871.
Milenioscuro · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

waiter during winter. The contrast between receiving guests as proprietor and serving them as an employee carried particular force in family recollection, but it should not be converted into a scene whose witnesses and words are unknown.

The household contracted as the enterprises failed. During the inflationary period Albert obtained a concession connected with shoe-shine stands and public lavatories at Hamburg's railway station, then lost it. He took short-lived work as a guard, packer, painter, and waiter, and later sold fish with one of his sons. A successful legal claim eventually provided enough compensation to buy a modest property in Fuhlsbüttel. His career was irregular, but it was not simply a story of personal ruin. It also belonged to the destruction of small businesses, savings, and social positions in Germany through war and monetary collapse.[22]

Anna's experience is harder to recover independently. Hanka's novel depicted a sensitive woman worn down by illness, pregnancy, domestic labor, diminishing resources, and a difficult marriage. A nephew later remembered her with respect but offered little detail. The novel is indispensable for how Hanka came to understand her mother; it cannot prove every incident or assign blame. In particular, later speculation about a sexual dimension in the relationship between Hanka and her father is unsupported and unnecessary. It does not belong in a factual narrative.[23]

The economic decline affected Hanka's education. She attended a lyceum but left when the fees could no longer be sustained. At seventeen she began training as a kindergarten teacher and did not finish. Beyond those facts, her motives become less secure. *Eine Frau* represented an early estrangement from family authority, dissatisfaction with bourgeois convention, periods of travel, acting lessons, poems, prose, and plans connected with the artists' colony at Worpswede. These details may follow her experience closely; they were still shaped by a writer looking backward. No single humiliation or parental conflict should be assigned as the cause of her politics.[24]

[22] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 8.
[23] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 8.
[24] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 11.

Reform circles and the stage

Her search crossed several institutions rather than following one ideological line. The Freideutsche Jugend offered one form of generational and cultural revolt. The Fichte-Hochschule, an adult-education setting with a nationalist as well as reformist environment, provided another. Hanka met artists, teachers, religious dissenters, and political activists. She experimented with ways of living before she acquired a stable party affiliation, and Scharlau's research states that she never became a member of the German Communist Party. Her later anarchist milieu should not be projected backward as if every earlier association were a step toward it.[25]

Around 1920 and 1921, she took part in Lothar Schreyer's experimental *Kampfbühne*. Schreyer's later memoir remembered "Hannah Grothendiek," misspelling the name, performing a sustained maternal lament in his expressionist work *Kreuzigung*. This independent recollection places her in a documented theatrical enterprise. The *Kampfbühne* treated voice, rhythm, mask, gesture, and spiritual conflict as material, rejecting ordinary naturalistic representation. Hanka's participation does not make her a major figure in Expressionism. It establishes that the ambition to write and perform, later so prominent in family memory, had a public basis.[26]

The theater connected her to one of the period's attempts to invent new forms of collective life. It also exposed the risks of reading art as autobiography. A performed lament does not tell us what the performer felt. An expressionist role does not reveal an inner essence. The historical claim concerns employment, participation, and artistic milieu. Interpretation begins only after those facts and must remain bounded by them.

Der Pranger

Hanka's work with *Der Pranger* brought another kind of public record. The Hamburg weekly was associated with women subjected to the city's regulation of prostitution and was founded by the communist activist Ketty Guttmann. It addressed police and medical control, exploitation, abortion, contraception, unemployment, violence, and the terms by which women were described as administrative problems. Hanka worked for the paper in an editorial and practical capacity. Because most articles were unsigned, the prose cannot be distributed among contributors merely by guessing at style.[27]

Scharlau reports that issue 15 in 1920 attributed the poem "Großstadtnächte" to Hanka and that publication led to confiscation and a prosecution ending in acquittal. The original issue and trial file have not been inspected for this chapter; the poem, unsigned prose, and courtroom language are therefore neither quoted nor independently attributed.[28]

The label "journalist," if left unexplained, would make this precarious activity resemble a settled profession. The evidence supports intermittent editorial labor, advocacy, and publication. Scharlau reports that Hanka wrote to authorities on behalf of people in difficulty. It does not establish a continuous salary, newsroom position, or recognized career. Calling her a writer is faithful to an aspiration she repeatedly claimed, but the material conditions of writing—paper, postage, a room, time, food, and paid work—remained unstable.

Her relation to the women for whom *Der Pranger* spoke also requires proportion. Hanka entered as a young outsider, not as someone whose experience was identical to theirs. The

[25] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 11.
[26] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 11.
[27] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 11.
[28] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 11.

paper contested a system in which police and medical authorities classified women and supervised their bodies. Her willingness to work there can be described as solidarity. The possibility of inexperience or self-dramatization does not erase that work, and admiration for it should not erase the distance between the reformer and women who survived the trade.

The difference between signed and unsigned writing is central here. An unsigned paper can document the concerns, vocabulary, and political environment in which an editor worked without proving that she composed a given sentence. Hanka's attributed poem carries a narrower authorship claim and a clearer legal consequence. The rest of the issue belongs to a collective publication. Assigning its strongest articles to her because they fit a later portrait would repeat, on a smaller scale, the error by which the other Alexander Shapiro's record was added to Sasha's life.

The forms of theater and newspaper also answered different kinds of authority. Schreyer's stage broke with naturalistic representation through disciplined sound, movement, and mask. *Der Pranger* challenged the administrative language imposed on women whose bodies were policed. Hanka participated in both undertakings at the level the sources permit. It is reasonable to see a continuity in her attraction to forms that contested respectable representation. It would be too strong to claim that she announced such a theory or followed a deliberate program from one institution to the other.

Her work belonged to the economic world already visible in her family's decline. Cultural ambition did not remove the need for fees, rent, meals, clothes, travel, and time. The hotel's collapse and the shrinking household were not decorative background to a rebellious personality; they narrowed available education and made artistic labor harder to sustain. Conversely, poverty does not explain every unfinished course or abandoned plan. Family resources, public crisis, temperament, relationships, and choice acted together, and the archive cannot assign each a percentage.

Hanka's mother and the women of *Der Pranger* occupied very different social positions, but both histories exposed the legal and material constraints inside conventional accounts of female virtue. Anna's work in a declining household was rendered largely private. The women addressed by the paper were made intensely public through registration and police control. Hanka's own movement between family, stage, newspaper, and irregular lodging crossed those divisions without abolishing them. That movement helps locate her historically; it does not authorize claims about an inherited psychology.

Two archives, two corrections

The family's Protestant records also require care. Correcting the unsupported assertion of maternal Jewish ancestry should not make baptismal affiliation into a full account of belief. A certificate shows how a church and civil system classified a person. It does not disclose private observance, doubt, or later conviction. Hanka's eventual hostility to religious authority and Sasha's reported atheism belong to their adult positions, but neither can be projected back into every member of the previous generation.

Albert's erratic commercial career is similarly vulnerable to retrospective caricature. Hanka's later account emphasized display, conflict, and failed enterprises. The documented sequence also shows repeated attempts to recover income after loss: hospitality, concessions, service work, small trades, and litigation. He eventually secured a modest property. Those actions do not invalidate the damage remembered by his family. They prevent the father from becoming only a bourgeois foil required by the daughter's story.

The mother's surviving profile is fainter because domestic labor generated fewer durable records. That archival imbalance must not be mistaken for a lesser role. Anna's pregnancies,

illness, household management, and dependence are present mainly through Hanka's representation and a relative's brief recollection. The biographer can state the scarcity and the conditions described. Furnishing her with thoughts, gestures, or a symbolic wisdom would conceal rather than repair the loss.

The two family archives therefore ask for different corrections. On the paternal side, political legend and mistaken identity can make a thin record look abundant. On the maternal side, regular civil documentation can make the record look complete while leaving domestic work, conflict, and aspiration largely unrecorded. Neither problem is solved by increasing narrative confidence. The first requires subtraction; the second requires an explicit account of what certificates do not contain.

Chronology supplies another correction. Sasha's childhood, imprisonment, release, armed activity, first family, and flight survive with wide or disputed dates. Hanka's line contains more exact births, marriages, businesses, and public undertakings. Placing the two in parallel should not imply that events with different precision occurred at matching intervals or caused one another. The chapter alternates between them because both histories are needed before their meeting, not because their lives advanced toward it in synchrony.

The difference is visible in the endpoints. Hanka met Alf around 1921 within a Hamburg milieu for which organizations and civil identities can be named. Sasha reached Berlin during 1921 after a route whose order is clearer than its dates. The sources even contain tension over whether his arrival preceded or followed a reported November encounter in Minsk. "By the end of 1921" is therefore more responsible than a month or half-year. A narrative transition should not conceal a chronological conflict.[29]

Precision also has an ethical dimension. A false exact date can make later inferences appear stronger than they are, especially when used to calculate age, responsibility, or sequence. An approximate date openly marked as such preserves what the sources support.

This distinction is already relevant to the child who had not yet been born. Later biographies often compress the parents into a pair of attributes: Russian-Jewish anarchist father, German Protestant writer mother. Both descriptions contain truth, but each hides changes of name, interrupted relationships, uneven evidence, and the practical work of survival. A category can orient the reader without exhausting the person it classifies. That proposition is historical before it is philosophical.

Papers, helpers, institutions

In 1921 the legal positions of the two adults could hardly have been more different. Hanka could reject German bourgeois norms while remaining legible to the German state through a birth record and family name. Sasha could profess a universal politics while presenting a document that concealed his origin and depended on officials accepting its surface. One crossed social boundaries within a state that recognized her; the other crossed territorial boundaries after states had made recognition precarious. Their later household would join these unequal forms of exposure.

The evidence also prevents a simple opposition between freedom and constraint. Hanka chose institutions that challenged convention, but economic decline repeatedly limited those choices. Sasha rejected coercive authority, but prisons and borders shaped his body and route. Both relied on networks of assistance. Comrades, relatives, editors, performers, and unnamed helpers supplied money, introductions, papers, or places to sleep. The biographies are not stories of autonomous individuals moving alone.

[29] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 5–7. Exact route dates and the Minsk/Berkman episode remain unverified.

Those helpers must remain unnamed where the sources leave them unnamed. A phrase such as "a comrade altered the papers" or "a student assisted the escape" can tempt the narrator to provide a motive, a relationship, or a later fate. The source supports an act and a role, not a completed character. Preserving anonymity is part of factual accuracy, especially when clandestine activity and later persecution may explain why the record is thin.

Institutions, by contrast, often appear with names but not with neutral purposes. A prison register, police declaration, church certificate, theater memoir, and prosecution file were created to do different kinds of work. They classified, punished, admitted, remembered, or defended. Their official status does not make every statement equally complete, just as the literary status of *Eine Frau* does not make every statement useless. Source criticism begins with purpose as well as date.

That principle will govern the chapters ahead. When a later document contradicts an earlier one, the book will not silently choose the form closest to the familiar biography. It will ask which institution created each form, what fact the form was designed to establish, and whether the records can refer to the same person. The discipline is already necessary before Alexander's birth because his parents' lives entered the archive through unequal systems.

By keeping those networks visible, the narrative avoids another retrospective distortion: the famous son need not confer significance on every person who preceded him. Rachil, Dodek, Anna, Albert, Nora, and participants in Hanka's theater and newspaper worlds had histories not reducible to preparing Alexander Grothendieck. Their inclusion is not genealogical ornament. It identifies the obligations, dependencies, and institutions that made the later family possible.

One reported crossing in this milieu points far ahead but cannot bear too much weight. Wilhelm Heydorn, a pastor in conflict with his church, may have appeared as a defense witness in proceedings connected with the paper. More than a decade later, the Heydorn household would receive Hanka's son. Scharlau found support for Heydorn's presence at a hearing but not for a continuous friendship between him and Hanka. The record permits an earlier institutional crossing, not a providential chain prepared for the child.[30]

By 1921, Hanka had moved through family decline, incomplete training, youth and reform circles, experimental theater, and an advocacy weekly. The sequence reveals repeated actions against expected roles. It does not disclose a single stable program. Artistic work and political work were not separate stages so much as overlapping attempts to find a form of speech that ordinary respectability denied. That interpretation is grounded in the institutions she joined; it is not a claim to know what she privately intended.

Hamburg and Berlin, 1921

In the same Hamburg milieu she met Johannes "Alf" Raddatz, born there on January 7, 1897. His father owned a machine-parts business and held Social Democratic convictions. Alf trained as a machinist and automobile mechanic, served in the First World War, and wrote occasional political or comic verse. His later affiliations and conduct belong to the next chapter, where the relationship became a household. At the 1921 boundary, the necessary fact is that Hanka had encountered the man she would marry, while Sasha was moving toward Germany under another man's name.[31]

By the end of 1921, Sasha had reached Berlin. The city had become a major point of passage for refugees from the former Russian Empire: writers, artists, former officials, political exiles, and activists moved through a metropolis already destabilized by military defeat, revolution,

[30] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 11 and 17.
[31] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 12.

and inflation. Anarchist networks organized meetings, publications, and aid for prisoners. Famous participants in those networks left clear documentary trails. Sasha's place among them remains thinner. The existence of the milieu must not be turned into proof that he attended every conference or knew every prominent exile.[32]

His refugee status depended on the document he carried. A state might regard him as a victim of Bolshevik persecution, a political risk, a bearer of false papers, or a person entitled to temporary protection. These classifications were not philosophical abstractions. They governed registration, work, and the ability to cross the next border. His opposition to state authority did not free him from state categories. On the contrary, stateless or precariously documented people met those categories at every office and checkpoint.

For Hanka, papers had so far performed a different function. They recorded birth, baptismal background, education, a father's businesses, theatrical participation, and a prosecution. Even when the family descended economically, it remained visible within German civil and commercial systems. Sasha's archive consisted more often of aliases, police attention, a declaration made under an assumed identity, and stories carried by people. The asymmetry between those archives is part of the history. It reflects unequal relations to citizenship, antisemitism, political policing, and border control.

That asymmetry also explains why "before the name" cannot mean before identity. Both lives were already crowded with names and classifications. Schapiro linked Sasha to Jewish origin but lacks a surviving birth record in the available record. Tanaroff enabled movement and became the name under which officials recognized him. Sasha was familiar usage; Sasha-Piotr would become a political byline. Johanna, Hanna, and Hanka marked different public and intimate forms within one documented family name. None is false in the same way, and none by itself tells the whole history.

Two prehistories

No principle of inheritance joins these two prehistories to algebraic geometry. The father's forged papers do not explain the son's later concern with objects and their presentations. The mother's resistance to convention does not explain mathematical abstraction. Such parallels are available only after the fact and can easily become a myth of destiny. The proper work of these pages is prior and more modest: to establish which people and institutions existed, which sources speak, where their claims conflict, and what remains unknown.

Nor do the parents' later reputations settle their earlier lives. Sasha's endurance under imprisonment cannot absolve choices that imposed costs on Rachil and Dodek. The absence of a military record does not prove that his family invented every revolutionary episode. Hanka's unfinished projects do not cancel her verified participation in theater and print. Her literary shaping does not make *Eine Frau* useless; it determines the questions the book can answer. Evidence remains strongest when each source is asked to carry no more than its form allows.

At the end of 1921, the two routes had not met. Sasha had crossed out of the former Russian Empire and reached Berlin with an assumed surname, a missing arm, a reported history of prison and civil war, and a wife and child left behind. Hanka remained within a German legal identity but had stepped away from the family's expectations through performance, advocacy, irregular work, and a new relationship. One life had been forced across borders; the other repeatedly tested the borders of class, gender, and respectability. These are descriptions of action and circumstance, not diagnoses.

[32] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 5 and 7.

The next movement would take place inside the same unstable geography. Sasha did not remain in Berlin after his first arrival. Paris and Belgium offered work, expulsion, political print, and further uncertainty before he returned. Hanka and Alf would marry, have a daughter, and move east into the poor edge of Berlin's cultural world. When the two paths finally crossed, they did so through networks of people who lent rooms, papers, money, work, and protection. The house that emerged from those networks would possess an address without acquiring security.

Chapter 2

A House without Borders

> *La belle maison est celle qui reflète fidèlement la structure et la beauté cachées des choses.*
>
> The beautiful house is the one that faithfully reflects the hidden structure and beauty of things.
>
> — Alexander Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, Promenade, §9 « Forme et structure – ou la voix des choses »

Berlin, Paris, Brussels

Scharlau's reconstruction places Sasha in Berlin under Tanaroff during 1921 and then in Paris; exact crossing dates and immigration status remain unverified.[1]

During that stay, the family account associates police scrutiny with Sasha's assistance to the Italian anarchist Francesco Ghezzi. *Eine Frau* supplies dialogue and comic detail that cannot be treated as a transcript. Scharlau reconstructs a move toward Paris after the encounter; no immigration file inspected here establishes the legal mechanism or status consequence.[2]

Paris offered another network of eastern European refugees, but entry and residence remained unstable. Hanka's novel describes Sasha being moved between borders and eventually obtaining recognition through the intervention of a comrade's French wife. No official case file in the available record confirms the route or the intervention. The account is credible as testimony to repeated administrative insecurity, not as a scene with recoverable words. For someone without a dependable national passport, deportation did not necessarily produce a country willing to receive him. It could result in circulation between jurisdictions.[3]

A camera for one hand

The first workshop job reported in Paris exposed the relation between disability and wage labor. An employer allegedly assumed that a one-armed worker would produce less and placed Sasha on piece rates. Once he reorganized the repeated motions and exceeded expectations, the employer proposed hourly pay. Sasha left rather than accept the changed arrangement. The episode comes through *Eine Frau* and may compress several experiences. Its importance lies less in an exact exchange than in the type of work it describes: bodily adaptation could increase output without granting control over the terms of employment.[4]

Street photography appeared as an alternative. Comrades in Belgium used an instant camera that produced a small image on a metal plate within minutes. The operator approached passersby, made the exposure, processed the plate inside or beside the apparatus, rinsed it,

[1] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7. Border and police details are Scharlau's reconstruction from family testimony unless otherwise stated.

[2] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7.

[3] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7. Border and police details are Scharlau's reconstruction from family testimony unless otherwise stated.

[4] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7. Border and police details are Scharlau's reconstruction from family testimony unless otherwise stated.

and attempted a sale. The work required modest equipment, mobility, chemical skill, and the ability to create demand on the street. It also offered a form of self-employment. Sasha later explained the attraction in political terms: he neither hired workers nor sold his time to an owner, and the customer paid for an immediate product.[5]

That account should not be confused with economic independence in a stronger sense. The photographer depended on crowds, weather, permissions, the cost of plates and chemicals, and police tolerance. A customer could decline the picture after it had been made. Winter reduced the trade. Mobility allowed Sasha to seek fairs and resort visitors, but it also exposed him to inspection at every border. The camera weakened one relation of dependence while creating others.

For a man missing his left arm, the apparatus demanded a remade sequence of movement. Surviving photographs show Sasha beside the camera, and Hanka's later technical description explains how he used his right hand with pressure from a knee or foot to steady or shift the tripod and processing mechanism. The exact performance in the novel is highly shaped, but the material core is supported by the equipment and his visible body. He learned a craft whose tools did not assume his body and made them workable without concealing the injury.[6]

Belgian authorities eventually expelled him, according to the family narrative. They reportedly arrested him while he was working and did not allow him to retrieve his possessions. Among the items left behind was a manuscript about the revolution. No manuscript survives, and no inventory records what was lost. Hanka and Grothendieck both remembered Sasha as an aspiring writer who connected literary work with revolutionary witness. The loss can be reported as family testimony; the quality, extent, and contents of the absent work cannot be assessed.[7]

The distinction matters because the vanished manuscript later became part of a family judgment about unrealized gifts. Grothendieck wrote about both parents as people with serious literary capacities whose works remained incomplete. That later assessment belongs to his understanding of them. It does not give access to the pages that disappeared or prove that a finished book would have resulted under different conditions. Arrest, expulsion, poverty, repeated moves, and the absence of a stable workspace were not incidental obstacles to writing. Neither were they a complete explanation for every unfinished project.

[5] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7 and 13.

[6] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13. Technical and domestic detail is mediated through Hanka's autobiographical narrative.

[7] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7. Border and police details are Scharlau's reconstruction from family testimony unless otherwise stated.

Sasha-Piotr in print

Scharlau reports a catalog finding of two pieces printed under the byline Sasha-Piotr in *La Revue Internationale Anarchiste*, dated November 15, 1924 and February 15, 1926, on anarchism in Bulgaria. The original pages have not been consulted here. The bibliographic lead may be stated, but authorship, original language, style, travel, and eyewitness knowledge cannot be inferred from it, and no line is quoted.[8]

The byline adds another identity without resolving the first ones. Sasha-Piotr was neither simply a private nickname nor the surname recognized by the state. It was a name used within the movement and in publication. Together, Schapiro, Tanaroff, Sasha, and Sasha-Piotr identify one man only after a chain of evidence has been established. A matching given name or political affiliation is not enough, as the confusion with Sania Shapiro demonstrated.

The subject of the articles—anarchism in Bulgaria—also sets a limit. Publication under his name establishes an interest or claimed knowledge; it does not by itself establish travel to Bulgaria, membership in a Bulgarian organization, or personal witness to the events discussed. The note that the text may have been translated raises further questions about original language and editorial intervention. Until the pages are inspected, even small conclusions about style or fluency would be premature.

The CIRA bibliographic trail is valuable because it identifies a recoverable object rather than a circulating anecdote. Date, periodical, issue, title, byline, language note, and page can eventually be checked together. This is a higher-quality path than assigning unsigned material by resemblance. In a life crowded by aliases, bibliographic exactness is a form of identity work.

The two articles do not make Sasha a professional journalist, any more than Hanka's attributed poem made her one. They establish publication within a political periodical culture supported by intermittent labor and voluntary networks. The distinction between a published writer and a person earning a regular living from writing matters for both parents. Each claimed a literary vocation while relying on other trades.

This shared claim may help explain the intensity with which they later revised one another, but it cannot prove compatibility. A pair can value the same vocation and disagree over whose time, income, and pages receive priority. The surviving evidence records aspiration and conflict more clearly than completed work. It should not be reorganized into the romance of two unrecognized authors destined to meet.

[8] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7.

A bust and a permit

Scharlau reports that the sculptor Aron Brzezinski made and exhibited in 1925 a bronze bust designated Sasha-Piotr; Scharlau traced later testimony but had not secured the object for direct study. The report places Sasha within an émigré artistic circle more securely than speculation about whom he might have met in a famous café.[9]

The city's artistic and political networks overlapped. A refugee could write for a short-lived anarchist review, pose for a sculptor, earn money with street photographs, and depend on comrades for a room or a border intervention. None of these roles created a settled profession. They formed an economy of intermittent labor and mutual assistance whose resources were easily exhausted. Sasha's gifts to people in need, later documented in Berlin, suggest that earnings were not kept separate from political obligation.

Scharlau places Sasha's return to Berlin in the autumn of 1925 and reports an entry permit valid for eight days. The permit and its legal consequences have not been checked against an immigration file. What the family narrative supports is a return followed by prolonged documentary insecurity, photography, and a new domestic partnership.

Hanka and Alf

Scharlau gives May 18, 1922 in Hamburg as the civil marriage date of Hanka and Johannes "Alf" Raddatz, while describing their advocacy of free love. The original marriage entry has not been consulted here, and their reasons for marrying are not documented.[10]

Hanka and Alf lived through irregular work and acute poverty. *Eine Frau* describes improvised schemes, debts, pawning household goods, small thefts, meals obtained without payment, and repeated dependence on relatives or acquaintances. Its episodes are literary and sometimes comic in form; they should not be staged as if observed by a neutral witness. The broader material condition is corroborated by movement between lodgings, incomplete work, and the family's later recollections. The pair rejected regular employment while also encountering an economy in which secure work was scarce. Principle and necessity cannot be cleanly separated.

The novel describes a son born after the marriage who died after nine days. No civil record has been located in the supplied research, surviving relatives did not remember the child, and Grothendieck apparently did not mention him. The episode may record an infant death, combine experiences, or function within the novel. It remains unresolved. This biography cannot silently add the child to the genealogy merely because the account is detailed.[11]

According to Scharlau, Frode Raddatz was born in Hamburg on January 24, 1924; the family knew her as Maidi. Hanka and Alf's unstable lodging and income now affected a child whose care required other adults. The novel's delivery scene has not been independently checked and is not reconstructed here.[12]

Maidi spent substantial periods with her maternal grandparents. The arrangement may have protected her from the couple's poorest lodgings and allowed Hanka and Alf to seek work, but the sources do not record a single agreed purpose or the child's feelings. Care moved across households. That movement was not unusual in conditions of unemployment and insecure housing, yet it would become central to this particular family, whose children repeatedly depended on people outside the parental pair.

[9] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7.
[10] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 12.
[11] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 12; Hanka Grothendieck, *Eine Frau* (n.d.), Unpublished autobiographical novel.
[12] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 12.

Hanka and Alf went to Berlin with the infant, reportedly traveling much of the route on foot while pushing a pram. The claim comes from the autobiographical account and has not been checked against travel or relief records. In Berlin they obtained occasional work connected with *Die Welt am Montag*, occupied furnished rooms and basements, and circulated through bohemian, anarchist, and left-wing acquaintances. The city celebrated in later memory for cabaret, theater, publishing, and visual art was also a city of housing insecurity. They inhabited its poorer edge.[13]

The phrase "golden twenties" can obscure that difference. A premiere, gallery, or fashionable café does not place Hanka in its audience. No source permits a tour through famous venues on her behalf. Her Berlin is better located by jobs, addresses, debts, political contacts, and the later novel's repeated attention to food and rent. Cultural innovation and deprivation were simultaneous without being evenly shared.

By September 1925, official papers indicated that Hanka and Alf were no longer living in marital union, although divorce came later. Their practical separation was incomplete. Alf remained within the same network, Maidi remained his daughter, and his papers and contacts would sometimes assist Sasha. A marriage could cease as a domestic partnership while continuing to govern surname, legitimacy, and the state's account of a future child.[14]

Alf should not be reduced to the husband displaced by a more forceful man. He was trained in mechanical work, had served during the First World War, wrote occasional verse, and moved politically from Social Democracy toward the Communist Party, which he joined in 1926. His later resistance activity under National Socialism lies outside this chapter, but it prevents an interpretation of him as merely idle or apolitical. The record shows intelligence, humor, repeated refusal of regular work, and continuing practical involvement with Hanka's circle. It does not provide a stable psychological portrait.[15]

[13] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 12.
[14] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 12–13.
[15] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 12 and 16.

A porous household

The network around them included the writer Theodor Plievier and his partner, as well as people who experimented with street photography and boatbuilding. A later memoir identifies Sasha as a source from whom others learned the instant-camera trade and links Alf to a boatbuilding project. Such testimony is useful because it comes from outside Hanka's novel, though it too was written later. It establishes connections among work, politics, and friendship without requiring the picturesque scenes through which memoir presents them.[16]

These circles were porous because resources were shared. Someone with wages supported people without them; a person with papers could lend them; a room became a meeting place; a craft moved from one worker to another. The arrangement embodied part of the anarchist ethic of mutual aid, but it also depended heavily on women's paid and domestic labor. A community opposed to hierarchy did not automatically eliminate gendered expectations or unequal burdens.

Maidi's care makes that dependence visible. The grandparents' home in Hamburg provided continuity that Hanka and Alf's movement could not. Sending a child to relatives may have been a response to poverty, work, and unsuitable lodging; the present sources do not rank those reasons. Nor do they support an emotional script of abandonment or rescue. What can be tracked is the transfer of daily responsibility and the financial obligation Hanka acknowledged toward her parents.[17]

The transfer had effects on every household. The grandparents supplied food, shelter, and attention. Hanka and Alf gained mobility but incurred material and relational debts. Maidi belonged legally to her parents while living for long intervals within another domestic routine. When she later joined Hanka and Sasha, that change did not erase the grandparents' role. Family continuity was produced across residences rather than contained within one home.

This history also resists the romantic language sometimes attached to bohemian poverty. Damp rooms, borrowed money, delayed support, and irregular meals were not proofs of artistic authenticity. They restricted work and shifted burdens toward relatives or better-paid friends. Rejecting a conventional career could be principled, but the practical consequences were borne collectively. The record is strongest when both the principle and the cost remain visible.

Hanka's literary account can make the period seem unusually full because it preserves schemes, quarrels, reversals, and acute observations of money. That abundance should not be mistaken for complete surveillance of the past. She selected episodes, assigned pseudonyms, shaped dialogue, and stopped the surviving narrative at a charged threshold. Alf, Maidi, Sasha, and other members of the circle would not necessarily have organized the same years in the same way.

For that reason, *Eine Frau* serves at least three distinct functions. It records what Hanka later wished to preserve about her life. It supplies technical and social knowledge available to a participant. It is also a literary construction whose scenes and judgments require corroboration. Those functions can operate together. Calling the work a novel does not ban it from biography; calling it autobiographical does not authorize every sentence as fact.

The same caution applies to Scharlau's use of family interviews. A later recollection that Sasha treated Maidi kindly has value as remembered relationship, particularly when supported by the way he signed a letter. It does not recover each year of her childhood. A

[16] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 14.
[17] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 12–13.

relative's dislike of Hanka records a durable family judgment; it does not prove the events offered to explain that judgment. Testimony must be dated in relation to the life it describes.

The legal marriage to Alf remained a more contemporaneous fact than any later interpretation. It determined Hanka's civil name and would determine the presumption entered at Alexander's birth. The practical partnership with Sasha was equally real but legible through other evidence: cohabitation, work, photographs, and later recognition of paternity. The conflict between these records is not evidence that one relation was authentic and the other false. It shows that law and lived household described different arrangements.

The coming birth would force those arrangements into sequence. First the hospital and registry named the married woman and her husband. Then divorce, a successful action concerning legitimacy, and Sasha's acknowledgment altered the child's documented position. The changes did not uncover a name that had always been waiting. Each was an act within a legal system, made at a date and preserved by a particular record.

Sasha enters the circle

Sasha's return in 1925 occurred inside this social geography. His stated reason concerned a dispute among Russian anarchists over suspicions surrounding his escape from the Soviet Union. *Eine Frau* turns the confrontation into a scene of threats and theatrical gestures. Without another witness, the scene cannot be repeated as fact. What can be retained is that he came to address distrust within the exile community, lacked money for a return journey, and began using the instant camera on Berlin streets.[18]

His eight-day permit did not provide the chain of documents needed for ordinary trade. A license required recognized residence; residence required acceptable papers; his Nansen documentation and earlier movements exposed the gap. At first he stayed unregistered with comrades or in cheap temporary rooms. The exact sequence of police summons and interventions comes mainly through Hanka's novel. The recurring administrative problem is well supported even where individual conversations are not.

Sasha entered the circle through Alf. Hanka was away from Berlin when the men first met, according to the autobiographical account. Alf wrote about the unusual visitor, and Sasha reportedly saw a photograph of Hanka before meeting her. The novel supplies declarations, jealous confrontations, emotional reversals, and nights of quarrel. Because the manuscript was composed years later as literature, none of that speech can be reproduced as documentary dialogue. It records Hanka's later construction of the encounter, not a stenographic record of 1925.

The relationship between Hanka and Sasha was established by about 1926. It displaced the marriage in domestic fact without dissolving all ties among the three adults. Alf at times lent Sasha identity papers or helped him deal with officials. Hanka remained legally married to Alf. Maidi stayed for long periods with the Grothendieck grandparents and later returned to the Berlin household. Affection, jealousy, political comradeship, law, and necessity drew different boundaries around the same people.[19]

Calling the arrangement a triangle would make geometry substitute for history. It was not a fixed three-person form. At different moments, Hanka and Alf were spouses, estranged partners, co-parents, political acquaintances, or people linked by practical aid. Sasha was Hanka's partner, an exile assisted by Alf, and eventually a parental presence to Maidi. The

[18] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 7. Border and police details are Scharlau's reconstruction from family testimony unless otherwise stated.

[19] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 7, 13, and 15.

sources do not establish that all parties accepted one theory of free love or lived by a negotiated plan.

Maidi's place is clearest in later traces. She recalled Sasha as kind to her, and a surviving letter sent in 1933 was signed by him as her father. Those facts do not allow the years 1925–1927 to be narrated as a domestic idyll. They do prevent biological and social fatherhood from being treated as identical. Alf remained her legal father; Sasha sometimes acted in the role within the household that was forming.[20]

Hanka and Sasha did not marry. That fact accorded with their criticism of bourgeois marriage, but it also left German law free to organize the family through Hanka's existing marriage. The choice was therefore both ideological and institutional. Refusing a ceremony did not place the couple outside civil consequences. In 1927 those consequences had not yet been concentrated in a birth certificate; they were already present in names, residence, work licenses, and responsibility for Maidi.

The partnership combined shared ambitions with evident inequality. Both wanted to write. Hanka's surviving manuscript shows sustained labor on an autobiographical novel, and the family remembered Sasha's lost revolutionary history. Hanka described Sasha as an exacting editor of her prose. At the same time, Scharlau's account says that he discouraged her from accepting newspaper work even when it could provide income. The source supports the conflict but not a complete theory of motive. A man committed to freedom from domination could still participate in gendered control.

This is not a paradox requiring an invented interior explanation. Political commitments do not automatically govern every domestic action. The exile economy made paid work, care, and writing compete for the same hours. Hanka depended on Sasha's earnings and family assistance; Sasha depended on her legal capacity to obtain licenses and on her labor with the camera. Each could regard the other's independent work as a threat to a shared project. The documents show the arrangement and its consequences more securely than they show intention.

Street photography

During the warmer months they traveled to fairs and resort areas to make photographs. In winter, when street demand diminished, the family account says they sang Russian songs in working-class taverns, with Hanka accompanying on guitar. The practice brought in coins rather than a stable wage. It also reveals how performance, political identity, and survival overlapped. A revolutionary song could be an expression of memory and a means of buying food. No specific evening can be recreated from the general account.[21]

The small instant plate made photography unusually immediate. A studio portrait normally required an appointment, controlled lighting, processing, and later collection. Sasha's apparatus promised an image during the encounter itself. The customer saw the operator expose and develop the plate, then decided whether to purchase it. That sequence made persuasion part of the craft. The photographer had to find a passerby, manage the apparatus, produce a recognizable likeness, and convert curiosity into payment before the person walked away.

Hanka's novel describes the work in exceptional technical and dramatic detail. It gives prices, material costs, processing actions, crowd formation, and a division of labor between Sasha at the camera and Hanka rinsing, drying, framing, and selling the plates. The text is

[20] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15 and 17.

[21] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13. Technical and domestic detail is mediated through Hanka's autobiographical narrative.

too carefully composed to be treated as a transcript of one workday. Its concrete knowledge nonetheless comes from practice. The apparatus, metal plates, visible amputation, and surviving photographs confirm the essential operations.[22]

The method required Sasha to coordinate one hand with the tripod and processing mechanism. That coordination was not a sentimental triumph over disability. It was learned labor. The equipment remained awkward, the hours long, and the income uncertain. Emphasizing mastery without material cost would turn a work practice into inspiration. Emphasizing impairment without mastery would misdescribe what he did. The documented fact is adaptation at the level of repeated movement.

The sales technique also has political and ethical ambiguity. The novel portrays Sasha offering to take a picture without obliging the subject to buy it, then allowing the finished likeness to persuade. The arrangement shifted risk to the photographer, who paid for the plate whether or not it sold. It also relied on social pressure and the fascination created by the crowd. Self-employment did not remove commerce, performance, or unequal powers of persuasion. It changed who controlled the immediate labor process.

The price structure mattered. A cheap plate could draw people who would not enter a formal portrait studio, while optional fittings such as a brooch or protective glass increased the sale. Materials consumed much of the gross receipt. Hanka's account of a highly productive day therefore cannot be read by taking the money collected as household income. Plates, chemicals, water, fittings, transport, and replacement equipment stood between receipts and food or rent. The business could be busy and the family still poor.[23]

The customer bought both likeness and speed. The image emerged while the subject remained present, so the stages normally hidden in a darkroom became part of the public performance. Processing had to be quick enough to sustain attention and careful enough that the plate would not deteriorate immediately. The operator's command of chemistry and timing was thus visible through the result even when the customer did not understand the procedure. Sasha's political account of direct labor had a physical basis: production and exchange occurred in one brief encounter.

The street supplied no neutral workplace. Police could regulate hawking, crowds could block passage, and a useful location could be lost. The photographer had no employer, but neither did he control the public space on which revenue depended. Weather and season mattered, as did the willingness of taverns, fair organizers, or local officials to tolerate the trade. Travel expanded the market while increasing the risk created by Sasha's papers. Independence was a practical degree, not an absolute condition.

The bodily division of labor was equally specific. Sasha controlled the exposure and much of the processing sequence; Hanka moved among customers, water, finished plates, frames, and payments. Her role required sustained bending, carrying, sales talk, and judgment about complaints. The novel's admiration focuses strongly on Sasha's concentrated rhythm, but its technical details also disclose Hanka's exhaustion. A history that names only the photographer would lose half of the labor that made the day possible.

Their product entered lives otherwise absent from the archive. Most customers remain unnamed, and the tiny portraits cannot be assigned to a particular day without provenance. The trade nonetheless depended on workers and families finding a few coins for an inexpensive likeness. In a period when formal portraiture still carried cost and ceremony, the instant plate

[22] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13. Technical and domestic detail is mediated through Hanka's autobiographical narrative.

[23] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13. Technical and domestic detail is mediated through Hanka's autobiographical narrative.

widened access imperfectly and temporarily. It also generated countless objects detached from the name of their maker, which is why attribution requires more than visual resemblance.

Sasha's disability could itself draw attention, but the sources do not permit a claim that customers bought pictures out of pity. Hanka's narrative stresses fascination with his control of the apparatus and his forceful public manner. That is her portrayal, shaped by admiration. The safest conclusion is that his visible body and technical coordination formed part of the encounter. Whether an individual customer felt curiosity, sympathy, unease, or respect is unknowable unless recorded.

The camera therefore joined three kinds of recognition. It made the customer's face into an object. It made Sasha visible as a worker whose papers might not authorize the work. It made Hanka visible to licensing authorities as the proprietor or responsible trader. These recognitions did not coincide. The person whose name appeared on the license, the person who operated the apparatus, and the person shown on the plate occupied different legal and material positions.

Licenses and borrowed papers

The studio promised to align them by placing business, work, and residence at one address. Even there, Sasha's name could not simply replace Hanka's. His insecure status made her legal visibility essential. Conversely, the studio's reputation and production depended heavily on his craft. The arrangement was neither a disguise alone nor a conventional family business. It was a practical answer to unequal access to documents.

Hanka's work was indispensable. She helped create the crowd, handled wet plates, washed and dried them, offered brooches or glass covers, collected payments, and dealt with complaints about likenesses. In the commercial record, however, her name would later stand as proprietor because she could obtain the license, while Sasha's embodied skill dominated the family narrative. The business inverted and reproduced conventional gender roles at once: the woman was the legal commercial surface, the man the celebrated operator, and both depended on the other.[24]

The photographs themselves had a material fragility. A small plate could preserve a face after the encounter, but poor washing or residual chemicals could destroy the image. The object was inexpensive enough for a passerby and durable enough that some examples survived. This is not a metaphor for memory; it is a condition of the archive. The same trade that paid rent generated the family photographs through which later researchers recognized bodies, equipment, and relationships.

Sasha's image work did not create legal transparency. He sometimes worked under Hanka's license as her employee. Alf reportedly lent papers on occasions when officials threatened expulsion. A name on a license could belong to the person authorized to trade rather than the person making most exposures. A name on borrowed identity papers could present another relationship to the police. The household's economic life depended on distinctions that official forms were not designed to express.[25]

Those practices carried risk for everyone involved. Lending documents exposed Alf; unregistered residence exposed Sasha; obtaining a license connected Hanka's legal identity to the enterprise. Mutual assistance was not an atmosphere but a set of acts with consequences.

[24] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13. Technical and domestic detail is mediated through Hanka's autobiographical narrative.

[25] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13. Technical and domestic detail is mediated through Hanka's autobiographical narrative.

It also had limits. The same adults who helped one another could quarrel, separate, withhold income, or fail to send money for Maidi's support.

The record of money is fragmentary but revealing. Hanka repeatedly owed support to the grandparents caring for Maidi. Income from photography arrived unevenly and was quickly consumed by materials, rent, food, travel, and help for others. When later family narratives describe chronic empty pockets, they do not necessarily indicate that the business failed on every working day. They indicate that revenue did not become reserves. Earning and security were different measures.

Brunnenstraße

Hanka's autobiographical narrative places the couple's move into a studio and dwelling associated with Brunnenstraße 165 near the end of 1927. Scharlau separately reports a 1929 Berlin address-book listing for Hanka's photographic atelier at that address. The directory page and trade-license chain have not been consulted here, so neither source proves an opening day, lease, continuous occupancy, profitability, or division of labor.[26]

A studio altered the labor without ending the street trade. It provided storage for plates and chemicals, an indoor setting for portraits, a fixed commercial address, and rooms in which writing could in principle continue. It also required rent and made the enterprise more legible to officials. A fixed address could shelter a household and expose it. It gave the family a place in the directory while making loss of that place traceable.

Indoor work also changed the relation to customers. The street operator found people in motion and had minutes to complete a sale. An atelier could receive appointments, control a background, and keep equipment in place, but it had to attract customers to an address. The available record does not show the studio's price list, client book, account ledger, or surviving portrait register. It cannot establish how much of the business moved indoors or which partner handled a particular commission.

The absence of those records limits the word "atelier." A directory category may describe a small commercial room rather than a prosperous portrait establishment. No floor plan, props, waiting area, darkroom, or continuous residence can be inferred. Pending direct consultation, Scharlau's report supports only a listed photographic business at the address.[27]

That distinction preserves the scale of the achievement. Securing a fixed workplace after years of border movement and temporary lodging was a material change even if the business remained poor. It did not need to resemble a fashionable studio to matter. At the same time, treating the address as proof of stability would ignore rent, licensing, and the continued street work on which the household may have depended.

The move into Brunnenstraße should not be narrated as arrival at stability. *Eine Frau* ends its surviving 1927 section as the rooms are being arranged and money is again short after a celebration. The scene belongs to the novel and is not reconstructed. The documentary point is that a licensed enterprise and dwelling were assembled from precarious labor. Their existence did not erase debt, police scrutiny, Maidi's dispersed care, or the unresolved marriage.

Brunnenstraße lay in an area shaped by workers, small businesses, migrants, and eastern European Jewish life. It was close enough to the political and immigrant networks north of Alexanderplatz to make the address intelligible without inventing a street scene. No source describes the light in the rooms, their furniture, or the daily sequence of visitors. The address

[26] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13 and 15.

[27] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13 and 15; *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929* (August Scherl, 1929), 1075, https://digital.zlb.de/viewer/metadata/34115495_1929/1/.

book and business history support walls, a commercial use, and a household; they do not furnish the interior.

Scharlau reports that a November 1927 relief-fund bulletin listed "Sasha Piotr" as a Berlin donor, gave the amount as twenty marks, and ranked it as the largest individual contribution in the German list. The original page has not been consulted here, so amount and ranking remain attributed to Scharlau rather than treated as direct evidence.[28]

The donation does not reveal the discussion that preceded it or the household budget from which it came. It demonstrates that Sasha directed money toward comrades despite his own insecurity. Placed beside missed or delayed support for Maidi, it also shows competing obligations. The point is not to expose a contradiction and declare a verdict. Political solidarity, parental responsibility, and immediate need drew on the same limited cash. The distribution of that cash had consequences for people who did not choose every commitment.

The source forms assign visibility unevenly. An aid bulletin made the donor legible. A directory made the licensed proprietor legible. Family arrangements made the grandparents' care of Maidi essential but less likely to enter a public ledger. Hanka's novel restored some of that work while shaping it through retrospective narrative. To reconstruct the household, no single source can be treated as complete.

Writing under one roof

The studio also gathered the pair's literary ambitions under one roof. The surviving account says that they discussed and revised prose, and that each imagined a book capable of establishing a public life beyond photography. There is no finished collaborative manuscript from 1927 in the available record. Aspiration is supported; accomplishment cannot be supplied. Their status as writers should therefore be described through surviving publication, manuscript labor, application, and testimony rather than a prediction of books that never appeared.

An unfinished work remains historically significant without being evaluated as a lost masterpiece. Sasha's absent revolutionary manuscript and Hanka's eventual long novel occupied time, hope, and family argument. Their incompletion affected how the son later judged both parents. What cannot be known is whether further stability would have produced publication, whether the texts would have survived revision, or how readers would have received them. Counterfactual success is not evidence.

The contrast with photography is instructive at the material level. A plate had to be exposed, processed, and sold within minutes; prose could be revised indefinitely and deferred when money ran out. The camera generated a sequence of finished small objects even under precarious conditions. Literary projects demanded longer continuity. This difference in production helps describe the household economy without turning photographic immediacy into a theory of personality.

Hanka was pregnant before the end of the year. *Eine Frau* represents the pregnancy as wanted by her and initially opposed in principle by Sasha, who believed that revolutionaries living outside settled society should not have children. The novel also frames reproductive decisions through their relationship. Those private arguments cannot be narrated as verified dialogue. The pregnancy itself and the later birth are documented. Any claim about conception as strategy, rejection of maternity, or an attempt to bind the father belongs to retrospective interpretation and does not enter as fact.[29]

[28] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13.

[29] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13. Technical and domestic detail is mediated through Hanka's autobiographical narrative.

This boundary is especially important because Grothendieck later developed an elaborate account of his earliest life from what his mother told him, family papers, and dreams. His writing records how the adult son understood birth and parental conflict. It cannot establish the mental state of an infant or recover an atmosphere experienced before language. Chapter 3 will separate the civil record of birth from those later interpretations rather than weaving them together into a scene.

A house without borders

At the end of 1927, then, the house existed in several incompatible senses. It was a fixed address with a studio. It was a legal enterprise under Hanka's name, worked substantially by Sasha. It was linked to an unresolved marriage, a daughter spending much time with grandparents, a Russian wife and son beyond reach, and a network of people who crossed its practical boundaries. It sheltered a couple without giving Sasha secure national status. The title "house without borders" describes this documentary arrangement, not an ideal of carefree openness.

Nor was it a political model. Anarchism was present in the couple's affiliations, donations, distrust of state authority, and preference for independent labor. Ordinary hierarchy persisted. Sasha's view of Hanka's paid work could be restrictive. Care for Maidi was displaced onto relatives. Legal privilege differed between the German partner and the Jewish refugee. Mutual aid redistributed resources without guaranteeing fairness. The history becomes less intelligible, not more, if "anarchist household" is made synonymous with equality.

The house was also larger than its residents. Rachil and Dodek remained connected through letters and photographs. Alf remained connected through marriage, paternity, papers, and friendship. Hanka's parents cared for Maidi and absorbed some of the costs of Berlin life. Comrades assisted Sasha with work and protection and received aid in return. These relations were not scenery surrounding an autonomous couple. They were the structure by which the couple survived.

No invented domestic scene is needed to see the density of those relations. A license identifies who could operate publicly. An address book fixes a place. A donation list measures one act of solidarity. A photograph shows the camera and body at work. A later novel describes technical practice while demanding caution about dialogue. The gaps between these objects are part of the account. Filling them with weather, furniture, gestures, or a child's imagined response would replace the archive with atmosphere.

This approach also prevents the years from becoming a moral preface to fame. In 1927, the future child had no mathematical identity. The parents' aliases, mobile labor, and resistance to convention did not contain a theory of schemes or categories in embryo. It would be easy to turn the family's unstable names into a symbolic origin of later abstraction. That connection has no evidentiary basis. The names matter because police, courts, employers, and relatives acted on them in the present.

What had changed since 1921 was concrete. Sasha had acquired a photographic craft, moved through Paris and Belgium, published two short political pieces, returned to Berlin, and formed a partnership with Hanka. Hanka had married Alf, become Maidi's mother, moved into poverty in Berlin, separated in practice, and built work with Sasha. Alf had not vanished; Maidi's care had not become simple; the state had not ceased to classify any of them. The studio gathered these consequences without resolving them.

The surviving portion of Hanka's novel stops close to this threshold. Its silence is not proof that life became less eventful. It changes the evidence available. For the pre-studio years, the novel supplies abundant, if shaped, detail. For the birth and its aftermath, civil documents,

address books, photographs, court proceedings, and later recollections carry more weight. The shift in source does not only alter the number of facts. It changes what kind of sentence can responsibly be written.

That shift also changes the narrative distance. A novel can follow a quarrel into a room and assign each participant words; a directory offers a surname, trade, and address; a court record reduces intimacy to categories with legal effect. None is a transparent window. The novel is rich in perspective, the directory in public placement, and the court file in institutional action. Reading them together requires preserving their differences rather than blending them into a seamless scene.

The years 1921–1927 demonstrate why source distance matters. A later account can describe border crossings while an uninspected passport cannot yet be made to answer them. A photograph can confirm an apparatus and a missing arm without recording the sales exchange. Scharlau's report of a donation amount remains a lead until the bulletin page is consulted. The household becomes knowable through intersections, not through one all-sufficient witness.[30]

Its openness was consequently both resource and exposure. Friends supplied work and documents; relatives absorbed care; political networks transmitted news and money. The same permeability made privacy difficult and obligations hard to delimit. This conclusion follows from the recorded movements and transfers. It does not require an assertion that any resident experienced the house in one particular way.

The next surviving institutional act was a birth notice dated March 28, 1928. Its names and legal effects belong to the next chapter.

[30] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13.

Chapter 3

Berlin, 1928

Il y avait la magie des nombres, et celle des mots, des signes et des sons.

There was the magic of numbers, and that of words, signs, and sounds.

— Alexander Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, Promenade, §1 « La magie des choses »

Moabit, March 28, 1928

Grothendieck was born in Berlin on March 28, 1928. Scharlau's transcription reports that Moabit Hospital notified the civil authorities of a birth at 11:45 to Johanna Raddatz, née Grothendieck, wife of the writer Johannes Raddatz, resident at Brunnenstraße 165. It further reports the given name Alexander and the initial registration Alexander Raddatz. The original civil entry was not inspected for this account.[1]

Figure 2. Stolperstein for Alexander Grothendieck, Brunnenstraße 165, Berlin-Mitte (photographed 2017).
OTFW, Berlin · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

The transcription supports a documentary opening, not a reconstructed scene. It reports an institution, time, maternal identity, marital relation, address, and name; it does not establish

[1] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.1.

the room, people present, labor, expressions, the biological father's location, or the infant's condition. None of those missing details may be furnished from convention.

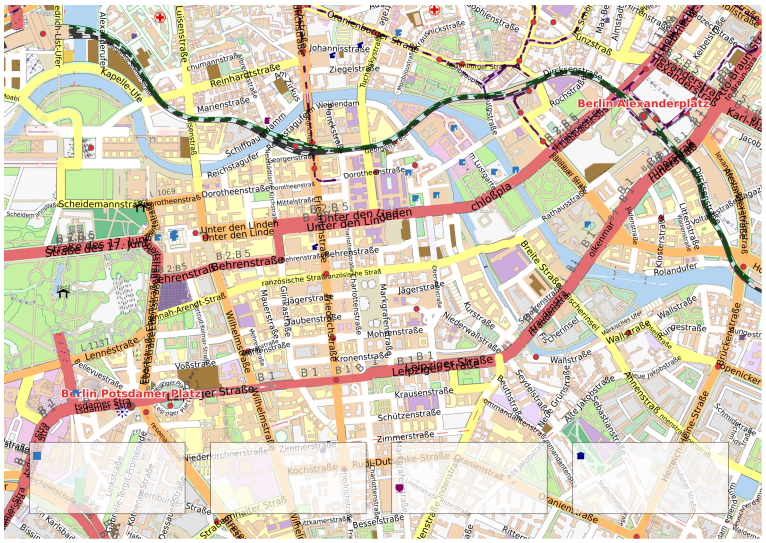

Figure 3. Map of Berlin-Mitte.
Selfmade by Rumpeltux · CC BY-SA 2.0 · Wikimedia Commons

If Scharlau's transcription is accurate, Raddatz was not an error waiting for a biographer to correct. It recorded the legal effect of Hanka's undissolved marriage, while the absence of Sasha Tanaroff from the entry did not establish his physical absence or emotional relation. Later proceedings changed the child's legal position; they do not permit the familiar surname Grothendieck to be projected backward into the original entry.

The exact birth time, reporting language, registry number, marginal annotations, and wording remain unresolved until the German object is consulted. Chai and Oort corroborate the date, place, and initial surname at secondary-source level, but neither secondary account can substitute for the page when the chapter analyzes its physical or legal details.[2]

Scharlau's transcription also uses "writer" for Johannes Raddatz and later for Alexander Tanaroff. Such an administrative occupation can record self-presentation without proving regular publication or income. Brunnenstraße 165 likewise links the birth report to the studio history but does not establish each adult's continuous residence or resolve the later Spandauer Straße address.[3]

Moabit Hospital functions similarly. It is a verified institutional location for the birth. It does not provide a visual setting unless hospital records, plans, or photographs are separately introduced and sourced. Later descriptions of the infant being moved to a children's hospital or refusing nourishment come from retrospective texts, not from the birth entry. The documentary line must remain visible between the event the registry confirms and the story the adult son later assembled.

The mother named in the certificate was twenty-seven. Hanka had lived with Sasha for roughly two years while remaining married to Alf. She and Sasha had taken over the photographic studio and dwelling at Brunnenstraße 165 during the previous autumn, according to the reconstructed business history. That brief context is necessary to understand the mismatch

[2] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.1.
[3] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.

among residence, partnership, and surname; the full convergence belongs to Chapter 2 and is not repeated here.[4]

The birth introduced no new clarity about Sasha's status. He was using the surname Tanaroff, had worked under Hanka's trade authority, and remained vulnerable to police attention. Later in 1928, a Berlin identity card would give him a more secure documentary presence. On the day of the birth, the supplied evidence places him in the family but not on the birth notice. The record's silence is institutional, not proof of physical absence or emotional distance.

Alexander, Raddatz, Schurik

The given name Alexander connected child and father without proving why it was chosen. Both the biological father and the newborn bore that name. The family called the father Sasha, and would call the child Schurik, another diminutive form within Russian usage. It is reasonable to observe the pattern. It would be speculative to claim that the name honored the father, asserted paternity, or expressed a particular hope unless Hanka or Sasha documented that intention.[5]

The familiar spelling "Alexandre" belongs mainly to the child's later life in French. The 1928 record summarized by Scharlau uses Alexander. A biography written in English needs a stable form. This one uses Alexander, while preserving Alexandre in French titles, quotations, and documents. Orthographic consistency in the book should not be mistaken for evidence that one spelling governed every language and period.

The nickname Schurik presents a different problem. Family photographs and later testimony establish its use for the young child and its persistence among relatives and close acquaintances. The available record does not provide a dated 1928 object showing the first occasion on which it was used. It is therefore safe to say that he was known in the family as Schurik during childhood; it is not safe to stage the act of naming or assign it to a particular adult.[6]

Four forms now coexist: Alexander as the registered given name; Raddatz as the initial civil surname; Schurik as family usage; and, soon, Grothendieck as the surname established after legal proceedings. Alexandre would become a linguistic variant in France. They do not all have the same authority or date. A name can be official, intimate, translated, chosen, imposed, or retrospective. Collapsing those functions would destroy the chapter's central fact.

Nor is the central fact that the child possessed a hidden essence beneath the names. Biography cannot step outside every record and pronounce a metaphysically true label. It can establish a continuing human subject through dates, relationships, documents, photographs, and later actions. The task is evidentiary: demonstrate why these forms refer to the same person, mark when each was used, and avoid importing properties from one context into another.

That task is especially necessary because the father's history had already shown how names could be confused. Schapiro linked Sasha to an original family account; Tanaroff governed his administrative life; Sasha-Piotr appeared in political print; another Alexander Shapiro possessed a separate and much larger archive. The son's naming sequence was better documented, but it too required proof rather than familiarity. The later fame of "Grothendieck" cannot serve as proof of what the registry said in March 1928.

[4] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13 and 15.
[5] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[6] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.

Early stories, later sources

In *La Clef des Songes*, written more than fifty years later, Grothendieck recounted a family-derived story that he refused nourishment as an infant and received hospital care. He described the reconstruction as drawing on family reports, writings, letters, and dreams. It is evidence for his late self-interpretation, not a contemporaneous clinical history.[7]

No medical chart, discharge record, or contemporary letter examined here establishes the transfer, diagnosis, treatment, duration, infant intention, or maternal motive. The chapter therefore makes no claim that the infant tried to die, that nurses restored a will to live, or that maternal rejection caused the episode. The documentary record establishes a birth; the later text establishes how the adult author came to narrate it.

Photographs from the Berlin years provide another kind of evidence. Scharlau refers to a picture of Hanka with the newborn in a baby sleeping sack and to a series of images of the children. Such objects can confirm bodies, approximate age, clothing, and photographic practice when the originals, dates, and captions are verified. They cannot prove harmony, attachment, fear, or early mathematical ability. A portrait is an arranged exposure, not an emotional test.

One later recollection claimed that the young Schurik counted unusually early. The source was a partner from Grothendieck's adult life, not a contemporaneous witness to infancy. Without an early record or a clearly identified family transmission, the claim belongs to the mythology of precocity and is excluded from this account. The future mathematician does not require an infant prodigy story.[8]

[7] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15. The account is a late self-interpretation, not a contemporaneous medical record.
[8] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15. The early-counting claim is late testimony and is excluded from the factual chronology.

The little family

Maidi's presence in the household is more firmly relevant. Her maternal grandmother Anna Grothendieck died on October 3, 1928. Scharlau's reconstruction suggests that Maidi, who had spent long periods with her grandparents, came to live with Hanka and Sasha around the time of Alexander's birth or after Anna's death. The exact move is not established. It should be described as probable rather than dated to a particular day.[9]

The four-person grouping later called the "little family" consisted of Hanka, Sasha, Maidi, and Alexander. The phrase came from Grothendieck's later meditations and may not have been a household term in 1928. It is useful only if its retrospective character remains visible. The group contained two children with different legal fathers, a mother whose marriage was ending, and a man whose relation to each child differed biologically and legally.[10]

Maidi's surname, Raddatz, matched the infant's first surname, but the similarity concealed different situations. Alf was Maidi's biological and legal father. In Alexander's case, the marriage supplied the legal connection while Sasha was the biological father. Sasha later acted toward Maidi in a paternal capacity and formally acknowledged Alexander. The household cannot be mapped by surname alone.[11]

The grandparents' role did not disappear when Maidi returned. Years of care had made them part of the structure through which Hanka's Berlin life was possible. Anna's death changed that structure. The record does not disclose how the child understood the move or bereavement. It shows a transfer of daily care at a time when the studio household had just added an infant.

[9] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 8 and 15.
[10] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15, retrospective testimony only.
[11] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.

A studio and its names

Brunnenstraße 165 joined residence and work. The family's rooms were associated with a photographic atelier, and Berlin address books listed Hanka's business in 1929 and 1930. The address on the birth record confirms the household's connection to the building in March 1928. It does not identify which rooms were used for portraits, sleeping, processing, or writing. Those details require a plan, inventory, or direct testimony not present in the available record.

The address stood near working-class and immigrant districts north of central Berlin, including areas shaped by eastern European Jewish settlement. This social geography helps explain why exile networks and small trades could overlap there. It does not authorize a cinematic description of the street. No source in the available record supplies the weather on March 28, the sounds outside the hospital, or what could be seen from the studio windows.

The studio's existence matters because it created the appearance of settlement. The family had a place where clients could find it and where an official directory could list a proprietor. That public stability remained conditional. Sasha's papers, the unresolved marriage, the cost of rent, and the dependence on irregular customers continued. A fixed address reduced mobility without eliminating precarity.

It also distributed names across documents. The birth notice used Raddatz for Hanka and the child. The address-book entry later used Grothendieck-Raddatz for Hanka's atelier. Sasha's own identity papers used Tanaroff. A customer might have known only the studio name, a comrade only Sasha-Piotr, and a relative the diminutive Schurik. The household had no single documentary surface.

This multiplicity should not be romanticized as freedom from borders. Each name belonged to an institution or relation with the power to include and exclude. A license allowed work. A surname created legal presumptions. A refugee document enabled movement while exposing its bearer to scrutiny. A family nickname conveyed intimacy but had no force at court. The house was crossed by these borders even when none was visible in its rooms.

Divorce and an identity card

Scharlau reports that Hanka's marriage to Alf ended in divorce in July 1928 and summarizes a judgment that referred to her relationship with Alexander Tanaroff. The original German judgment and its legal wording have not been inspected. If Scharlau's chronology is accurate, the marriage still governed the March registration and had ended by July.[12]

Divorce did not automatically rewrite the child's birth entry into the later familiar form. Nor did it erase Alf's relation to Maidi or the years of practical connection among the adults. It changed one legal status at a dated moment. The temptation to narrate it as a final separation is contradicted by later assistance and continuing family links. A judgment can terminate a marriage without terminating every relation created during it.

Scharlau reports that Hanka often used the compound form Grothendieck-Raddatz after the divorce while some later official documents still used Raddatz. The uncollated examples suggest that name usage did not change cleanly on the date of judgment, but they do not establish a first use.[13]

Scharlau reports that Berlin police issued an identity card to Tanaroff on October 30, 1928. The card itself has not been consulted for this account, so its wording and legal effect remain unresolved; the report does not establish how earlier irregularities were resolved or whether residence was secure.[14]

That distinction is easy to lose. A forged or altered origin does not mean that every later document issued on its basis is itself fictitious. Institutions can recognize an identity repeatedly until it becomes the stable legal route through a life. Tanaroff was the name under which Sasha worked, appeared before offices, and would later be persecuted. Calling it an alias is accurate only if the word does not suggest an optional mask he could remove without consequence.

[12] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[13] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[14] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 13.

The paternity proceedings of 1929

Scharlau reports that Alf sought a change in Alexander's legal status and that a Berlin family-court action followed on April 17, 1929. The original file and precise legal category remain unconsulted; the chapter therefore does not quote the judgment or treat its terminology as settled.[15]

It is tempting to describe the proceeding as the discovery of biological truth. The record was more institutional. A court acted on a claim concerning legitimacy and altered the legal relation. Biological paternity was part of the background, but the source summary does not provide scientific evidence, testimony, or reasoning. The biographer should state the order and outcome, not reconstruct the hearing.

According to Scharlau's transcription, on June 28, 1929 Tanaroff appeared before the Berlin-Center youth welfare service and acknowledged paternity of Alexander Grothendieck. The transcription describes him as a writer, gives an undertaking of 120 Reichsmarks four times a year until age sixteen, and records a Spandauer Straße address. The original acknowledgment has not been inspected.[16]

On Scharlau's reading, the undertaking would total 480 Reichsmarks a year. It is not a payment ledger, and the transcribed address does not establish permanent residence, separation from Hanka, or falsity. Payment history and address use remain unknown.[17]

Several explanations for the address are possible. He may have lived elsewhere for a period, used a reliable mailing address, stayed with a comrade, or supplied an address suited to his documentary circumstances. None is established. A biography must not choose the explanation that makes the family most dramatic. The discrepancy should remain a discrepancy until residence records or correspondence resolve it.

Scharlau also summarizes a youth-welfare guardianship, but its powers and duration require the original case file and legal context. The only safe conclusion is that his reconstruction gives the welfare service an administrative role; its exact scope is unresolved.[18]

By the middle of 1929, the familiar name Alexander Grothendieck appears in Scharlau's reconstructed documentary chain. The reported transition involved divorce, a family-court action, acknowledgment, a support undertaking, and youth-welfare oversight. Until the originals are consulted, that sequence remains an attributed reconstruction rather than an documented close reading.[19]

Much later, Grothendieck's mathematics repeatedly emphasized structures that remain meaningful under transformations.[20] That mature work belongs to later chapters.

[15] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15. The April 17, 1929 family-court file and legal category remain unconsulted.
[16] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[17] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[18] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[19] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.1.
[20] Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," 11–12. This note supports only the nontechnical historical statement about his mature mathematical practice.

Figure 4. Stolperstein for Johanna (Hanka) Grothendieck, Brunnenstraße 165, Berlin-Mitte (photographed 2017).
OTFW, Berlin · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

Work in the directory

Scharlau reports 1929 and 1930 address-book entries for a photographic atelier at Brunnenstraße 165 under Hanka's compound name. The pages have not been directly consulted here; even if confirmed, a listing would not prove profitability, continuous occupancy, or division of labor.[21]

The listing also gives Hanka a documentary presence not dependent on being named as wife or mother. She appeared as the person associated with the atelier. This did not necessarily reflect who made most photographs, and it did not cancel the work of Sasha or any assistant. It shows how legal capacity and commercial attribution intersected. The woman whose married status had named the child Raddatz could use a compound surname to name the business after divorce.

Sasha remained attached to photography, whether at the studio or on the street. The 1929 paternity declaration called him a writer, not a photographer. Occupational labels shifted with the form and the self-description supplied to it. Neither label should be treated as fraudulent. He had published political articles and aspired to a major written work; he also earned money with a camera. A person could have a vocation, a trade, and an administrative occupation that did not coincide.[22]

Hanka likewise occupied several categories. She had worked in theater and advocacy print, wrote prose, helped operate the photographic enterprise, cared for an infant, and negotiated a household containing Maidi. "Writer," "photographer," "mother," and "divorced wife" named real functions without providing a complete portrait. The record becomes misleading only when one category is allowed to erase the others.

[21] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[22] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chaps. 7, 13, and 15.

A destroyed file

In 1929, Hanka applied for support from the German Schiller Foundation, an organization assisting writers and their dependents. Scharlau reports that the file created for her was later selected for destruction and that she was listed as Grothendieck-Raddatz. The application establishes an institutional claim to literary work. The outcome is uncertain, and no surviving file in the available record allows the contents or merits of the application to be described.[23]

The destroyed file is a reminder that archival silence can be produced administratively. No failure of preservation should be converted into a failure of effort. At the same time, an application is not evidence that a grant was awarded or a manuscript completed. The secure statement lies between those errors: Hanka sought recognition and material support as a writer in 1929 under the compound surname.

Destruction also changes the balance among surviving voices. If an application contained Hanka's own account of her work, its loss leaves the later novel and other people's summaries carrying more weight. That imbalance is contingent, not proof that she had nothing more precise to say. A note that the file was selected for destruction records an archival event; it does not license reconstruction of what was inside.

Four kinds of record

The business directory survives for the opposite reason. Directories were produced systematically and preserved in runs, so a small commercial entry can outlast intimate papers. Its survival makes the atelier easy to locate but tells little about the children or the couple's writing. Archives favor repeated administrative forms. Biography must recognize that advantage without confusing regular preservation with greater human importance.

Court and youth-welfare records occupy a middle position. They concern intimate relations but translate them into legal categories. The paternity declaration can state an obligation more exactly than a memoir, yet it says nothing about daily care. The divorce judgment can establish legal dissolution, yet its findings were framed for a proceeding rather than for a complete family history. These documents are strong within their purpose and partial beyond it.

Photographs are partial in another direction. Once authenticated, they can show who appeared together and how a studio represented its subjects. Captions may preserve names unavailable elsewhere. But the decision to take or keep a picture selects a moment. Family albums often survive because someone curated them. The absence of conflict from an album does not prove an idyllic year, and the absence of a person from one image does not prove absence from the household.

The four documentary classes can therefore check one another. The birth record fixes the initial civil identity. The address book confirms the commercial address. Court and welfare actions show changes in legal relations. Photographs and later testimony establish family usage such as Schurik and the presence of Maidi. No one class supplies all answers. Agreement increases confidence; disagreement identifies a question rather than an opportunity for invention.

The 1929 sequence also demonstrates why a chronology needs dates finer than a general "Berlin childhood." March 1928, July 1928, October 1928, April 1929, and June 1929 mark different institutional states. If they are compressed, Sasha's acknowledgment can appear to

[23] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15. The Schiller Foundation file was reportedly selected for destruction; contents and outcome remain unknown.

precede the birth name, or the divorce can seem to have removed the need for a court action. Ordering the documents is itself an explanatory act.

The sequence should not be mistaken for steady progress toward truth. Each proceeding answered a practical legal problem, but later history does not confer moral superiority on the final form. The name Grothendieck became enduring and famous; that does not make every earlier relation an obstacle destined to be cleared away. Raddatz records the marriage that existed, and Tanaroff records the father who acknowledged the child.

A child without memories

For the infant, none of these proceedings can be narrated as remembered experience. The child was present as the subject of decisions made by adults and institutions. A biographer may describe the changes that affected him, not assign surprise, relief, confusion, or recognition. Those emotions would be plausible inventions and therefore impermissible.

The ethical limit is more than stylistic. Childhood biography often treats later personality as a source for imagined early reactions. Grothendieck's eventual concern with names, responsibility, or parental memory cannot be projected into 1928. Adult reflection may testify to later significance, but significance is not recollection, and recollection is not contemporaneous observation.

The same limit protects the adults from retrospective roles. Hanka is not yet "the mother of a mathematician" in any meaningful social sense; she is a writer, photographer, partner, former spouse, and mother managing immediate conditions. Sasha is not yet the legendary absent father; he is present in the legal record of 1929 and undertakes support. Alf is not only an incorrect surname; his marriage creates the initial status and his court action changes it. History proceeds through what they did then, not what the son later became.

The adults' occupations also resist a hierarchy imposed by later fame. Photography paid for at least part of the household. Writing supplied ambition, identity, and occasional publication. Care work, much of it unrecorded, sustained the children. Administrative work—applications, licenses, court appearances, registrations—made the other activities possible. A biography centered on intellectual achievement can easily treat these as background, but in 1928 and 1929 they were the substance of family life.

The chronology reveals no moment when those forms of work were reconciled. A studio client, a grant application, a court appointment, and an infant's needs would have drawn on the same limited time, but the archive does not provide a calendar. It would be plausible to describe exhaustion or tension; plausibility is not enough. The narrative can state the concurrent demands and leave their daily arrangement unknown.

Similarly, the child-support undertaking should not be made into a moral verdict by itself. Formal acknowledgment and a specified amount show responsibility accepted before an office. Without receipts, they do not show performance. The existence of the obligation neither proves devoted fatherhood nor proves neglect. Later chapters may add evidence of presence, letters, or separation; this chapter records only what the 1929 document can bear.

The legal action initiated by Alf deserves the same neutrality. It changed a status that did not match biological paternity. The source summary does not reveal whether his primary concern was accuracy, money, personal conflict, or another consideration. Assigning motive would turn a procedural fact into private drama. His continuing role as Maidi's father must remain separate from the decision concerning Alexander.[24]

[24] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.

Hanka's use of a compound surname shows that a legal transition need not produce a clean social one. Grothendieck connected her to the family of birth and to the name her son would carry. Raddatz connected her to a marriage and to Maidi. The compound form could function commercially and personally even when agencies continued to use a simpler official form. No evidence in the available record records a single declaration of what the name meant to her.

For Alexander, the result was a surname derived from the maternal line rather than either father's working name. That fact later became so familiar that it can appear inevitable. In 1928 it was not. It arose from a particular configuration of marriage, divorce, court action, and acknowledgment. A different legal sequence could have left another documentary result. Recognizing contingency does not diminish the name; it restores its history.

How this book names him

The chapter's archive is thus an archive of acts more than scenes. Someone notified a registry. A court dissolved a marriage. Police issued a card. Another court altered a legal relation. A father appeared before youth welfare. A directory listed a studio. A writer applied for assistance. These verbs provide movement without invented atmosphere. They also show that early life can be narrated closely even when the infant's consciousness is inaccessible.

They also determine the book's naming practice. In narration after the 1929 proceedings, "Grothendieck" can become the default surname because it is the stable historical and project form. "Raddatz" remains necessary whenever the initial registration or Alf's legal relation is at issue. "Schurik" belongs to documented family usage, not to an intimate narrator pretending familiarity. "Alexandre" belongs to French contexts. Stating these rules prevents stylistic variation from turning into an unsupported claim about identity.

The rules must remain revisable if original records alter the dates of first use. A photograph caption might move Schurik earlier; a marginal registry note might specify the surname change; a letter could show which form Hanka used before a court acted. Until such objects are consulted, the text marks secure ranges rather than announcing a first utterance. Authority control is not clerical decoration. It keeps later chapters from giving one person several accidental biographies.

This discipline is particularly important for indexing and quotation. A reader searching Raddatz must be led to the birth and legal proceedings without being directed into Alf's separate history indiscriminately. A quotation using Alexandre must retain its language while the surrounding prose identifies the same subject.[25]

Writing, photography, politics

The pair reportedly continued to revise prose and imagined a book that might establish their literary standing. Grothendieck later wrote of sponsorship consumed without the promised work being produced. That recollection belongs to a later family judgment and lacks a financial ledger in the available record. It can show the adult son's view of recurring ambition and noncompletion. It cannot determine how the money was spent or which person was responsible.[26]

Writing and photography shared material conditions. Both required time, equipment, a place to work, and some protection from immediate need. The studio offered rooms and a commercial base, but also rent, clients, chemical work, and infant care. To say that the

[25] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15. First dated uses of the name variants remain unresolved.
[26] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15. Retrospective family interpretation only.

couple failed because they lacked discipline would ignore those pressures. To say that circumstances alone prevented completion would ignore choices and conflict. The evidence supports repeated aspiration under unstable conditions, not a complete allocation of cause.

The household's political life during 1928 and 1929 is less visible than the earlier exile networks. Scharlau found no tangible evidence of major revolutionary activity by Sasha in these years. Lack of evidence does not show that he abandoned anarchism; his 1927 donation and later commitments argue against such a simple conclusion. It does prevent the studio from being represented as a political headquarters without records of meetings, publications, or organizational roles.[27]

The ordinary administrative acts may have consumed more attention than political legend suggests. A birth registration, divorce, identity card, legitimacy action, paternity acknowledgment, support obligation, business listing, and grant application all occurred within roughly eighteen months. These documents show a family engaged repeatedly with institutions it could criticize but not ignore. The state entered through the child's name, the father's papers, the mother's marriage, and the terms of work.[28]

The surviving photographs create a quieter record. Images of the children indicate that the family's own craft was turned toward its members. Once provenance is checked, inscriptions and dates may help establish when Maidi joined the household and when Schurik became common usage. Until then, the photographs should not be mined for expressions or relationships. A child looking away from the camera is not evidence of alienation; an adult holding an infant is not proof of ease.[29]

Berlin remembered

Later Grothendieck remembered the Berlin years as containing deep identification with his father and great admiration for both parents. That recollection describes how he organized early memory as an adult. He had been under two throughout the period covered here. It should not be used to supply thoughts to the infant in 1928 or to settle conflicts reported by others. The chronological distance must accompany the testimony.[30]

The same principle applies to later accounts of the parents' quarrels. Their relationship was conflictual in Hanka's novel and in Grothendieck's reflections, but the surviving novel stops before this period, and no contemporaneous diary in the available record records a particular dispute in 1928–1929. Generalizing backward from later testimony may identify a pattern; it cannot produce scenes, dates, or an infant witness.

By the end of 1929, Alexander Grothendieck existed in records under the name familiar to history. That documentary settlement did not settle the household. Hanka's surname remained variable. Sasha's legal identity remained Tanaroff. Alf's relation to Maidi continued even after divorce, while his legal relation to Alexander had been disclaimed. The youth welfare service stood within the father–child relation through support and guardianship. One name had stabilized while the surrounding relations remained distributed.

This is why a close reading of the records matters more than a symbolic story about naming. The documents did things. The birth notice placed a child within a marriage. The divorce ended that marriage. The court action removed one legal presumption. The paternity declaration created an acknowledged relation and monetary obligation. The address book made a business findable. The identity card made a refugee legible under an assumed

[27] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[28] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[29] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15.
[30] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chap. 15, retrospective testimony only.

surname. None simply described an independent reality; each altered the field in which the family could act.

The records also show their own limits. They classify without narrating care. They state money without showing payment. They give addresses without proving continuous residence. They identify relationships without measuring affection. They can be more reliable than memory for dates and less informative than memory about meaning. A factual biography needs both kinds of source while refusing to make either answer questions beyond its reach.

The year 1929 closes without a scene. There is no verified evening on which the family adopted its final arrangement and no document that announces the end of uncertainty. The child had moved from Raddatz to Grothendieck through law; the father had acknowledged him as Tanaroff; the mother operated under forms of Grothendieck and Raddatz; the family called the child Schurik. That plurality is not a puzzle to solve. It is the historical result.

The next chapter begins when residence and presence start to separate. Its subject is the father's movement away from Berlin in the years leading to 1933 and the evidence by which absence can be measured. This chapter delivers only the state reached in 1929: a named child, an acknowledged father, a documented studio, and no warrant for imagining that documentary order produced domestic security.

Chapter 4

The Absent Father

> *Mon père avait disparu à Auschwitz, en 1942.*
>
> My father had disappeared at Auschwitz in 1942.
>
> — Alexander Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, Promenade, §1, footnote (*)

Berlin in 1933: after the studio

At the beginning of 1933, the household no longer had the stable commercial trace supplied by the earlier photographic studio. The directly inspected 1929 address book lists Hanka Grothendieck-Raddatz's business at Brunnenstraße 165, while Scharlau found no continuation after 1930; the evidence supports the loss of a fixed directory entry without turning that silence into a documented eviction.[1]

Figure 5. Stolperstein for Alexander Schapiro, Brunnenstraße 165, Berlin-Mitte (photographed 2017).
OTFW, Berlin · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

This reduced resolution defines the chapter's opening conditions. Hanka's surviving manuscript ends before Alexander's birth, the address books cease to provide a stable point, and later testimony suggests renewed mobility without a continuous address sequence; by

[1] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*, 1075; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.

1933 the family remains visible through work, photographs, and memory, while the rooms in which daily life occurred have largely disappeared from the record.[2]

Economic instability did not mean that every day was destitute. Tanaroff could earn money with the instant camera, and a good day in a busy place might produce many small sales. The detailed account in *Eine Frau* belongs mainly to the earlier street-photography period, and its totals cannot be projected onto 1929–1933. It does show why income varied: plates and chemicals had to be purchased, work depended on crowds, and the price of each image was low. A fixed studio brought rent and storage as well as shelter from weather. Losing the listing therefore marks the disappearance of an economic platform, not proof that photographic work ceased. Scharlau reports that Tanaroff continued to be known as a street photographer in Berlin and later in Paris.[3]

The camera also complicates the meaning of presence. A worker who had to go where customers gathered could be away from the household without having left it. Scharlau says that in earlier summers Hanka and Tanaroff traveled to fairs and resort areas for work. No itinerary in the available record establishes comparable trips after Alexander's birth. The fact should therefore remain background, not become a childhood scene. It is enough to recognize that a mobile occupation and unstable registration made the father's location harder to recover even before political flight.[4]

The address book and the camera describe two different kinds of work. The directory fixes a proprietor, occupation, and business address at the moment its information was compiled, whereas the instant camera belonged to a trade that could move toward fairs, streets, and crowds; neither source by itself shows how many days the family shared the studio or how much income reached the household.[5]

Scharlau's account of the photographic practice, based partly on Hanka's literary manuscript and surviving images, is strongest at the level of material action. Tanaroff operated an instant apparatus despite the loss of his left arm, processed small plates, and depended on direct sales, while Hanka participated in the enterprise and held the registered business role; the vivid dialogue and crowd choreography in the novel remain literary and do not enter this chapter.[6]

A fixed studio altered that mobile economy without making it secure. It offered an address, storage, indoor work, and a business identity under Hanka's name, but it also required rent and placed the enterprise within licensing and directory systems; when the listing disappeared after 1930, the archive lost a stable point even if Tanaroff continued taking photographs elsewhere.[7]

This distinction guards against two opposite exaggerations. The studio should not be treated as proof that the family had achieved lasting middle-class stability, yet its disappearance should not be narrated as a documented eviction into homelessness; the supported movement is from a direct business trace to a less resolved period whose settings survive mainly through later testimony.[8]

Photography also affected what later survived. A household organized partly around image-making naturally left portraits, but those pictures record moments of exposure rather than ordinary relations, and their existence cannot establish harmony, fear, neglect, or the

[2] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[3] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13, 15, 18.
[4] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[5] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*, 1075; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[6] Grothendieck, *Eine Frau*.
[7] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.
[8] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.

amount of time Tanaroff spent at home. The same object may confirm presence while remaining silent about care.[9]

The father's work therefore belongs to the chapter not as picturesque atmosphere but as a condition of the household. It supplied irregular income, required mobility, depended on Hanka's registered role, and gave Tanaroff a recognizable occupation that he could resume elsewhere; when political danger finally moved him out of Berlin, the family lost both an adult presence and part of its working arrangement.[10]

Maidi, Alexander's older half sister, adds another measure of the household's changing boundaries. Scharlau places her within the four-person Berlin household formed by Hanka, Tanaroff, Maidi, and Alexander, while also acknowledging uncertainty about when she returned from extended stays with maternal relatives. Alf Raddatz remained part of her reported legal history but not of this daily household; neither the exact duration nor the domestic arrangement can be recovered continuously.[11]

Tanaroff's relationship with Maidi resists a simple biological hierarchy, although the private object that bears on it has not been inspected. Scharlau reports a letter from Paris dated August 8 and characterizes its closing as paternal, but this chapter uses neither wording nor signature as direct evidence; it relies only on Scharlau's date and location for the exit terminus. Grothendieck's separate retrospective statement about receiving no paternal letters during the later foster years remains his testimony, not an explanation of Tanaroff's conduct.[12]

[9] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[10] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13, 15, 18.
[11] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[12] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15 note 51; Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 608.

A household on Berlin's precarious edge

The studio belonged to a part of Berlin in which migrants, small trades, political networks, and crowded housing overlapped, but the address does not authorize a cinematic neighborhood. Scharlau places the family near Eastern European Jewish and émigré life around Brunnenstraße, while the directly inspected directory supplies only a business entry; no source identifies the view from the rooms, the neighbors on a particular day, or the path the children took through the district.[13]

What can be recovered is a social position. Hanka and Tanaroff moved among writers, workers, anarchists, and refugees without occupying the prosperous cultural Berlin that later memory often treats as the whole city; their household depended on irregular work and informal relations, and its political commitments did not remove rent, food, childcare, or documentary requirements.[14]

The parents' literary ambitions formed part of that economy rather than an alternative to it. Scharlau reports collaborative writing, an unsuccessful application by Hanka for literary support, and plans that produced less completed work than the adults hoped; the lost application and Hanka's incomplete manuscript show aspiration and interruption, but they cannot be used to diagnose talent, discipline, or parental commitment.[15]

Political generosity could also compete with household resources. Earlier records described by Scharlau include donations to persecuted anarchists, while the family narrative repeatedly mentions money owed for Maidi's care; placing those facts together shows competing obligations, although no ledger allows the biographer to calculate what one payment prevented or which adult made each decision.[16]

Maidi's presence keeps the household from becoming merely a preface to her brother. Scharlau's account places her with Hanka, Tanaroff, and Alexander during at least part of the Berlin period, and later memory suggests that Tanaroff sometimes acted in a paternal role toward her; her exact movements between maternal relatives and the Berlin home remain uncertain, so the chapter does not turn intermittent residence into a continuous domestic scene.[17]

Alexander's early childhood is even less continuously visible. Photographs and his adult recollections confirm a remembered family relation, but the available record does not contain a diary, school record for these years, or contemporaneous observer capable of narrating ordinary days; the absence of such material is why work, address, and later testimony must carry separate parts of the account.[18]

The household's unorthodox structure should not be romanticized as freedom from institutions. Marriage law, licensing, surname usage, police registration, and youth welfare all appear in Scharlau's narrative, while private choices governed partnership, work, and care; the family lived through both systems at once, accepting some relations and resisting others without gaining immunity from administrative power.[19]

By the beginning of the 1930s, the studio no longer supplied a directory trace, and the family's settings become correspondingly harder to follow. That reduced resolution matters because it precedes the political crisis: before Tanaroff left, the archive had already shifted from a directly locatable business toward later accounts of mobility and scarcity, making

[13] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[14] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.
[15] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[16] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.
[17] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.
[18] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[19] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.

the final Berlin years less suited to scene and more dependent on carefully separated source layers.[20]

A family remembered afterward

Grothendieck's account of the Berlin years was written at a formidable distance. In *Récoltes et Semailles* he located his investigation of the family rupture in 1979–1980, after both parents had died, and described working from correspondence and a small residue of memory; his prose therefore records an adult inquiry into 1933 rather than a transcript of what he knew at five.[21]

That distinction governs his recollection of the first years. He remembered unusually strong attachment to both parents and a particular identification with his father, but this later testimony neither proves a uniformly peaceful household nor licenses a scene of the child observing Tanaroff's work or waiting for his return. It establishes how the mature writer understood the relation that preceded the break.[22]

Scharlau's reported family photographs provide a different and narrower form of presence: they place people before a camera without demonstrating the quality of domestic relations. His interviews also preserve reports of parental quarrels and temporary absences, yet their source chain cannot establish a particular night, sequence, farewell, or childhood response; these remain attributed family history rather than a reconstructed evening.[23]

Grothendieck later interpreted the parents' changing relation through a spiritual scheme of passivity and dominance. That vocabulary belongs to his adult analysis and cannot diagnose either parent, while Scharlau's report of correspondence from the first months of separation merely shows the material on which part of the later inquiry rested. Because the letters were reportedly destroyed in 1991, the chapter draws no event detail from their contents.[24]

The lost correspondence would have supplied dates, addresses, and contemporaneous language, but its absence leaves later readers with Grothendieck's interpretation and Scharlau's source history. The difference matters because an adult meditation can establish what the rupture came to mean without resolving the departure's exact circumstances or either parent's motive.

Before the break

The remembered Berlin family was neither a conventional household nor a political commune free of ordinary obligations. Hanka and Tanaroff worked, wrote, argued, and cared for children within arrangements shaped by poverty and unstable documentation. Grothendieck's later account nevertheless remembered the first five years as a distinct family period.[25]

Tanaroff's missing arm made his photographic work conspicuous, but it did not make him dependent in every practical task. Scharlau's strongest evidence shows an experienced worker adapting an instant camera and continuing a trade across cities. Hanka's later claim that he needed her help must therefore remain part of a conflicting family narrative.[26]

Hanka's registered role in the studio also resists a simple story of dependence. Her name appeared in the directory, while Scharlau credited Tanaroff with much of the camera work

[20] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[21] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[22] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[23] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[24] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18.
[25] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4 and 607–608.
[26] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 17.

and described their joint travel for business. The enterprise depended on cooperation even when the adults disagreed about work, money, and gendered authority.[27]

Writing occupied a parallel place in their ambitions. Hanka pursued prose shaped by autobiography, and Tanaroff was remembered as planning an account of revolutionary experience that did not survive. Their projects demonstrate aspiration, although incompletion cannot be assigned to one motive or defect.[28]

Maidi's position exposed the household's layered forms of parenthood. Alf remained part of her reported civil history, while Tanaroff appears in later family evidence as someone who sometimes assumed a paternal role. The available materials show relation without allowing a complete account of residence, support, or feeling.[29]

Alexander's early relation to Tanaroff reaches us chiefly through his adult writing. He remembered admiration and identification rather than fear as the defining terms of those first years. That memory cannot erase conflict, but it prevents conflict from being projected across every day before departure.[30]

The parents' quarrels are similarly difficult to scale. Scharlau reports temporary absences after disputes, yet no record counts them or identifies a single occasion. They establish a remembered pattern, not a timetable of domestic instability.[31]

The distinction becomes important when Tanaroff finally left Germany. A later narrator might connect the final migration to earlier nights away, but the child's recognition of finality remains unknown. The biography can describe repeated absence only at the level Scharlau's source supports.[32]

Political identity entered daily life through associations, donations, and the history Tanaroff carried from Russia. Scharlau found no evidence of new German organizational activity during the final Berlin years, which limits claims about immediate police interest. His anarchism remains biographical context rather than proof of a specific underground act.[33]

Hanka's oppositional history was different in form. Earlier work around a stigmatized newspaper and avant-garde theater placed her outside respectable convention, but Scharlau found no party membership that would define her 1933 position. Those facts complicate danger without yielding a motive for departure.[34]

The household therefore entered 1933 with several kinds of fragility already present. Its fixed business trace had ended, its income remained irregular, and one adult's refugee history exposed him to renewed administrative danger. Nazi rule transformed those vulnerabilities into a crisis that private improvisation could not resolve.

No evidence shows the adults predicting the full course of persecution that followed. Tanaroff had reasons to recognize danger, but the available record does not preserve his words about the decision. Historical consequence must not be substituted for contemporaneous foresight.[35]

The same rule applies to the children. Later separation gave the first family period a sharp boundary in Grothendieck's memory, although neither child left a contemporaneous

[27] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[28] Grothendieck, *Eine Frau*.
[29] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[30] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4.
[31] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[32] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[33] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.
[34] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 11 and 17.
[35] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

account of the father's departure. Their silence in the archive is a limit on scene, not proof of indifference.[36]

By August 8, the one adopted chronological statement is Scharlau's report that Tanaroff was in Paris. Competing departure months remain outside the narrative, and the route remains unrecorded. This restraint allows the chapter to close without turning disagreement into false precision.[37]

The break altered the household before it explained itself. Hanka and the children remained in Berlin, reported correspondence connected the adults, and the loss of Tanaroff's labor created immediate material consequences. Chapter 5 begins with those consequences rather than repeating the evidence for departure.[38]

The pages of *Récoltes et Semailles* remain primary evidence for that later meaning. Grothendieck identified the first family as a decisive early relation and returned to its dissolution while reflecting on patterns he believed he had discovered in 1979–1980; those claims belong securely to the history of his self-understanding even when they cannot reconstruct a child's contemporaneous knowledge.[39]

His retrospective attachment to both parents prevents a simple portrait of Tanaroff as always absent. The adult son remembered the father inside the household before migration and later described prolonged silence, which makes chronology indispensable: early identification, departure, and foster-year correspondence are three different periods rather than evidence for one timeless paternal character.[40]

Scharlau's interviews and documents add external structure without resolving the private relation. They place photographic work, a changing business trace, reported quarrels, and migration around the family memory, but the biographer cannot combine those fragments into continuous domestic observation; the gaps are part of the historical form rather than defects to be hidden with scenes.[41]

This layered reading also preserves Hanka as a separate actor. Grothendieck's later analysis of the parents' bond, Scharlau's judgments about their conduct, and Hanka's earlier literary manuscript arise from different purposes, so none should silently become Hanka's contemporaneous explanation of why she remained, quarreled, or later followed Tanaroff.[42]

The chapter consequently treats remembered love and remembered injury as evidence of the adult writer's relation to the past, not as licenses to rank the parents' affection. That restraint does not diminish the rupture; it locates the claim in the person who made it and allows the migration record to carry its own, narrower weight.

[36] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[37] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18.
[38] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 18.
[39] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4 and 607–608.
[40] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4 and 608.
[41] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[42] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Grothendieck, *Eine Frau*.

The political meaning of an insecure paper

By 1933, Tanaroff's established biography placed him in several categories targeted by the new regime: Scharlau identifies him as Jewish, anarchist, and a refugee from revolutionary Russia, while official museum chronologies document the rapid destruction of civil protections and the expansion of political and anti-Jewish persecution after January. These national developments establish the field of danger without proving an individual warrant, summons, or police action against him.[43]

Scharlau is the principal biographical source for the conclusion that this danger preceded Tanaroff's move to France. Chai and Oort repeat the broad early-life chronology while relying substantially on Scharlau, so their survey cannot be counted as independent corroboration; the only exit terminus used here is Scharlau's report that Tanaroff was in Paris by August 8.[44]

The available record provides no basis for naming a single enforcement act as the cause of departure. Dagmar later remembered Hanka connecting the move to persecution after the Reichstag fire, but the memoir is mediated, chronologically unreliable in places, and unsupported by a Tanaroff-specific police file; the national decree supplies context rather than confirmation of that remembered explanation.[45]

Scharlau also found no tangible evidence of Tanaroff's participation in a German anarchist organization during the final Berlin years. Earlier political commitments and associations remain part of his biography, yet the chapter does not promote them into a claim of current underground activity, because persecution could attach to an attributed history without a newly documented act.[46]

Hanka's documented position differed without yielding a practical counterfactual. Scharlau describes German identity documents, non-Jewish ancestry, oppositional cultural associations, and no known Communist or Social Democratic membership; those facts show different kinds and degrees of danger but leave her feasible courses of action and reasons for following Tanaroff unresolved.[47]

The children's legal positions are not inferred from Tanaroff's papers. The mediated civil record describes different paternity and surname histories, while Alexander's nationality remains unresolved and Maidi's status cannot be derived from household membership; the immediate supported consequence is material, because the departure removed Tanaroff's labor and changed the conditions under which the Berlin household could continue.[48]

The national chronology helps explain why an already fragile documentary position acquired new urgency. Hitler became chancellor on January 30, 1933, the decree issued after the Reichstag fire suspended core civil protections on February 28, and the measures of March and April rapidly expanded dictatorship, political detention, and anti-Jewish exclusion; these dates come from official historical chronologies and describe Germany as a whole, not an enforcement file for Tanaroff.[49]

[43] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17; United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates," Holocaust Encyclopedia, https://encyclopedia.ushmm.org/content/en/article/1933-key-dates; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution'," Hitler and the Germans: Nation and Crime, https://www.dhm.de/archiv/ausstellungen/hitler-und-die-deutschen/en/machtuebertragung.html.

[44] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18 note 51; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," secs. 1.3–1.4.

[45] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates", February 27–28 entries; Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

[46] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.

[47] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17; Koordinierungsstelle Stolpersteine Berlin, "Johanna 'Hanka' Grothendieck," https://www.stolpersteine-berlin.de/en/brunnenstrasse/165/johanna-hanka-grothendieck.

[48] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.

[49] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution'".

For a Jewish refugee known in anarchist circles, the distinction between general policy and individual danger was practical rather than academic. The available record does not need to invent a personal arrest order to show that categories attached to his origin, political history, and uncertain papers had become more threatening, although it still cannot state which warning, encounter, or calculation determined the day he left.[50]

The timing conflict among later chronologies is kept outside the event claim. This chapter selects none of the proposed departure months; Scharlau's report of presence in Paris by August 8 supplies only the latest point needed for the chapter boundary.[51]

Hanka's position cannot be measured simply by subtracting Tanaroff's risks. Her documented ancestry and political history differed, yet she shared his household, economic uncertainty, and oppositional milieu, and the sources do not inventory the practical options available to her after he left; this is why different exposure does not become a claim that remaining was safe or feasible.[52]

The children's situation also changed before any legal conclusion can be drawn. Tanaroff's departure removed a worker and parent from the Berlin household, leaving Hanka to organize daily life while she considered her own departure; Chapter 5 follows the later care arrangements, but the material pressure begins here as a consequence of the first migration.[53]

Political context, documentary insecurity, and family economy thus meet without collapsing into one cause. The available evidence supports a dangerous environment, an adult who left Germany, and a household altered by his absence; it does not support a precise motive hierarchy among fear, politics, partnership, work, and parental obligation.

[50] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17; United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates".
[51] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18 note 51; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," secs. 1.3–1.4.
[52] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17; Koordinierungsstelle Stolpersteine Berlin, "Johanna 'Hanka' Grothendieck".
[53] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

A crisis measured at two scales

At the national scale, the change was rapid and documented. The appointment of Hitler, the emergency decree after the Reichstag fire, the dismantling of constitutional limits, political detention, and anti-Jewish measures all occurred within the first months of 1933, transforming the meaning of a political history or Jewish origin even when no new act had been committed.[54]

At the family scale, the evidence is fragmentary. Scharlau reports that Tanaroff left, that Hanka and the children remained for a time, and that correspondence crossed the new distance; the archive does not preserve a meeting at which the adults set out a plan, nor does it identify which danger, warning, or practical opening determined the departure.[55]

The difference between those scales prevents a familiar error in political biography. General persecution can make flight intelligible without proving an individualized pursuit, while the absence of a personal warrant does not make the broader danger unreal; narrative accuracy depends on holding the public chronology and the private source gap together.[56]

Tanaroff's earlier experience of clandestinity and expulsion may appear to offer a psychological explanation for quick action, but no contemporaneous statement in the available record records his calculation. Scharlau sometimes interprets his history as giving him an unusual sensitivity to danger, and that remains the biographer's inference rather than a motive this chapter adopts.[57]

The household consequences are more directly visible than the decision process. An adult and income-producing worker was gone, Hanka remained with two children and an intention to leave, and the fixed studio had already disappeared from the directories; these facts explain why the existing arrangement could not simply continue without requiring the narrator to rank love, politics, fear, or ideology.[58]

The children's perspectives remain absent from this moment. Grothendieck's later description gives the rupture long-term importance but does not reproduce what he understood before the household dispersed, while no contemporaneous statement from Maidi survives; the political crisis changed their circumstances before the sources reveal their knowledge.[59]

This chapter therefore ends the father's Berlin chronology at a reported destination rather than an imagined decision. The next chapter begins with the care arrangements that followed, preserving event ownership and preventing the same private letter or departure conflict from being explained twice.

[54] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution"'.
[55] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.
[56] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates".
[57] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[58] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.
[59] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.

From January to August 1933

The year opened with a household already lacking the fixed studio that had once anchored its work. Tanaroff could still practice street photography, but income depended on movement and crowds, while Hanka's literary ambitions and the children's care continued within an address history that had become difficult to trace.[60]

On January 30 Hitler became chancellor, and the transfer of power rapidly changed the environment around political opponents, refugees, and Jews. The shift was national before it became visible in any family file, yet Tanaroff's origin and political history placed him within categories made newly dangerous.[61]

The emergency decree of February 28 suspended protections and widened detention after the Reichstag fire. Hanka later connected Tanaroff's departure to that moment in Dagmar's recollection, although the chapter treats the family explanation as memory rather than an individual police record.[62]

Measures in March and April consolidated dictatorship and expanded political and anti-Jewish exclusion. They did not write the family's private decisions, but they narrowed the setting in which a Jewish anarchist refugee with insecure papers could continue to work and reside.[63]

Scharlau found no new German anarchist activity that would explain departure through a specific recent offense. Tanaroff's established commitments and earlier networks nevertheless remained visible parts of his biography, allowing persecution to attach to a history rather than to a fresh act.[64]

The family economy made waiting consequential. Tanaroff's photographic labor contributed to a household whose stable business address had disappeared, and his movement out of Germany removed both an adult presence and a source of income; Hanka and the children remained together for the moment.

Scharlau's chronology next places Tanaroff in Paris by August 8. The private letter that supplies that endpoint remains unquoted and uninspected here, but the reported date and location are enough to mark the completion of the father's Berlin departure.[65]

Correspondence reportedly connected the adults across the new distance. The letters have not survived for inspection, so they provide source history rather than dialogue, yet their reported existence shows that physical separation did not end communication between Hanka and Tanaroff.[66]

By the chapter boundary, then, the father was in France and the remaining household faced the consequences of his absence. Hanka's arrangements for Maidi and Alexander had not yet been narrated; those actions, and Hanka's own journey, belong to Chapter 5.

[60] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.
[61] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution"'.
[62] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[63] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates".
[64] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[65] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18 note 51.
[66] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.

Berlin closes around the household

The political calendar after January moved faster than the family archive. The Reichstag fire on February 27 was followed by the emergency decree on February 28, which suspended protections and enabled detention, and the March 23 Enabling Act gave the government broad legislative power outside normal parliamentary control.[67]

Political repression acquired institutions and places as well as laws. Dachau opened for political prisoners in March, Communist and Social Democratic organizations were attacked, and the new government converted opposition into a category of detention; Tanaroff's anarchist history entered a state environment increasingly hostile to every independent left movement.[68]

Anti-Jewish measures became public in April through the boycott and exclusions from public employment. Tanaroff's Jewish origin was already part of family knowledge, while the assumed surname in western records offered no reliable shield against a regime organizing persecution around ancestry and political history.[69]

These developments did not occur in a separate world from photographic work. Street trade depended on public space, licensing, and tolerance from police, and a refugee photographer could encounter the new state through ordinary attempts to earn money; the household's economy was exposed to the same institutions that governed residence.[70]

The disappearance of the studio listing made that exposure harder to document rather than less real. A fixed business had once given Hanka and Tanaroff an address and commercial identity, while the later return to mobile work placed more of the household's livelihood outside durable records.[71]

Tanaroff's earlier migrations offered practical precedent for leaving. He had traveled through Berlin, Paris, and Belgium, worked with a portable camera, and relied on political or émigré contacts; by 1933 Paris was a known destination rather than an abstract symbol of freedom.[72]

The same history also made documents part of every move. Scharlau's account follows assumed papers, short permits, expulsion threats, and an identification card, showing a life repeatedly negotiated through administrative encounters even though the individual objects await authentication.[73]

Family history supplied another reason the move mattered. Grothendieck later remembered Tanaroff as a central parent in the first household, and Maidi's later evidence suggests a paternal social relation despite their different legal history; departure removed one adult from both children's daily world.[74]

Hanka remained the adult organizing the Berlin household after Tanaroff left. Her work, documents, and political associations differed from his, yet she shared the economic consequences of the migration and the task of caring for two children while considering her own journey.[75]

The children's positions differed in age and prior residence. Maidi's history included stays with maternal relatives, while Alexander's remembered early place centered on the

[67] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates".
[68] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates".
[69] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates".
[70] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[71] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[72] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 18.
[73] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 13.
[74] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[75] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

four-person Berlin home; this contrast shaped the practical setting without granting access to either child's immediate response.[76]

Both children still depended on adult arrangements after Tanaroff left. Their differing histories explain why one shared label for the coming placements would obscure rather than clarify the family chronology.

Correspondence became the first bridge across the new geography. Scharlau reports letters between the parents during the separation, and Grothendieck later used family correspondence while reflecting on the rupture; the exchange connected Berlin and Paris before the family's other routes were settled.[77]

The care problem emerged from that divided geography. One adult had reached France, another remained with the children, and the household no longer had its old work structure; Chapter 5 begins when Hanka turns those conditions into separate arrangements for Maidi and Alexander.[78]

Seen in sequence, the departure was neither a single dramatic night nor a complete family flight. It was the first movement in a staggered dissolution, beginning with political danger and a father's migration and continuing through decisions made after he had left Berlin.

The exact month inside that sequence remains outside the adopted chronology. The reported August 8 Paris terminus gives the chapter a firm exit while preserving the source conflict for future archival review.

This chronology also fixes narrative ownership. Chapter 4 carries Tanaroff from the changing Berlin household to the reported Paris endpoint; Chapter 5 receives Hanka and the children after that move and narrates the arrangements that followed.

Care before the household divided

Before any placement, care still belonged to the Berlin household. Hanka remained with Maidi and Alexander after Tanaroff's move, managing ordinary needs within a family economy already altered by the loss of his work and presence.[79]

The children occupied different positions within that household. Maidi's earlier residence with maternal relatives contrasted with Alexander's remembered place in the Berlin home; their histories shaped practical responsibilities without revealing private responses.

Tanaroff had participated in the household as photographer, partner, and father. His departure changed income and daily presence together, making care an economic question as well as a relation among adults and children.

Hanka's own work history offered no simple replacement for the studio economy. Her writing remained incomplete, the photographic business had lost its fixed listing, and Scharlau's account supplies no stable new employment for the first months of separation.

Reported correspondence linked Berlin and Paris while Hanka remained with the children. The exchange shows that the adults' relation continued across distance, although its unavailable contents leave the division of planning and responsibility unresolved.[80]

Formal care language enters only through mediated records. Scharlau reports earlier youth-welfare involvement, but the missing file supplies no basis for describing who held authority during these months; daily care and legal guardianship remain separate questions.[81]

[76] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[77] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.
[78] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[79] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[80] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.
[81] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

The political crisis intensified this practical pressure. A return by Tanaroff offered no stable assumption under Nazi rule, while Hanka's own departure would require another arrangement for each child.

Nothing in this sequence makes the later placements inevitable in their exact form. It establishes the problem Hanka faced after the first migration: two children still in Germany, one adult already in France, and a household whose economic structure had weakened.

That is the care chronology Chapter 4 can own. It ends before a receiving household or institution is selected, leaving Chapter 5 to narrate the arrangements rather than previewing them.

The end of this chapter also keeps the siblings as separate subjects. Maidi's next residence requires evidence different from Alexander's, and neither route should be inferred from the other child's later account. Chapter 5 begins with that divergence.

The father's departure therefore changes care without completing its reorganization. At the August boundary, Hanka still carries daily responsibility in Berlin, Tanaroff is reported in Paris, and the children's later destinations remain ahead. This is a complete transition rather than an incomplete preview.

A departure without a recorded scene

The departure itself has no recoverable scene. Scharlau marks the reported nighttime exit and the child's alleged immediate hurt as hearsay, while no station, route, companion, farewell, or contemporary family letter fixes the sequence; Grothendieck's later writing establishes only the lasting importance he assigned to the rupture.[82]

What survives is a change of location. Scharlau reports Tanaroff in Paris by August 8, Hanka and the children still in Germany, and parental correspondence during the first months apart; Paris was also a familiar émigré center where Tanaroff had previously lived and worked, although no 1933 lodging or employment record is available.[83]

The private August letter is used only through Scharlau's report of its date and place. Its wording, signature, language, postmark, holder, and rights were not checked, so the chapter neither quotes nor interprets it as evidence of affection, advice, or paternal conduct.[84]

Grothendieck's later account of paternal silence begins with the subsequent foster years and cannot be projected backward into the months before December 1933. It shows how the adult son remembered that later interval, whereas the departure chapter can conclude only that Tanaroff had become geographically absent from the Berlin household while remaining present in family memory and reported correspondence.[85]

Chapter 5 follows what came next: Hanka still had to arrange care for both children before leaving Germany.[86]

[82] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[83] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7, 15, 18.
[84] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15 note 51.
[85] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4 and 608.
[86] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

Paris as a reported endpoint

Paris was not an arbitrary destination in Tanaroff's biography. Scharlau had already followed him there during the 1920s, when Russian émigré and anarchist networks offered contacts and street photography offered a portable way to earn money; the earlier history makes a later return intelligible without proving who received him, where he stayed, or what work began immediately in 1933.[87]

The city's meaning was therefore both practical and limited. It lay outside the regime that had transformed Tanaroff's position in Berlin, contained people and occupations he knew, and provided the address from which Scharlau reports the August letter; none of those facts establishes secure asylum, permanent residence, or a replacement household.[88]

That distinction prevents the destination from becoming a retrospective refuge myth. Later internment and deportation show that France did not supply enduring safety, but those later events should not be used to make every 1933 decision tragic in advance; at this point the evidence supports movement out of immediate German danger and into another uncertain documentary setting.[89]

The Paris endpoint also reveals how an archive often records migration backward. The departure itself leaves no opened ticket or border file, while the destination appears through a biographer's description of a private letter; the result is a firm-enough change of city for narrative sequence and an unresolved route that must remain invisible.[90]

For the family, that asymmetry mattered because the father became knowable at a distance before the circumstances of leaving became knowable. Hanka and the children remained in Berlin at the chapter boundary, parental correspondence reportedly crossed the new distance, and the next practical decisions arose from a separation whose first journey cannot be reconstructed.[91]

The title thus names a change in household relation rather than an essence assigned to Tanaroff. He had been present as worker, partner, photographed family member, and acknowledged father; after migration he was physically elsewhere, yet correspondence, memory, and political history kept him inside the family narrative.[92]

[87] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 18.
[88] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 18.
[89] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.
[90] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18.
[91] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 18.
[92] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.

Absence and memory

The departure survives as a change of city rather than a scene: Scharlau reports Tanaroff in Paris, while station, route, companion, farewell, and sequence at home remain outside the record. Grothendieck's later memory joins intense early attachment to paternal silence during the foster years, establishing the rupture's enduring importance without revealing Tanaroff's motive.[93]

Fatherhood appears through different source forms. Scharlau reports civil acknowledgment, photographs place Tanaroff within the household, and a private letter is described as paternal toward Maidi; these materials establish relation at particular moments while leaving payment, daily care, and emotional consistency unresolved.[94]

The archive preserves those relations unevenly. Grothendieck's French meditation and the 1929 address-book page are directly inspectable, whereas civil files, private correspondence, and much family testimony reach the chapter through Scharlau; Chai and Oort repeat an early-life chronology substantially dependent on his work.[95]

That source hierarchy supports consequence rather than verdict. Grothendieck's adult testimony can establish that the rupture remained painful, yet it supplies neither Maidi's experience nor either parent's private calculation, and nothing in the record turns childhood papers or departure into an origin of later mathematical style.

Once Tanaroff is reported in Paris, Hanka's arrangements belong to Chapter 5. Respecting that boundary prevents the departure from absorbing every later consequence.

[93] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4 and 607–608; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18.
[94] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[95] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13–18; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," secs. 1.3–1.4; *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*.

What 1933 left open

The exit state contains one dated terminus and several open questions. Scharlau places Tanaroff in Paris by August 8, while the departure day, route, and individual trigger remain unknown. Chapter 5 need not reopen that conflict.

When this chapter ends, Hanka and the children were still in Germany. Their later movements require different evidence and belong to the next chapter. This separation keeps chronology from becoming repetition.

The family relation also remains unresolved rather than erased. Grothendieck remembered early attachment, later silence, and enduring significance, while Scharlau reported continued correspondence among adults. Those sources establish persistence and break together.

No legal status passes across the boundary. The paternity, guardianship, and nationality chains remain mediated or unknown, so the next chapter receives people and places rather than adjudicated classifications.

The political context does pass forward. Nazi repression had transformed the danger around Tanaroff and oppositional networks, although no individual enforcement file explains the exact departure. Later chapters may inherit the danger without inventing the missing order.

This limited ending completes the chapter's task. The father is absent from Berlin, present in a reported Paris source, and still central to the adult son's memory. The care arrangements begin only after that point.

The chapter also leaves a recoverable research path. A private-letter inspection could test the terminus and paternal wording, while civil files could test Scharlau's paternity narrative. Neither task requires preserving unsupported detail in the meantime.

Until those objects are obtained, the strongest account remains layered. Direct sources establish Berlin context and Grothendieck's later interpretation, while Scharlau supplies attributed documentary findings.

Nothing else is handed forward as settled fact. Motive, route, immediate childhood response, and legal status remain outside the exit state.

A line drawn to Paris

At the chapter's exit, Scharlau's report places Tanaroff in Paris by August 8 while Hanka, Maidi, and Alexander remained in Germany; no route or exact departure date is asserted, and the private letter contributes no quoted language.[96]

The migration made Tanaroff geographically absent without erasing earlier work, shared residence, reported correspondence, or the adult son's attachment. That distinction prevents both total condemnation and sentimental repair, because the sources establish a broken household relation more readily than they establish motive.[97]

Hanka's remaining arrangements begin the next chapter and receive no preview here.[98]

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[96] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18 note 51.
[97] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4 and 607–608.
[98] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

Chapter 5

The Road South

> *Au lycée, en Allemagne d'abord la première année, puis en France, j'étais bon élève.*
>
> In secondary school—first in Germany for one year, then in France—I was a good student.
>
> — Alexander Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, Promenade, §1 « La magie des choses »

After the father's departure

By August 8, Scharlau places Tanaroff in Paris; Chapter 4 gives the evidence for his departure.[1]

The chronology now follows the three people who remained in Germany. Hanka intended to leave, but the children did not travel with her, and the household's dissolution therefore proceeded through separate care arrangements rather than a common flight. Grothendieck's later account places both separations within the latter part of 1933, while Scharlau's narrative places Alexander's transfer near the end of December; neither source supplies Hanka's border record or Maidi's 1933 intake file.[2]

This division of routes is the chapter's subject. It does not require a railway itinerary or a repeated account of Tanaroff's departure, because the supported sequence begins with Hanka still in Germany, Maidi already living elsewhere by Grothendieck's later recollection, and Alexander remaining with Hanka until the December transfer. The route south belonged to Hanka; for the children, the immediate movement stayed within Germany.[3]

Grothendieck later gathered the period into an adult interpretation of family rupture, drawing on sparse memories and parental correspondence that he examined decades afterward. His account establishes the weight he assigned to 1933, not a continuous record of childhood anxiety or a precise calendar for each decision. The narrative can preserve that retrospective judgment while keeping the event floor narrower: the family ceased to share one household, the two children entered separate care, and Hanka left around the turn of the year according to Scharlau's chronology.[4]

The months after Tanaroff's departure placed different practical questions around each child. Maidi was nine and already had a history of residence with maternal relatives, whereas Alexander was five and still living with Hanka; those facts leave each child's needs and feelings unresolved, but they show why one undifferentiated account of the family's flight would be historically false.[5]

Hanka's role during this interval is visible mainly through outcomes. She remained in Germany after Tanaroff, made two separate care arrangements, brought Alexander to Blankenese, and then left around the year's turn; the unavailable correspondence and admission

[1] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18.
[2] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[3] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[4] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 18.
[5] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 12, 15, 17.

records prevent a reconstruction of the order in which alternatives were considered or of Tanaroff's participation in particular decisions.[6]

This source boundary also limits moral shorthand. The acts had lasting consequences and can be described without reducing Hanka to a mother who simply walked away, because arranging care was itself an action, while the record's silence about consultation and the later pain remembered by Grothendieck remain part of the ethical weight. Consequence can be acknowledged without supplying a private calculation.[7]

The political environment did not choose the arrangements for the adults, but it narrowed the world in which choices were made. Nazi repression transformed Tanaroff's danger, affected oppositional households, and created uncertainty around people connected to Jewish and political refugees; Hanka's documented position differed, yet the sources do not establish a safe, stable alternative available to her.[8]

Nor did the road south produce one destination called home. Tanaroff was already in France according to Scharlau, Hanka was preparing to leave, Alexander would remain in Blankenese, and Maidi's exact 1933 institution is unknown; the map is therefore a record of separation, not a line showing a family traveling together.[9]

The chapter ends before any account of schooling begins. Alexander's education in Blankenese, later German school records, movement into France, and eventual French-language schooling belong to the next chronological sequence; Maidi's later institutional and educational history likewise supplies no explanation for her 1933 placement.[10]

Maidi's unknown 1933 destination

The evidence for Maidi begins with a gap. Grothendieck wrote decades later that she had been placed in an institution several months before his own transfer, but he did not provide an intake record, institutional name, or route. Scharlau later connected her to Hilde Wulff's Erlenbusch home through a letter on that institution's stationery dated June 9, 1938; the later object supports an association by 1938, not a 1933 admission.[11]

Wulff's institutional history bridges neither the five-year gap nor Maidi's missing intake. Through Petra Fuchs, Scharlau reports that Wulff opened a Berlin-Westend home in April 1933 and moved it to Volksdorf in September, but neither source available here places Maidi on the 1933 intake or residence list. The former draft treated that route as a strong reconstruction; the present account withdraws it and leaves the 1933 destination unresolved.[12]

The distinction is substantive rather than verbal. A later letterhead can identify a subsequent relationship, and an institutional chronology can show where the home operated, yet neither proves when Maidi entered, whether she moved with the institution, what administrative category applied, or who arranged the admission. Those unanswered questions prevent the chapter from narrating Berlin-Westend or Volksdorf as her 1933 route.[13]

The same limit applies to judgments about benefit or harm. Scharlau considered Wulff's care fortunate in retrospect, but Maidi left no contemporaneous account in the available record, and her brother's later language is not her testimony. The chapter therefore records

[6] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[7] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[8] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution'"; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[9] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[10] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19.
[11] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[12] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[13] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

separation while leaving her emotional state, view of the institution, and knowledge of her mother's plan unresolved.[14]

Scharlau also describes a July 1938 letter in which Maidi referred to visits with Alexander and considered a later household-service arrangement involving the Heydorns. That document supports contact between the siblings in 1938, while saying nothing about consultation, resilience, injury, or destination in 1933. It belongs here only to demonstrate the temporal boundary of what survives.[15]

The gap illustrates how an attractive reconstruction can become stronger than its evidence. Wulff's institutional chronology fits Grothendieck's broad memory of an institution, and the 1938 stationery supplies a later association, but compatibility across sources does not create a missing admission record; without that record, Berlin-Westend and Volksdorf remain possible contexts rather than Maidi's established route.[16]

The difference between association and intake is especially important because an institution can serve many roles over time. A child might reside there, work there, correspond on its stationery, visit, or remain connected to its director without having entered on the date later biography assumes; only a dated intake or residence source can distinguish those possibilities for 1933.[17]

Grothendieck's own account carries a different limit. He knew that a separation had occurred and later grouped his sister's placement with his own family rupture, yet his text was not Maidi's testimony and did not supply the administrative detail needed to identify her institution; it establishes his understanding of the family structure, not her route or response.[18]

Maidi should therefore remain a person whose evidence is partly independent of her brother's fame. Her later letters show continuing family contact and a life connected to institutions and households beyond the Berlin home, while offering no basis for a nine-year-old's emotional adaptation, consent, or judgment of Hanka.[19]

The exact care arrangement also matters for legal language. Terms such as intake, guardianship, residence, and institutional placement imply distinct procedures, while the available record proves none of them for a named 1933 home; the chapter uses the broad fact of separate care and reserves administrative vocabulary for an authenticated record.

This restraint does not imply that nothing happened until 1938. Hanka made an arrangement for Maidi before leaving, and Grothendieck later remembered that separation as part of the household's dissolution; the historical fact is the loss of common residence, whereas the receiving institution, route, terms, and contemporary experience remain unknown.[20]

The distinction also prevents later institutional success from becoming retrospective justification. Wulff's work and the survival of children in her care may be historically admirable, but until Maidi's 1933 connection is proved, those facts cannot be used to evaluate Hanka's decision or the quality of Maidi's placement.[21]

[14] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[15] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[16] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[17] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[18] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[19] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[20] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607.
[21] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

Hanka's unfinished departure

After Tanaroff reached France, Hanka still had to secure daily care for Alexander before she could leave Germany. Dagmar's late memoir connected that task to Hanka's passport and remembered a financially elaborate initial approach, but no administrative file, inquiry letter, contract, or ledger survives in the available record; the chapter therefore omits the claimed rule, amount, and representations while retaining only the fact that care was negotiated under financial uncertainty.[22]

How Hanka found the Heydorns remains unresolved. Wilhelm Heydorn had appeared years earlier in a proceeding connected with the Hamburg periodical for which Hanka had worked, yet Scharlau found no continuous friendship, and both Dagmar's memoir and Grothendieck's later account present the 1933 contact as one between people without an established personal relationship.[23]

The earlier institutional crossing may explain why later researchers looked for a connection, but it supplies no intermediary. The available record names no referrer, alternative household, or participating welfare office; the route from need to the Heydorn address remains a genuine gap.

The Heydorns' existing practice of caring for several children makes the destination socially intelligible without making the contact inevitable. A household already organized around private foster care could accept another child, but that general capacity does not establish the terms offered, the duration contemplated, or the adults' prior knowledge of one another.[24]

Scharlau reports correspondence between Hanka and Tanaroff during the separation, although the letters were later destroyed after Grothendieck had used them in his own inquiry. Their existence means that physical distance did not end communication between the parents, while their loss prevents any allocation of proposals, instructions, urgency, or responsibility sentence by sentence.[25]

What remains visible is Hanka's action in Germany. She found a household that accepted Alexander, brought him there near the end of December, and then left the country around the year's turn according to Scharlau's chronology; the evidence does not reveal every alternative, but it does show that departure followed rather than preceded the arrangement of care.[26]

This order matters ethically without becoming exculpation. Arranging a place protected Alexander from being left without an adult household, yet the separation removed him from his mother and placed daily authority with people he did not know; both consequences can be stated without attributing a private motive to Hanka or an immediate feeling to the child.[27]

The source record therefore supports neither a story of effortless abandonment nor one of fully planned safeguarding. It shows an urgent private arrangement made under material and political pressure, viewed later from sharply different positions by the receiving adult and the former child.

[22] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[23] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 11 and 17.
[24] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 20.
[25] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18; Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[26] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[27] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.

The doorway in two memories

The transfer to Blankenese survives through two retrospective perspectives rather than a contemporaneous scene. Dagmar Heydorn wrote from the receiving household many decades later, and Scharlau identifies errors in her dates and geography; Grothendieck wrote as the former child after examining family correspondence in 1979–1980. Chai and Oort repeat the broad chronology while relying substantially on Scharlau, so they do not add an independent witness.[28]

At the event level, those sources support only a narrow sequence: Hanka brought five-year-old Alexander from Berlin near the end of December 1933, the Heydorns accepted responsibility for his daily care, and Hanka left Germany around the turn of the year. Dagmar's remembered clothing, possessions, dialogue, educational requests, facial expression, and station departure are omitted because the exact German text and contemporaneous corroboration are unavailable.[29]

The two writers also assign different meanings to the same transfer. Dagmar's memoir centers a household accepting another child despite limited resources, whereas Grothendieck's later account centers the end of the family in which he had lived; neither perspective can be converted into neutral access to Hanka's motive or Alexander's immediate feeling. The chapter therefore reports the change in care and residence while leaving rescue, abandonment, gratitude, hostility, and comprehension outside the event claim.[30]

The distance between the accounts is not a defect to be averaged away. Dagmar remembered the event from the standpoint of adult responsibility and later affection, while Grothendieck revisited it after decades and after reading family correspondence; combining their most vivid details would create a third witness who never existed.

Scharlau's warning about Dagmar's errors provides a concrete reason for restraint. Her memoir displaced the timing of the initial inquiry toward the eve of war and misstated other biographical details, so its remembered sequence cannot establish a precise day, dialogue, object, or gesture; its durable value lies in the receiving household's later account of accepting the child.[31]

Grothendieck's account carries its own temporal structure. He wrote as an adult who regarded 1933 as a decisive break and interpreted the placement through the later experience of foster residence, parental letters, and war; his text establishes that retrospective judgment without turning each remembered feature into a contemporaneous observation.[32]

The transfer-level chronology is nevertheless clear enough for narrative movement. Alexander was five, Hanka brought him from Berlin to Blankenese near the end of December, and the Heydorns accepted daily care before Hanka left Germany; no exact scene is required to understand that the child's place, carers, and ordinary surroundings changed at the year's boundary.[33]

Financial uncertainty belongs to that chronology only in broad form. Both retrospective accounts remember insecure payment, but no contemporary agreement or receipt survives; fee, payment history, and financial influence on the Heydorns' decision remain unresolved.[34]

[28] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.4.
[29] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[30] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[31] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[32] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[33] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[34] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

Authority is similarly divided. Hanka remained Alexander's mother, Scharlau reports a youth-welfare framework whose original file is missing, and the Heydorns assumed daily responsibility; the evidence does not allocate legal power among them or show which office approved the arrangement.[35]

This threshold is the proper stopping point for education. Whatever requests Dagmar later remembered about schooling are not enumerated without the German text, and the actual school years belong to Chapter 7; Chapter 5 records a transfer of care, not the curriculum or language that followed it.[36]

Their disagreement about timing further limits reconstruction. Dagmar misplaced the initial inquiry close to the Second World War, while Scharlau corrected the transfer to late 1933 and distinguished it from the 1939 departure for France. That correction supports a year-end range, not a dated doorway scene, and it keeps the French schooling and wartime journey outside this chapter.[37]

Care as an agreement without security

Both later accounts describe uncertainty about payment, but no contemporaneous agreement, ledger, or receipt has been examined; the account consequently retains no exact fee and makes no claim about performance. Scharlau also reports youth-welfare guardianship, although the underlying file does not establish for this account which official, if any, approved the December arrangement.[38]

The supported change concerns daily care rather than a fully reconstructed legal transfer. The Heydorn household became Alexander's residence, while later correspondence described by Grothendieck shows that Hanka remained part of his family history; the precise terms, duration originally contemplated, and division of authority among parent, guardian, and carers remain unavailable. What became a five-year residence must not be treated as the plan that every adult held in December 1933.[39]

Schooling, relations within the foster household, official travel permissions, and the 1939 journey belong to Chapter 7. At this boundary, the evidence supports only that the Heydorns accepted daily responsibility and gave Alexander a place to live before Hanka departed; it does not support a conclusion about belonging or emotional adaptation.[40]

Private care and public administration need not have coincided in one document. Scharlau's later guardianship narrative shows that offices entered Alexander's history, while the 1933 transfer survives mainly through retrospective accounts; without an approval or placement file, the biography cannot convert household acceptance into a defined legal procedure.[41]

The arrangement's eventual duration was not necessarily its original term. Alexander remained in Blankenese for years, but no surviving agreement states that Hanka, Tanaroff, the Heydorns, or a guardian expected that outcome in December 1933; emergency, boarding, fostering, and indefinite care remain later descriptions of a relation whose initial terms are lost.[42]

Daily responsibility nevertheless had concrete content even when its legal form is obscure. Another household would provide residence, meals, supervision, and eventually schooling,

[35] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.
[36] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[37] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19.
[38] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.
[39] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19.
[40] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19.
[41] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[42] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 608; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

while the parents remained abroad and family contact continued unevenly; these consequences explain why the December transfer mattered without requiring a claim about who possessed final authority.[43]

The payment question belongs to the same missing agreement. Later witnesses remembered uncertainty, which may illuminate the household's resources, but an absent ledger prevents the chapter from turning remembered scarcity into a record of unpaid debt or parental neglect; financial conditions remain context rather than verdict.

Care exceeds the later alternatives of gratitude and criticism. Grothendieck could acknowledge what he received while objecting to hierarchy within the foster household, and Dagmar could remember affection while overlooking how the arrangement appeared to the child; those evaluations belong to Chapter 7's account of the years themselves.[44]

By keeping the initial transfer narrow, the chapter preserves room for that later complexity. It neither prelabels the Heydorn years as rescue nor frames every act of care as an extension of parental abandonment; the year-end evidence establishes a new residence, not a settled moral meaning.

[43] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19.
[44] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 608; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.

Hanka goes south

Scharlau places Hanka's departure after Alexander's transfer and around the turn of 1933/1934, but the available record contains no ticket, passport stamp, arrival registration, or verified route. Dagmar's later memory of same-night urgency is not used to narrow that range, and the chapter names France only as the destination reported by the biographical chronology.[45]

Grothendieck later interpreted his mother's journey through his understanding of the parents' bond, yet his interpretation leaves her practical choices and the pressures of a particular day unresolved. The record shows different kinds and degrees of danger for Hanka and Tanaroff, while offering no basis for a counterfactual claim that she could simply have remained.[46]

The immediate consequence is geographic rather than psychological: Hanka and Tanaroff were reported in France, Alexander lived in Blankenese, and Maidi lived elsewhere at an institution that the available 1933 evidence does not identify. Scharlau's separate account places Alf Raddatz under mounting political pressure, but that context neither identifies Maidi's destination nor supplies an alternative care arrangement.[47]

The resulting network joined parents abroad to children in separate German care arrangements, although the frequency of letters, payments, official involvement, and personal contact remains only partly visible. It was neither a common family migration nor a state-organized evacuation; the available record leaves the exact allocation of responsibility among decisions made under political and material pressure unresolved.[48]

The pressure surrounding those decisions was not abstract. Germany's new regime had already suspended civil protections, expanded detention, and begun systematic political and anti-Jewish exclusion, while Scharlau reports that Tanaroff's history placed him in direct danger; Hanka's exposure differed, but difference does not identify a viable alternative residence, income, or family arrangement.[49]

Hanka's documentary position also remains bounded by time. Scharlau later found German consular documentation from 1939, yet that object cannot establish the passport or permission used at the year turn, and Dagmar's remembered explanation about a withheld passport has no supporting administrative file; the crossing therefore remains a biographical range rather than a legal event reconstructed from papers.[50]

France was a destination rather than a demonstrated common home. Tanaroff had earlier contacts and work there, Hanka followed according to the reported chronology, and later sources place the adults in different French locations; arrival in one country did not by itself reunite the four-person household or settle the parents' own domestic relation.[51]

Reported parental correspondence complicates a picture of total disappearance. The letters indicate continued communication between Hanka and Tanaroff, and Grothendieck later remembered occasional maternal letters during foster care, but the destruction or private status of those objects prevents a detailed account of money, planning, affection, or conflict across the border.[52]

[45] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.
[46] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.
[47] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 16–18.
[48] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.
[49] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution'"; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[50] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.
[51] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.
[52] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 608; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.

The journey's moral consequence therefore lies first in changed responsibility. Hanka left after arranging care, but departure placed ordinary decisions in other households and made contact dependent on distance, money, and postal exchange; stating those consequences is more defensible than claiming either that she had no choice or that an easy alternative was available.

The family's political commitments remain relevant without becoming an excuse. Opposition to authoritarian rule and allegiance to anarchist ideals help explain why accommodation to Nazi Germany was difficult, while they do not erase the children's dependence or predetermine how care should have been arranged.[53]

This balance also prevents Hanka's move from being narrated solely through the absent father. She organized the children's care, crossed the border under unknown documentation, and entered a precarious life in France; her actions had consequences that can be judged historically even though her private hierarchy of motives remains unavailable.

The long future inside a short passage

Grothendieck's retrospective passage crosses from December 1933 to 1939 in a few lines, summarizing residence with the Heydorns, intermittent maternal letters, paternal silence, and eventual movement to France. Those later endpoints explain the weight he assigned to the transfer, but the five intervening years, including German schooling and the route into French education, belong entirely to Chapter 7.[54]

The present chapter closes at the turn of 1933/1934. Alexander's residence with the Heydorns had begun, Hanka had left Germany according to the reported chronology, and Maidi's exact institution remained unknown; nothing in that boundary authorizes a preview of French lessons, lycée attendance, or wartime schooling.[55]

Keeping those limits also prevents the late-December transfer from becoming a dramatic summary of the whole family history. The supported sequence is modest: Hanka found care for Alexander, another arrangement had already been made for Maidi, and Hanka then left around the year's turn; the unavailable records do not reveal every negotiation, motive, or legal step.[56]

Refuge without a common destination

Paris was familiar from Tanaroff's earlier western exile, when Scharlau places him among émigré and anarchist contacts and describes street photography as his trade. Those connections make the destination intelligible without establishing a 1933 host, address, job, or permit; later photographs show the occupation in Paris only within an unresolved date range.[57]

Scharlau also describes interwar France as a major destination for immigrants and political refugees whose reception grew increasingly contested. That background explains why France could function as refuge without proving that Tanaroff received asylum or secure residence, and the chapter makes no legal claim from the unseen Nansen or police objects.[58]

Hanka's crossing belongs to a different documentary chain. A later German consular record shows continued documentation under a married surname in 1939, while leaving the paper,

[53] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[54] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[55] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 608; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[56] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[57] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 18.
[58] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18; United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)* (n.d.), https://archives.ungeneva.org/refugees-mixed-archival-group-nansen-fonds.

permission, and border category used around the turn of 1933/1934 unidentified; Dagmar's remembered passport explanation remains late testimony rather than an administrative fact.[59]

The children did not cross an international border in this chapter. Alexander moved within Germany to Blankenese, and Maidi moved into an unidentified care arrangement within Germany; describing either child as legally exiled or stateless would import a status that the available records do not establish.[60]

Later foreigner language and French schooling cannot be projected backward onto these domestic transfers. Those experiences belong to wartime France, while the 1933 evidence supports only parental migration and the children's continued residence in Germany.[61]

Different verbs are therefore necessary for different people: Scharlau describes Tanaroff as fleeing danger, Hanka as leaving after arranging care, and the children as entering separate German households or institutions. The words mark distinct movements and responsibilities rather than four versions of one journey.

The political history remains essential because none of these movements occurred in ordinary conditions. Nazi consolidation transformed the risk around a Jewish anarchist refugee and oppositional networks, while Hanka's practical alternatives and both parents' private motives remain unresolved.[62]

[59] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.
[60] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[61] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 17; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.
[62] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution"'.

What the accounts can carry

Dagmar and Grothendieck wrote for different purposes and from opposite sides of the transfer. Dagmar memorialized a household that accepted a child, whereas Grothendieck examined the loss of the household formed by his parents, sister, and himself; Scharlau selected and translated both, and Chai and Oort later compressed Scharlau's account rather than supplying independent corroboration.[63]

Their common event floor excludes dialogue and private motive. Hanka contacted the Heydorns despite no established prior personal relationship, brought Alexander to Blankenese near the end of December, and left Germany around the year's turn after the household accepted daily care. The sources remember financial uncertainty while remaining silent about contemporaneous terms; later assessments of happiness, gratitude, injury, hierarchy, and rescue belong to their speakers rather than the narrator.[64]

The asymmetry of agency can be stated without inventing a child's mind: adults corresponded, negotiated, accepted responsibility, and departed, while Alexander was moved between households. Maidi's position is less recoverable because no contemporary account records consultation or response, and the 1938 material establishes later contact only; neither child receives an emotional label in this chapter.[65]

The source dependency behind those accounts is part of their meaning. Grothendieck's French text is directly inspectable as his later testimony, Dagmar's memoir is known through Scharlau's translated excerpt, and Chai and Oort derive the early-life summary substantially from Scharlau; agreement among the latter two therefore does not create a second witness to the transfer.[66]

This hierarchy is why the revised draft contains no direct language from the private inquiry, remembered dialogue, educational requests, or farewell. Removing those phrases does not make the sources useless; it assigns them the narrower task of showing how the participants later framed the transfer while leaving the event narration at the level supported by chronology.

The two perspectives also prevent a simple moral binary. A household can accept care under difficult conditions and a child can later experience hierarchy or rupture, because protection from one danger does not determine the meaning of every daily relation; the chapter preserves both retrospective positions without choosing a complete verdict before the years themselves are narrated.

Maidi's absence from the witness pair is equally significant. Her later letters show connection to Alexander and the Heydorns, but the sources do not give her 1933 words, making any three-person synthesis of the siblings' experience impossible.

The account therefore remains intentionally asymmetrical while still being complete at its boundary. It identifies the adults who acted, the child who entered Blankenese, the sister whose exact destination is unknown, and the year-turn departure reported for Hanka; no additional scene is needed to move the chronology into Part II.

[63] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.4.

[64] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17–20.

[65] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.

[66] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.4.

Where the year ended

At the turn of 1933/1934, Scharlau's chronology places both parents in France and Alexander in Blankenese, while Grothendieck's retrospective account says that a separate arrangement had been made for Maidi without identifying the institution. Those are the only endpoints used. The private Paris letter is not quoted or independently treated, Wulff's later association is not projected backward, and no guardian, welfare office, station, or border route is supplied without an examined record.[67]

The four people also continued under different names and administrative descriptions, but those forms do not settle nationality or the division of legal authority. Tanaroff used the identity under which Scharlau follows him in western records; Hanka appears under changing married and family names; Maidi remained Raddatz; Alexander bore Grothendieck. Their distribution across files shows a dispersed family, not a single legal status.[68]

Political pressure supplied context without dictating one inevitable decision. Nazi rule placed Tanaroff, a Jewish anarchist refugee, in a different documented danger from Hanka, while her practical alternatives and predominant motive remain unresolved. The children's care arrangements emerged through private contacts and institutions rather than a unified state plan.[69]

The positions at the end of the year are few but sufficient. Tanaroff was already in France by the end of Chapter 4, Hanka left around the year's turn, Alexander lived in Blankenese, and Maidi lived elsewhere in Germany at an institution not identified by a 1933 record.[70]

Two children, two histories

The siblings entered the family rupture with different prior histories. Maidi had spent substantial periods with maternal relatives, whereas Alexander's first five years were remembered within the Berlin household. Those outlines leave each child's response unresolved.[71]

Maidi's age may have changed the practical questions adults faced, but age is not evidence of independence. At nine she still required care, schooling, and an adult household, while the record remains silent about consultation. Later competence is insufficient to fill that silence.[72]

Alexander's younger age likewise supplies no immediate feeling. He was five when Hanka brought him to Blankenese, and adult recollection later gave the event decisive weight. The chapter states dependence and movement without imagining comprehension at the doorway.[73]

The sources also preserve the siblings unevenly. Alexander became the author of a vast retrospective text, while Maidi appears through later letters summarized by someone else. Biography must not let abundance of one voice become authority over the other child's experience.[74]

That imbalance affects language about family injury. Grothendieck interpreted both placements within one rupture, but only his own experience is available in his voice. Maidi's separation belongs to the chronology, whereas its emotional meaning remains hers and is unavailable.

[67] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[68] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.
[69] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17, 19, 20.
[70] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[71] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 12 and 15.
[72] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[73] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[74] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.

The care arrangements therefore require separate statements. Alexander's destination is supported by retrospective testimony and later residence evidence, while Maidi's exact 1933 institution lacks an intake record. Combining them as parallel foster placements would give the second route a certainty it does not have.

Later association with Wulff's institution remains historically relevant when properly dated. The 1938 stationery and Scharlau's account connect Maidi to Erlenbusch by that later period, while the moment, place, and terms of her earlier entry remain unresolved.[75]

Wulff's institutional history also deserves its own chronology. The home operated in Berlin and then Volksdorf during 1933, according to the mediated scholarly account. Until Maidi appears in its records, those dates describe the institution rather than the child.[76]

The Heydorn evidence has the opposite shape. The receiving household is known, but the initial inquiry, agreement, payment, and official approval are missing. Retrospective accounts identify the transfer while leaving its procedure incomplete.

This asymmetry shows why one general word for care can mislead. Residence, boarding, fostering, guardianship, and institutional intake refer to different social or legal relations. The chapter uses ordinary care language unless a specific record supports something narrower.

Daily care nevertheless had real consequences. The children no longer lived with Hanka, and other adults assumed responsibility for food, shelter, supervision, and later education. Those outcomes do not require a complete legal file to be historically significant.[77]

Separation also changed sibling contact. Scharlau's later material indicates visits between Maidi and Alexander, showing that different residences did not erase the relationship. The evidence begins too late to establish how often contact occurred in the first years.[78]

The parents remained connected to this dispersed network unevenly. Grothendieck remembered occasional maternal letters and no paternal letter during foster care. His testimony defines his correspondence history, not Maidi's or the parents' full conduct.[79]

Financial support is similarly fragmented. Later reports mention uncertainty and later receipts, but no complete ledger covers either child's care. The chapter therefore refuses both a total-support claim and a total-nonpayment claim.

The household choices occurred while political danger was accelerating. That context matters because ordinary family resources were already limited and oppositional networks faced new pressure. It does not prescribe one correct arrangement after the fact.[80]

Hanka's action remains the clearest link between the routes. She arranged care for both children, personally brought Alexander to Blankenese, and left Germany afterward. The record does not show every conversation, but it preserves that sequence.

Tanaroff's part in the arrangements is less visible. Scharlau reports correspondence with Hanka, yet the absent letters leave particular proposals unattributed. Physical absence proves neither complete control nor complete disengagement.[81]

The receiving adults also deserve measured agency. The Heydorns agreed to care for Alexander, and an unidentified institution accepted responsibility for Maidi. Acceptance protected the children from having no placement, while its later quality requires evidence from subsequent years.

[75] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[76] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[77] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607.
[78] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[79] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 608.
[80] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution"'.
[81] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.

This distinction prevents protection from erasing loss. A new household can supply necessities while the end of a previous household remains painful in retrospective memory. Both propositions may be true without yielding a complete judgment of the carers.[82]

The same distinction prevents loss from erasing care. Grothendieck's later criticism does not make every reported act by the Heydorns harmful, just as Dagmar's affection does not settle his experience. The years must be narrated from their own evidence.[83]

At the December threshold, then, biography can state place and responsibility more securely than emotion. Alexander entered a known household, Maidi remained in an unidentified institution, and Hanka prepared to leave. The rest belongs to later chronology.

This is also why French education remains absent. Neither child crossed into a French school system during the chapter's event range. Any account of language, curriculum, or lycée life would move beyond the year-turn boundary.[84]

The divided routes did not predict the later mathematician. They established new conditions of residence and care, but no source connects those conditions causally to a mathematical style. The chapter leaves that false prophecy unused.

The two evidentiary histories finally meet only at the level of family structure. By the time Hanka left, neither child shared her daily household. Their destinations, records, and later memories remained distinct.[85]

What crossed and what remained

Hanka crossed into France while the children remained in separate German care arrangements, and later evidence indicates continuing but uneven family contact. Grothendieck remembered occasional maternal letters and paternal silence during the foster years, whereas Scharlau describes later sibling contact; these traces show persistence while leaving the frequency of letters, payments, visits, and 1933 decisions unresolved.[86]

Daily care shifted without yielding a complete legal account. The Heydorns supplied Alexander's residence, and some official framework existed according to Scharlau, but the unopened guardianship and placement files prevent a conclusion about approval, authority, or nationality; Maidi's corresponding 1933 institution remains unknown. Kinship, residence, financial support, and legal status must therefore remain separate rather than being condensed into a claim that the children simply acquired new families.[87]

The road south ended this chapter with provisional safety rather than reunion. Hanka and Tanaroff were reported in France, Alexander had a place in Blankenese, and Maidi lived elsewhere under an arrangement whose location the evidence does not recover; the family's shared Berlin residence had ended, while its later correspondence and memories continued across the separation.[88]

That separation created several lines of later contact without restoring one household. Grothendieck remembered occasional letters from Hanka, Scharlau reports later sibling visits, and the parents themselves corresponded across periods of separation; these traces show persistence of relation while leaving frequency, tone, payment, and practical support unresolved.[89]

[82] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8.
[83] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.
[84] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 17; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.
[85] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607.
[86] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17–19.
[87] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 19.
[88] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 18.
[89] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 608.

The receiving households also did not erase the parents' social identities. Alexander continued to be known through Hanka and Tanaroff's family history, while Maidi's later evidence connected her to relatives and carers across institutional boundaries; residence changed who provided daily care without producing a simple replacement family in the available record.[90]

Legal vocabulary cannot complete what the domestic evidence leaves open. Scharlau's mediated paternity and guardianship narratives explain why offices later appeared, while the 1933 placement procedure, Hanka's crossing paper, and both children's nationality remain unauthenticated and outside the chapter's factual claims.[91]

The chapter closes, then, with movement rather than resolution. The adults had left Germany, the children had entered separate forms of care, and every later claim about schooling, adaptation, danger, or reunion depends on evidence from the years that follow; the road south had divided the family before it carried Alexander anywhere beyond Germany.

The turn of the year

The chapter's final date remains a range rather than a day. Scharlau places Hanka's departure around the turn of 1933/1934, and no opened travel object narrows it. That range is sufficient for continuity.

Alexander's next chapter begins in Blankenese. The transfer has occurred, but schooling, household hierarchy, political danger, and the 1939 journey have not yet been narrated. French education remains later still.[92]

Maidi's position is different because her 1933 institution is unresolved. Later Wulff evidence may guide research but stays outside continuity as a proven residence, and her emotional response remains unassigned.

The parents' position also resists simplification. Both were reported in France, yet the available record does not establish one residence, secure status, or continuous partnership. Their later chronology must begin from that uncertainty.

The family entered 1934 dispersed across households and borders. That statement is complete at the level of supported chronology, even though the records of care, payment, and legal authority remain incomplete.

The remaining research questions are concrete rather than rhetorical. An intake record could identify Maidi's institution, an inquiry letter could clarify the Heydorn contact, and a travel object could date Hanka's crossing. The prose does not simulate any of them.

Until those records appear, the chapter's ethical task is restraint. It names the adults' actions and the children's changed residences while withholding motives, feelings, and administrative conclusions. That is enough to preserve consequence.

The road south therefore closes as a divided route. It does not become a verdict about love, care, or belonging before the later evidence is heard.

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[90] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[91] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[92] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.

Chapter 6

Stateless

C'était la guerre, et on était des étrangers — des « indésirables », comme on disait.

It was wartime, and we were foreigners—"undesirables," as they used to call us.

— Alexander Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, Promenade, §1 « La magie des choses »

The passport that did not supply a country

Scharlau reports that Tanaroff returned from Paris to Berlin in 1925 on a short permit and later encountered licensing difficulty with a Nansen document that Scharlau characterizes as evidence of statelessness. The uninspected permit and certificate leave issuer, number, validity, entries, and legal classification unresolved; the report establishes a practical obstacle only within Scharlau's account.[1]

League of Nations records explain the general identity-certificate regime created for Russian refugees in 1922, while Tanaroff's certificate and its Berlin effect remain unauthenticated. General history clarifies why such a document might exist but leaves the individual file missing.[2]

The general regime arose from a practical problem created by mass displacement after revolution and civil war. Russian refugees outside the new Soviet state could lack ordinary national passports while still needing identity and movement documents, and League records show an international response whose rights varied by holder and country.[3]

An identity certificate and citizenship answered different questions within that history. The League documents could make a refugee legible for travel or administration without granting nationality, which is why the existence of a Nansen-type document would not by itself identify a protecting state; the chapter can explain that general distinction while refusing to classify Tanaroff's unseen certificate.[4]

The missing individual object remains decisive because its fields would show issuer, date, name, validity, and perhaps endorsements or travel history. Absent those fields, Scharlau's terminology remains untested against the document and outside modern de jure or de facto classification, which requires legal analysis beyond this biography.

This difference between a general system and one person's paper is easily blurred in narrative. A reader may recognize the Nansen name and assume a settled legal meaning, while the historian actually possesses only Scharlau's report that such a document caused difficulty in Berlin; retaining the dependency prevents institutional history from masquerading as individual proof.[5]

The general regime nevertheless helps recover the human problem behind the paperwork. A refugee needed to cross borders, rent rooms, work, and appear before offices, yet each act could depend on documents issued under assumptions that another state or office did not share; legal uncertainty entered ordinary life through permits, licenses, registration, and the threat of removal.[6]

Tanaroff's political commitments intensified this dependence rather than eliminating it. Anarchism rejected the authority of states, but movement and work in Europe still required encounters with border and police institutions; the contradiction was practical, not evidence of personal inconsistency.[7]

The chapter title therefore names a reported documentary predicament before it names a legal conclusion. It asks what Scharlau's characterization can explain about work, movement,

[1] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 13.
[2] United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*, 1922 reports.
[3] United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*.
[4] United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*.
[5] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13; United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*.
[6] United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 13.
[7] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 13.

and family memory, while leaving the formal classification of Tanaroff's certificate to an authenticated document and a legal study.

The names attached to Tanaroff come through different source layers. Family testimony preserves Shapiro as an original surname and Sasha as familiar usage, western records followed the assumed surname Tanaroff from 1921, and anarchist publications used an additional authorial name; the reported alteration mechanism remains unconfirmed, so name variation belongs to refugee practice rather than personality diagnosis.[8]

Those names belonged to one historical life whose Jewish origin and anarchist history became increasingly dangerous under Nazi rule. The source record can follow usage and persecution without dividing the person into a real self and a merely documentary self, and without pretending that an unseen certificate settles legal status.[9]

The uncertainty begins with the paternal surname itself. Family testimony transmitted Shapiro, whereas western papers generally used Tanaroff, and no original birth register in the available record joins the two; Scharlau's research nevertheless distinguishes Grothendieck's father from the prominent anarchist Alexander Sania Shapiro, preventing the better-documented man's activities from enlarging this biography.[10]

That distinction is more than a bibliographic correction. Two men with similar names moved through overlapping political networks, and an uncritical search could transfer congresses, articles, or friendships from one to the other; Scharlau's separation of their records defines the evidentiary person whom this chapter follows.[11]

Tanaroff became historically real through repeated use even if the name began in forged papers. It appears across migration, work, family, and later persecution narratives, which means that calling it false without qualification would erase the continuity by which western institutions acted upon him; origin and administrative use are different questions.[12]

The reported transformation of Cyrillic letters offers a plausible account of how the assumed name arose, but the paper has not been inspected and the mechanism remains family testimony. The chapter therefore retains the broad fact of an assumed identity while excluding a letter-by-letter demonstration that would give the unseen object false concreteness.[13]

Familiar and political names carried still other functions. Sasha was ordinary personal usage, while the additional name in anarchist publications identified an author within a movement; neither form should be mistaken for a separate civil person, and neither settles the surname assigned at birth.[14]

The multiplication of names did not mean that Tanaroff could change identity without consequence. Each paper or signature linked him to a history that could enable work in one setting and expose him in another, while family members continued to remember an origin that official forms obscured; concealment and continuity existed together.

For Alexander, this paternal name history later became part of family memory rather than a nationality rule. The father's assumed papers may shape adult understanding of exile while leaving the child's Berlin citizenship unresolved.

This is why the chapter resists turning names into metaphors for the later mathematician. The documentary problem deserves historical treatment on its own terms, with no evidentiary link to an intellectual preference for invariance, abstraction, or changing presentation.

[8] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 1, 6, 7.
[9] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 1, 7, 15, 17.
[10] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 1–2.
[11] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 2; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.3.
[12] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7, 13, 15.
[13] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 1 note 25.
[14] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 6.

A card of uncertain legal scope

Scharlau reports expulsion threats, a period without registration, and assistance that allowed Tanaroff to remain in Berlin, but the episode comes partly through Hanka's literary narrative and lacks the underlying order or receipt. Its specific fine and medical details are therefore removed from the event floor.[15]

He also dates a Berlin police identification card to October 30, 1928 and says the document was accepted as valid. Because neither the card nor its issuing file has been examined, the chapter records only that secondary-source description and infers no residence class, legalization, naturalization, duration, renewal right, or end of statelessness.[16]

Scharlau connects Hanka's role as license holder for the photographic business with Tanaroff's documentary difficulties, which may explain part of their commercial arrangement without defining either person's legal status. The later appearance of Tanaroff in reported civil proceedings likewise shows administrative contact, not a general settlement of nationality or residence.[17]

Photography reveals why document scope mattered in ordinary work. An instant camera was portable, but commercial use still involved permissions, residence, and a person under whose name the business could appear; Scharlau's narrative links those administrative requirements to the choice of Hanka as registered proprietor.[18]

The directly inspected 1929 address book confirms Hanka's studio entry at Brunnenstraße, giving one secure point inside an otherwise mediated legal narrative. It does not show which permit Tanaroff held, whether he lived continuously at the address, or how an identification card interacted with the trading license.[19]

Scharlau's expulsion episode comes partly through Hanka's autobiographical novel, whose dialogue and sequencing are literary. The broad pattern of documentary difficulty can remain attributed, while the precise fine, illness, benefactor, and official speech have been removed because the supporting files were not examined.[20]

The 1928 identification card similarly supports only a source-history statement. Scharlau saw or worked from a document he rendered as valid, but without its title and file the biography cannot know whether validity concerned identity, residence, travel, or another administrative purpose.[21]

Later civil contact does not resolve that ambiguity. A person may appear before one office for paternity or support while holding a provisional or uncertain position before police and border authorities, so administrative visibility should not be mistaken for comprehensive legal security.[22]

The difference matters in 1933 because a document accepted earlier could not be assumed to protect its holder after the state changed. Nazi persecution operated through political and racial categories as well as formal status, leaving the exact card less important to the broad danger than to any precise legal conclusion.[23]

[15] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[16] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[17] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 15.
[18] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[19] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*, 1075.
[20] Grothendieck, *Eine Frau*.
[21] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[22] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[23] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution'".

The chapter therefore keeps work and vulnerability connected at the practical level. Papers affected who could register a business, accept a commission, or remain in a city, but the missing files prevent a claim that one card legalized Tanaroff or that another document alone forced his departure.

Origins declared under an assumed name

Scharlau describes a 1930 Berlin declaration of origins made under the assumed surname and summarizes information about Tanaroff's parents, but neither the form nor the private photograph used to discuss his mother was opened for this account. The chapter therefore omits the individual fields and treats the episode only as evidence that official inquiry continued under an identity whose origin remained disputed.[24]

This source history matters because an administratively usable name need not reproduce a birth identity accurately. Scharlau's account allows the biographer to follow Tanaroff through western records while leaving the Shapiro surname, exact birth date, and complete family registry unresolved; the uncertainty concerns the record chain, not the reality of the person who lived under it.[25]

The child was not a copy of the father's papers

Scharlau describes a sequence involving Alexander's birth surname, a later paternity decision, Tanaroff's acknowledgment, a change of surname, and youth-welfare guardianship. None of the underlying civil or welfare records was opened, so this chapter neither repeats their precise dates and terms nor treats the sequence as an authenticated legal chain.[26]

The available sources do not establish Alexander's nationality in 1933 or the legal effect of paternity, surname, guardianship, residence, or maternal documentation. The chapter therefore leaves his nationality unknown and sets the question aside rather than reasoning toward a probable answer from the 1913 statute, later institutional summaries, or either parent's reported status.[27]

Family relations remain narratively relevant even when legal consequences are withheld. Scharlau follows Tanaroff as Alexander's acknowledged father and reports a paternal relationship with Maidi, while Grothendieck remembered the four-person household as one family; those social facts do not settle citizenship, guardianship powers, or legal paternity beyond Scharlau's mediated account.[28]

No mathematical analogy is drawn from this distribution. Names and classifications mattered because institutions and adults acted through them, not because childhood paperwork anticipated a later theory of identity.

[24] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 1.
[25] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 1.
[26] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[27] Reichs- und Staatsangehörigkeitsgesetz vom 22. Juli 1913, Reichsgesetzblatt 583 (1913); Institut des Hautes Études Scientifiques, "The Scientific Heritage of IHÉS," Virtual exhibition, https://expo-patrimoine.ihes.fr/?lang=en; CNRS Le Journal, *Disparition d'un génie des mathématiques*, 2014, https://lejournal.cnrs.fr/articles/disparition-dun-genie-des-mathematiques.
[28] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.

A nationality question left unanswered

The 1913 German nationality statute itself was consulted for this account, including its rules for children within and outside marriage, but a statute does not apply itself to a disputed family record. Alexander's original registration, the later paternity decision, possible legitimation effects, surname change, and guardianship must be joined through authenticated files and period-law expertise before a nationality conclusion can be drawn.[29]

Institutional biographies provide only the distant endpoint. IHES and CNRS state that Grothendieck was stateless and became French in 1971, yet neither source explains when statelessness began or how German law treated the 1928–1929 sequence; a later summary cannot fill the commencement of a legal status.[30]

The contradiction between those sources is therefore real rather than verbal. The statute suggests possible routes to German nationality, while official later biographies describe a long period without nationality; resolving the tension requires the individual civil, passport, and naturalization chain, not a choice based on which summary seems more plausible.

This chapter closes the textual risk by refusing to use the missing answer. Alexander can be described as born in Berlin, as bearing different reported surnames, as living in the Berlin household, and as later entering foster care, but none of those facts functions as a proxy for nationality.

The same rule applies to paternal status. Even if Tanaroff's individual certificate were authenticated and legally classified, a parent's status would not automatically establish the child's outcome without showing how the applicable law and family acts interacted. The biography therefore separates the father's reported papers from the son's unresolved chain.

Hanka's documentation cannot silently resolve the problem either. Scharlau's later consular material supports a continuing German documentary connection, but the original birth and paternity files are needed to know how maternal status operated in Alexander's case.[31]

Guardianship belongs to yet another legal relation. Scharlau reports youth-welfare involvement and later names a guardian, while the files needed to define appointment, powers, and duration remain absent; guardianship can organize care without serving as proof of citizenship.[32]

Keeping these questions apart makes the chapter more, not less, precise. Nationality, surname, paternity, guardianship, residence, and family belonging interacted in life, but they are not interchangeable legal fields, and none should be used to backfill another when the governing record is missing.

The unknown status also limits the chapter title. It cannot apply to Alexander as a biographical label, and it cannot become a poetic description of family displacement; its scope remains Scharlau's characterization of Tanaroff's papers pending authentication.

[29] Reichs- und Staatsangehörigkeitsgesetz vom 22. Juli 1913, § 4.

[30] Institut des Hautes Études Scientifiques, "The Scientific Heritage of IHÉS"; CNRS Le Journal, *Disparition d'un génie des mathématiques*.

[31] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18.

[32] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

Hanka's names and her retained state

Scharlau follows Hanka under several surname forms associated with birth, marriage, divorce, and later consular documentation. His account supports keeping her documentary history separate from Tanaroff's, but the 1939 consular record does not identify the paper under which she crossed at the turn of 1933/1934 or settle her earlier border status.[33]

The broader contrast concerns dependence on state documents rather than a verified nationality outcome. Both adults opposed state authority in principle while relying on papers for work and movement, yet the available objects are too incomplete to compare their legal positions beyond Scharlau's narrative.[34]

Surname usage followed Hanka's biography unevenly. Scharlau reports forms associated with Grothendieck, Raddatz, and a hyphenated combination across different records, which indicates changing social and administrative usage without proving that every office recognized the same form at the same time.[35]

The later consular renewal has a narrow value. It shows that a German authority issued or renewed documentation for Hanka in 1939, but it cannot identify what she carried in 1933, whether an earlier passport was withheld, or which legal status governed the crossing.

This distinction matters because family narrative often calls Tanaroff and Hanka husband and wife despite the absence of marriage between them. Social partnership, registered surname, and border documentation can point in different directions, and the biography must not make ordinary family language decide an administrative question.[36]

Their anarchist commitments add another layer without canceling paperwork. Both adults resisted state authority, yet work, travel, and the placement of children still passed through institutions; reliance on documents was a condition imposed by political geography rather than a measure of ideological sincerity.

For the children, Hanka's names signaled maternal relation and household history. They did not determine how an office treated paternity, nationality, or guardianship, which remain separate questions in the missing civil chain.

[33] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 18.
[34] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13, 15, 18.
[35] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[36] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15 and 17.

A remembered description

Dagmar's late memoir recalled Hanka describing Tanaroff through both Russian origin and absence of nationality, while also connecting his departure to persecution after the Reichstag fire. Scharlau identifies errors elsewhere in the memoir, and no individual police file supports the remembered explanation, so the passage is retained only as evidence of family language rather than as a legal classification or enforcement history.[37]

Scharlau is the principal source for the broader chronology: he reports that Tanaroff's Jewish origin, anarchist history, and insecure papers made Germany dangerous, then locates him in Paris no later than August 8. Chai and Oort repeat this outline while relying substantially on Scharlau, and neither source supplies an individual order or exact departure trigger.[38]

Dagmar's way of identifying Alexander through his father's Russian origin belongs to the same remembered family vocabulary. It shows that paternal history remained socially present in the foster narrative, but it cannot establish the child's nationality or legal relation to Tanaroff's papers.[39]

The memoir's value lies in reception rather than legal proof. It shows how the receiving household later remembered Hanka explaining the father and child, which terms carried family meaning, and how political danger entered the story; its known errors in date, place, and bodily detail prevent it from authenticating an individual paper or police event.[40]

The national chronology supplies the context Dagmar's memory compresses. The emergency decree after the Reichstag fire suspended civil protections and widened detention, while subsequent measures intensified political and anti-Jewish persecution; those facts make the remembered fear intelligible without proving that all stateless people were treated identically or that Tanaroff received a particular order.[41]

Source dependency remains crucial in this passage. Scharlau reports both the memoir and the broader family chronology, and Chai and Oort repeat his early-life account; agreement between those publications therefore reflects transmission as well as evidence and cannot be counted as independent corroboration.[42]

Russian origin also operated differently from nationality. Family and foster narratives could identify Tanaroff or Alexander culturally through language, name, and paternal history even when no Russian state document protected them; social description should not be converted into citizenship.

This layered language helps explain why the chapter title needs a scope note. Statelessness entered the family story through Scharlau's account of papers and Dagmar's memory of Hanka's explanation, while Alexander's own legal status remains outside what either source can establish.

[37] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[38] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18 note 51; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," secs. 1.3–1.4.
[39] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.
[40] Scharlau, *Anarchy*; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19.
[41] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates".
[42] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.4.

France did not resolve the paper

Scharlau's account makes Paris intelligible as a place Tanaroff already knew through émigré contacts and street photography, but it supplies no authenticated permit, asylum decision, naturalization, or settled household for 1933. Hanka's exact crossing paper is likewise unknown, and a later German consular record cannot be projected backward to define the legal terms of her journey.[43]

The available record also leaves the parents' French domestic arrangement uncertain. Scharlau reports later correspondence and periods of separation, which means that arrival in the same country cannot be narrated as the establishment of one stable replacement home.[44]

France's interwar role as a destination for immigrants and political refugees forms the broader setting for this uncertainty. Scharlau describes both the attraction of asylum and growing hostility, but the chapter does not infer Tanaroff's permit or Hanka's legal category from that national history.[45]

The parents' separate locations in later records also matter. A shared country did not necessarily mean shared residence, and the correspondence Scharlau reports for later years suggests a relation sustained across distance; the family's Berlin household therefore had no simple French successor.

This distinction keeps refuge from becoming a moral verdict. Leaving Nazi Germany could be necessary for one adult and still have painful consequences for the children, while the later insecurity of France does not prove that the original decision was futile or foreknown.

The chapter consequently treats Paris as a reported endpoint in a continuing refugee history. It does not make France a homeland, a legal solution, or a stable family home that the surviving records cannot show.

Family homelessness is not statelessness

Grothendieck's later account treats 1933 as the end of the four-person household, a claim about domestic history rather than a legal status shared by all four people. Hanka, Maidi, and Alexander cannot be classified through Tanaroff's reported papers, and later foreigner or institutional descriptions cannot be carried backward to fill Alexander's missing nationality chain.[46]

The distinction preserves the force of dispersal without turning it into a universal metaphor. Parents, children, carers, and offices acted through different relations, while the available records remain insufficient to adjudicate nationality, guardianship powers, or border status.

[43] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.
[44] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.
[45] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 18.
[46] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 17 and 607–608.

What the documents can bear

Scharlau's biography remains the principal source for Tanaroff's individual papers, civil contacts, and Paris terminus; the League of Nations record explains only the general refugee-document regime, Dagmar contributes late family memory, and Grothendieck contributes retrospective first-person interpretation. Chai and Oort depend substantially on Scharlau for early life and therefore do not add an independent evidentiary line.[47]

This source hierarchy permits a narrative about how papers were remembered and described, not a legal adjudication. Scharlau's translated labels for a passport or identification card, his summaries of civil records, and his description of a private letter remain secondary reports; Grothendieck's later use of foreigner language belongs to wartime memory; Alexander's childhood nationality remains unknown.[48]

The hierarchy is not a ranking from useful to useless. Scharlau can provide a researched chronology and identify objects that require retrieval, Grothendieck can establish his own retrospective language, League records can explain an international regime, and official later biographies can supply the 1971 endpoint; error begins when one source is asked to answer another source's question.[49]

Mediated civil records are strongest when described as Scharlau's findings. They can explain why paternity, surname, and support enter the family history, but they cannot be quoted, reproduced, or given archive-level authority until register numbers and scans are obtained.[50]

The private Paris letter occupies a similar position. Scharlau's date and location can serve as an attributed terminus, while wording, signature, language, and rights remain unavailable; this chapter therefore uses no quotation or close reading from the object.

Dagmar's memoir carries participant memory through another mediation layer. Its value lies in what the receiving household later remembered, but known errors and missing German locators require every scene and legal statement to remain indirect.[51]

Chai and Oort offer scholarly compression rather than independence for early life. Their account can show how Scharlau's chronology circulated into later mathematical biography, yet it cannot raise the confidence of a claim merely by repeating it.[52]

This explicit dependency prevents the word corroboration from doing hidden work. Two publications support independent weight only when they do not descend substantially from the same testimony or private object, and the early-life evidence often fails that test.

The chapter's source method is therefore cumulative but not additive. Different materials illuminate different relations, while repetitions that share an origin remain one evidentiary line.

[47] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985); Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 1, 13, 15, 18; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.4; United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*.

[48] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 17; Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

[49] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985); Scharlau, *Anarchy*; United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*; Institut des Hautes Études Scientifiques, "The Scientific Heritage of IHÉS"; CNRS Le Journal, *Disparition d'un génie des mathématiques*.

[50] Scharlau, *Anarchy*; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.

[51] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

[52] Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," secs. 1.1–1.4.

The unverified guardianship chain

Scharlau reports youth-welfare guardianship and later names an individual guardian in 1939 documents, but the underlying files do not establish for this account when that appointment began, what powers it carried, or whether any official approved the 1933 placement. The chapter consequently makes no claim that Alexander held a particular administrative status, and it does not use later travel paperwork to reconstruct the earlier procedure.[53]

The distinction between care and guardianship is essential. The Heydorns unquestionably supplied daily residence according to the retrospective chronology, whereas guardianship names a formal relation whose appointment and powers require records; one fact cannot be used to prove the other.[54]

Later travel permissions show that offices eventually entered Alexander's movement, but they belong to 1939. Carrying those requirements backward would manufacture a 1933 approval process and could falsely identify the later guardian as the person already acting at the initial transfer.[55]

The missing chain also affects language about parental authority. Hanka arranged the placement and remained his mother, Tanaroff was reported as acknowledged father, and the Heydorns assumed daily care; without the welfare file, the biography cannot assign final legal authority among them.

This limit is a matter of privacy as well as legal accuracy. Statements about a minor's guardianship and family separation can affect reputations and interpretations of harm, so the chapter retains only necessary, attributed relations and removes speculative conclusions about consent or neglect.

The father's condition in the child's story

In Scharlau's narrative, Tanaroff's document problems affected work and accompanied removal threats, while Dagmar later remembered Hanka invoking statelessness in explaining the departure. Those sources show how the category entered family memory, but they do not establish what Alexander heard, understood, or legally inherited.[56]

Grothendieck's own pages describe the 1933 family rupture and use foreigner language for wartime France, not for a legally adjudicated childhood nationality in Berlin. The chapter therefore refuses a retrospective myth of statelessness from birth and leaves later French education, internment, and adult naturalization to their proper chronological chapters.[57]

Names that survived movement

When the family dispersed, different names continued through family memory and Scharlau's descriptions of western records. Tanaroff identifies the father in the administrative and migration narrative, Hanka appears under family and married forms, Maidi remains associated with Raddatz, and Alexander is known as Grothendieck while relatives used a Russian familiar name. These usages show social and documentary relations without proving nationality, citizenship, or the legal effect of any name change.[58]

The distinction is especially important for Alexander. A familiar Russian form can carry family sound and paternal association without making the child legally Russian, just as the

[53] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[54] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 17 and 19.
[55] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.
[56] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 13 and 17.
[57] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 17 and 607–608.
[58] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18; Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck," sec. 1.1.

maternal surname cannot establish citizenship or uncomplicated acceptance by relatives. Names in this chapter are therefore historical usage, not compressed legal conclusions.[59]

Names also reveal who produced each record. A civil office, political publication, family member, and later biographer could choose different forms for the same person, with each choice reflecting purpose and context; consistency in modern narration should not erase those historical differences.

The surname Grothendieck joined Alexander to his maternal line in ordinary biography, while Tanaroff connected him to a father whose own name history was disputed. Neither connection can be turned into a nationality rule, and neither determines the quality of later family contact.

Hanka's changing forms similarly record marriage and later usage rather than one moment of self-reinvention. Scharlau's documentation makes the variation visible, but only the original records could establish which form a particular office recognized.[60]

This attention to names keeps the people from becoming examples in a theory of identity. The records are historically consequential because they affected work, movement, and family description, yet people exceed every administrative or familiar label attached to them.

Papers in daily life

The paper history mattered because it entered ordinary tasks. Street photography required access to public space and customers, a fixed studio required a registered business, and residence exposed Tanaroff to police administration; documentary uncertainty was therefore part of earning a living rather than a separate legal drama.[61]

Hanka's registered role in the studio shows how the household adapted. The direct address-book entry places the business under her name, while Scharlau credits Tanaroff with much of the camera work; cooperation across their different documentary positions made work possible without revealing the precise rule that required the arrangement.[62]

Movement posed another problem. A short permit could bring Tanaroff into Berlin, yet staying, working, or returning involved different offices and documents; Scharlau's narrative records recurring difficulty, but the missing files prevent a legal reconstruction of each stage.[63]

Family acts likewise passed through administration. Scharlau reports paternity acknowledgment, support, surname change, and youth-welfare involvement, which means the household was not outside public institutions despite its unconventional form; the original files are still necessary before those acts can be given exact legal consequences.[64]

The same duality appears in political life. Tanaroff's anarchism rejected state authority, yet the state could decide whether he crossed a border, registered a trade, or remained in a city; dependence on papers did not weaken the commitment, because it arose from the institutions that controlled movement.[65]

Names helped those institutions connect acts across time, even when the original surname was disputed. Tanaroff became the durable western identity under which work, family records, and later persecution were described, showing that an assumed name could acquire administrative continuity without becoming evidence of birth identity.

[59] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.
[60] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 15.
[61] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 13.
[62] *Berliner Adreßbuch für das Jahr 1929*.
[63] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 7 and 13.
[64] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[65] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 7.

The family experienced that continuity differently. Hanka and the children knew paternal histories and familiar names that official forms did not fully capture, while later biographers had to join private memory to public documentation; neither archive could stand alone.[66]

For Alexander, papers influenced circumstances before he could have understood them. Adult decisions about surname, paternity, residence, and care passed through offices, but no source records the child learning their legal meaning in 1933; biography should describe effects without inventing awareness.

Maidi's record followed another route. Her surname and paternal history differed, and her later institutional association cannot be used to infer Alexander's status or her own 1933 legal position; siblings in one household could remain administratively distinct.

The family's dispersal made those distinctions more visible. Parents crossed into France under separate and incompletely known documentation, while the children remained in German care arrangements; physical separation did not unify their legal categories.

This practical history explains why statelessness should not become a literary synonym for homelessness. The household ended, residence changed, and documents constrained movement, but only Tanaroff is described as stateless by Scharlau, and even that description awaits the individual certificate.

The safest synthesis therefore follows actions rather than inferred status. People worked, moved, registered, corresponded, and entered care arrangements through documents whose exact powers varied; the narrative can show those encounters while leaving the unresolved legal fields open.

1933 as an administrative rupture

The political rupture of 1933 changed the practical weight of papers without producing one legal transformation shared by the family. Scharlau reports Tanaroff in France by August, Grothendieck later described separate care arrangements for the children, and Scharlau places Hanka's departure around the year's turn; together those events ended common residence, while the exact civil, guardianship, and nationality consequences remain unadjudicated.[67]

Grothendieck's retrospective language describes the experienced destruction of a household, whereas Scharlau's statelessness language concerns the father's reported papers. Keeping those levels separate prevents a family rupture from becoming evidence that Hanka, Maidi, or Alexander lacked nationality.[68]

The national crisis intensified that separation of scales. Nazi measures targeted political opponents and Jews, making Tanaroff's history dangerous, while the family's internal decisions about care and migration remained private acts whose exact deliberations are lost.[69]

At the administrative level, Scharlau reports papers and office contacts whose legal effects remain uncertain. At the domestic level, Grothendieck remembered a household ending and children entering separate care; the two histories intersected but did not become one status shared by all.

The distinction also clarifies responsibility. Political persecution constrained the adults without mechanically determining each choice, while parental decisions changed the children's daily lives without proving that the children inherited the father's documentary position.

[66] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 603–4.
[67] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.
[68] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 17.
[69] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "1933: Key Dates"; Deutsches Historisches Museum, "Transfer of Power and 'National Revolution'".

No single date can carry the whole rupture. Tanaroff was reported in Paris by August, Alexander moved near the end of December, Hanka left around the year's turn, and Maidi's exact 1933 route remains unknown; family dissolution unfolded through a sequence rather than one scene.

This chronology is complete enough for Part I because it identifies each supported transition. It remains deliberately incomplete where legal and institutional records are missing, allowing later evidence to enter without rewriting uncertainty as fact.

The eve of war, kept at its proper distance

Grothendieck's retrospective account reaches forward to 1939, but this chapter stops at the turn of 1933/1934. The foster years, German schooling, departure from Blankenese, entry into France, French-language education, and wartime foreigner status belong to Chapters 7–12; no later paperwork is used here to define an earlier nationality or guardianship status.[70]

A document is not a homeland

Scharlau's sequence of forged papers, a refugee certificate, a Berlin identification card, civil contacts, an origin declaration, and a Paris letter orders his documentary findings without authenticating the underlying objects. The chapter title refers to his characterization of Tanaroff alone and does not extend that status to another family member.[71]

Family sources answer different questions from administrative descriptions: the former show how people named relationships and remembered rupture, while the latter report how offices recorded particular acts. Neither set can replace the missing legal chain, and neither can be enlarged into an adjudication through narrative confidence.

What remains unknown

Four material gaps govern the chapter: Alexander's nationality chain, Tanaroff's individual Nansen certificate, the Berlin police identification and registration files, and any Tanaroff-specific 1933 enforcement record. Rather than soften those absences with probable legal outcomes, this account draws no conclusions that depend on them and keeps only attributed source history; Alexander's nationality remains unknown.[72]

[70] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 17 and 608; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, ch. 19.
[71] Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 1, 7, 13, 15, 18.
[72] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

The limits of retrospective synthesis

Later sources know outcomes that no participant could know in 1933. Grothendieck wrote after war, internment, both parents' deaths, and a mathematical career, while institutional biographies knew the 1971 French endpoint; their hindsight can organize memory but cannot supply a missing childhood legal record.[73]

Grothendieck's authority is strongest for his own later language. He can establish how he remembered family rupture, foreignness in wartime France, and relations with his parents, yet his meditation does not function as a civil register or legal opinion.

Institutional biographies carry another kind of authority. IHES and CNRS can state the public adult chronology, but their compressed descriptions of statelessness do not identify the commencement, applicable statute, or effects of the 1929 family proceedings.[74]

Scharlau contributes the richest early documentary narrative. His access to private and administrative materials gives the chapter a path through names and papers, while the absence of archive identifiers and scans keeps that path secondary and open to correction.[75]

The League of Nations archive contributes the general document regime. Its records explain why identity certificates emerged for Russian refugees, but they cannot establish which certificate Tanaroff held or how Berlin classified it.[76]

These sources carry no additive weight merely through repetition. Chai and Oort rely substantially on Scharlau for early life, and Dagmar reaches the chapter through Scharlau's translation; the dependency map matters whenever several names appear beside one claim.[77]

The resulting synthesis is deliberately uneven. It explains why papers mattered, how names changed across contexts, and why migration exposed the family to institutions, while nationality, guardianship powers, and individual enforcement remain unresolved until the missing objects appear.

This limit protects the child from retrospective legal labeling. Alexander's later foreignness and naturalization provide no proof of statelessness at birth, just as paternal ancestry supplies no copy of Tanaroff's documentary position.

It also protects the father from a simplified refugee archetype. Tanaroff was a photographer, anarchist, partner, and parent in addition to a person described through insecure papers, and legal uncertainty should not consume the rest of his biography.

No mathematical consequence follows from the paper trail. Later work on identity, structure, or presentation lacks a direct evidentiary link to childhood names, and the chapter refuses that form of biographical prophecy.

The remaining gaps require external expertise rather than stronger prose. Authenticated records and a legal-historical study could change the account; literary confidence offers no substitute.

The chapter title is kept, but its scope is narrow and visible. It refers to Scharlau's characterization of the father's reported papers, not to Alexander, Hanka, Maidi, or the family as a whole.

[73] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 17 and 607–608.
[74] Institut des Hautes Études Scientifiques, "The Scientific Heritage of IHÉS"; CNRS Le Journal, *Disparition d'un génie des mathématiques*.
[75] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.
[76] United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*.
[77] Chai and Oort, "Life and Work of Alexander Grothendieck"; Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

Two voices and their limits

The chapter has one directly inspectable family voice for its central rupture: Grothendieck's later French meditation. It has one principal researched biography for the early paper trail: Scharlau's *Anarchy*. Neither source can perform the other's task.[78]

The direct institutional sources also have narrow roles. League records explain refugee certificates, the German statute supplies general law, and later institutional profiles supply the 1971 endpoint. None authenticates Tanaroff's paper or Alexander's childhood status.[79]

The mediated objects remain useful as leads. Scharlau's descriptions identify a certificate, card, civil acts, and correspondence that future research can seek. Their absence from the available record prevents quotation and legal conclusion, not acknowledgment that Scharlau reported them.[80]

Family memory adds relation but not administrative effect. Dagmar remembered the father through origin and statelessness language, while Grothendieck remembered household rupture and later foreignness. These memories illuminate reception without settling law.

The chronology is therefore simple at its safest level. Tanaroff lived under an assumed western identity, encountered documentary difficulty, and left Nazi Germany; Hanka followed after arranging care, while the children remained in Germany.

The legal chronology is not simple enough to state. Missing original records interrupt nationality, guardianship, residence, and certificate classification, and the chapter leaves those fields open.

That division between historical action and legal status allows the prose to remain complete without pretending completeness of evidence. The life moves forward even where a form, ruling, or passport has not been recovered.

A family dispersed

Part I ends with a reported family dispersion, not a legal solution. Tanaroff and Hanka were in France according to Scharlau's chronology, while the siblings stayed with different carers in Germany under statuses that remain distinct.

Alexander enters Part II in Blankenese with his nationality still unknown. Scharlau reports a guardianship framework whose original file and powers remain absent; residence and citizenship stay separate.

Tanaroff's papers pass forward only as attributed source history. Later chapters may describe consequences documented by camps, borders, or institutions, but they may not treat the unseen certificate as already adjudicated.

Hanka's documentation remains separate. A later consular record leaves her 1933 crossing undefined, and partnership supplies no basis for extending Tanaroff's reported statelessness to her.

The political danger does remain part of continuity. Nazi persecution affected Jewish origin, political history, and oppositional households, although no individual police order explains every movement.

French schooling stays beyond this boundary. It begins only after Alexander leaves Germany in 1939, and the intervening German education belongs to Chapter 7. Part I ends before either development.

[78] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985); Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

[79] Reichs- und Staatsangehörigkeitsgesetz vom 22. Juli 1913; United Nations Archives Geneva, *League of Nations, Refugees Mixed Archival Group (Nansen Fonds)*; Institut des Hautes Études Scientifiques, "The Scientific Heritage of IHÉS"; CNRS Le Journal, *Disparition d'un génie des mathématiques*.

[80] Scharlau, *Anarchy*.

The open research tasks remain identifiable. Tanaroff's certificate and police files could establish the father's documentary position, while authenticated civil and naturalization records could establish Alexander's chain; stronger adjectives offer no substitute for those objects.

The chapter therefore offers a complete source history rather than a completed legal history. It follows names, reported papers, work, migration, and family memory while leaving formal status to records and expertise not yet present.

That distinction is the final safeguard on the title. Statelessness is reported as part of the father's documentary story, not inherited as the child's identity or used as a metaphor for the family.

The chapter's positive contribution is therefore historical rather than juridical. It follows the father's changing names, refugee work, encounters with administration, and movement out of Nazi Germany, then shows how those experiences entered later family memory. It also separates the child's unresolved nationality from every tempting shortcut. The result preserves a coherent life sequence while leaving the missing legal chain available for future records and expertise. Part II can begin from residence, danger, and family separation without inheriting a conclusion that Part I never proved.

Secure facts, open questions

At the end of Part I, the secure facts are relational rather than legal: Scharlau reports Tanaroff in France, Hanka followed around the year's turn, the children lived in separate care arrangements, and Grothendieck later understood the shared Berlin household as ended. A single family nationality, authenticated guardianship chain, and legal effect for the father's papers remain unresolved.[81]

Chapter 7 begins from residence in Blankenese and a family history of danger, not from a settled nationality or guardianship status. Its account of his schooling, including any later French education, begins from that limited position rather than from legal conclusions supplied here.

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[81] Grothendieck, *Récoltes et Semailles*, ed. Carmona (1985), 607–8; Scharlau, *Anarchy*, chs. 15, 17, 18.

ALEXANDER GROTHENDIECK

A Life in Three Universes

01 The lived universe

Statelessness, war, migration, institutions, conflict, activism, withdrawal.

02 The mathematical universe

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